

PAGE 6

NATION

PM Modi must order filing of FIR: Rahul on Kharge purification row



PAGE 9

GLOBAL

FM Sitharaman invites global investors to build manufacturing and tech hubs in India



PAGE 11

SPORTS

India begin Women's Asia Cup T20 campaign against Thailand



AGENDA



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Nepal floods kill 669 as rescue crews battle rain

More than 11,000 security personnel have joined the search as authorities race to reach isolated communities



(Left) An aerial view of damaged structures covered in thick mud and debris in the aftermath of flash floods, at Devighat, in Nuwakot district, Nepal, Saturday; (Right) Family members look at posters displaying details of people who died in the floods, outside a hospital mortuary, in Kathmandu, Nepal, Saturday



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ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

The death toll from devastating flash floods in Nepal climbed to 669 on Saturday, as rescue teams continued searching across the affected areas for survivors and missing people. More than 2,400 people are still unaccounted for, according to Nepal Police.

Authorities said bodies have now been recovered from all eight districts hit by the disaster. Rescue and recovery operations have been intensified, with thousands of security personnel deployed across "the region."

The floods were triggered by an avalanche linked to a glacial collapse near the

Nepal-Tibet border, which unleashed a massive surge of water, mud and debris. The torrent swept through communities in central Nepal, destroying homes and villages, damaging vital infrastructure and severely affecting hydropower facilities.

According to Nepal Police, 248 bodies were recovered in Chitawan, the highest

number among the affected districts. Nawalparasi East recorded 158 deaths, followed by Nawalparasi West with 75 and Gorkha with 54. Authorities reported 49 bodies in Dhading, 41 in Nuwakot, 31 in Tanahu and 13 in Rasuwa.

The scale of the disaster has prompted a large-scale emergency response. Nearly

2,500 people, including 163 foreign nationals, have been evacuated from flood-hit areas as rescue crews work despite intermittent rainfall.

More than 11,000 security personnel have been mobilised for search and rescue operations, including over 5,000 members of the Nepal Army.

Officials and rescue workers remain focused on locating those still missing and reaching communities cut off by the destruction. With difficult weather conditions continuing, authorities are racing to complete search operations and provide assistance to people affected by the floods.

Nepal opens doors to international aid

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Nepal has agreed to accept specialised international search-and-rescue assistance in areas devastated by flash floods, reversing its earlier decision to rely exclusively on domestic rescue agencies.

Teams and technical support from India, China, Australia and South Korea will be allowed to assist ongoing operations, particularly in areas requiring specialist capabilities such as tunnel rescue, medical support, DNA analysis and forensic identification.

The decision was approved by an inter-ministerial coordination committee following an assessment by Nepal's National Disaster Management Centre. The change came as the scale of the disaster became clearer and pressure grew from countries seeking help in locating their nationals who remain missing.

The floods caused widespread destruction along the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli river systems, sweeping away roads, bridges, buildings and other critical infrastructure.

Nepal's authorities have

THE CHANGE CAME AS THE SCALE OF THE DISASTER BECAME CLEAR AND PRESSURE GREW FROM COUNTRIES SEEKING TO LOCATE THEIR NATIONALS

reported a sharp rise in the number of people still missing. Foreign nationals account for a significant share of those unaccounted for, with Indian citizens representing the largest group, followed by nationals from the United States, Ukraine, Australia and the United Kingdom.

The disaster followed a glacier-related collapse that released a powerful mixture of water, ice, rocks, mud and debris into Himalayan river channels. At least 579 people have been reported dead in Nepal, while seven deaths have been recorded in China's Tibet region.

India has offered a range of resources, including a tunnel-rescue unit, medical personnel and members of the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF).

PIONEER IN SHORT

HELMET RULE HITS LATUR POLICE

Maharashtra's Latur police have taken action against 58 police personnel, including officers, for riding two-wheelers without helmets, ahead of the district-wide enforcement of mandatory helmet use from September 1.

Superintendent of Police Amol Tambe has directed that police personnel must not be exempted from helmet rules, stressing that those enforcing the law must first follow it themselves. "Compliance must begin with us," Tambe said. The traffic branch has been instructed to penalise officers and personnel arriving at police stations on two-wheelers without helmets. The action applies across all 23 police stations in the district. In a significant move, details of helmet violations will also be entered in the offenders' service books. Personnel found violating the rule will face the applicable penalty as well as disciplinary action. The police said the initiative is intended to set an example for the public and promote responsible road behaviour as authorities prepare for stricter helmet enforcement from September 1. Motorists have been urged to make helmet use a habit rather than wait for enforcement.

US revives plan to end work permits for some H-4 spouses

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

H-1B visa holders' spouses could face renewed uncertainty over their ability to work in the United States after the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) revived a proposal that could end employment authorisation for certain H-4 visa holders.

The proposal targets the H-4 Employment Authorisation Document (EAD), which has allowed eligible spouses of H-1B workers to legally work in the US



AP

since 2015. However, the Government has not cancelled the programme, and there is no immediate change for H-4 spouses who currently hold valid work permits.

NDA ALLIES DIVIDED OVER SC SUBQUOTA

Union ministers Chirag Paswan and Jitan Ram Manjhi on Saturday clashed over a proposed sub-category within the Scheduled Caste quota for the most deprived Dalit communities, with Paswan calling the move divisive and Manjhi arguing it would enable targeted welfare. Paswan, chief of the Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas), said a sub-quota would "create a schism within the community". He also asked supporters of the proposal to back the concept of a creamy layer and give up their posts. His position echoes that of his late father, Ram Vilas Paswan, who opposed the "Mahadalit" category introduced in Bihar during Nitish Kumar's tenure. Manjhi, who belongs to the Musahar community, rejected Paswan's argument, saying more vulnerable Dalit castes needed targeted welfare. His son, Bihar minister Santosh Kumar Suman, also defended a "quota within quota", saying communities such as Musahar, Bhuia, Nat and Dom faced discrimination even within the SC category.

Pilgrims stranded in Tibet head to Nepal

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

A large number of Indian pilgrims stranded in Tibet began returning to Nepal on Saturday through an alternate border point after massive flash floods destroyed the Gyirong border post.

The Gyirong-Nepal border post is the main entry and exit point for Tibet through Nepal. Hundreds of foreign tourists, most of them pilgrims taking part in Kailash Manasarovar Yatra, were stranded after the post was



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destroyed in Wednesday's devastating flash floods, which have killed over 600 people.

Stranded pilgrims, including several Indians, began crossing into Nepal through the Zhangmu border point,

which was closed earlier due to earthquakes and landslides in the region.

Former Chairman of Defence Research and Development Organisation G Sateesh Reddy was among the Indian pilgrims who returned to the Nepal border on Saturday through Zhangmu. Talking to PTI here while travelling to the border point, Reddy said, "I can see a lot of buses and vehicles travelling en route to Nepal through Zhangmu border point."

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Red Fort blast: Court accepts NIA's 7,500-page chargesheet

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH ■ New Delhi

A special court of the National Investigation Agency (NIA) has accepted the 7,500-page chargesheet in connection with the explosion near the Red Fort on November 10, 2025, which resulted in 11 deaths, left many others injured and ripped through one of the Capital's most guarded historic precincts. The first chargesheet was filed on May 14, and another on June 27. The main suspect, Dr Umer Un Nabi, died in the explosion and the case against him will be dropped, as he is dead and there is no evidence left.

Special Judge Prashant Sharma has set the next hearing for September 9 and directed the NIA to provide the accused with copies of the complaint. Nine of the accused appeared by video link while in custody. The accused named in the com-



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plaint are Amir Rashid Mir, Jasir Bilal Wani, Dr Muzamil Shakeel, Dr Adeel Ahmed Rather, Dr Shaheen Saeed, Mufti Irfan Ahmad Wagay, Soyab, Dr Bilal Naseer Malla, and Yasir Ahmad Dar.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

BJP summons, reprimands MPs over Sajjan Kumar house visit

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

Three BJP MPs have landed themselves in trouble with the party top leadership after their visit to late Congress leader Sajjan Kumar house to pay condolences. Kumar was convicted in a 1984 anti-Sikh riots case. This didn't go down well with the party top brass as it had questioned Congress leaders visiting Kumar house.

After a backlash, BJP national president Nitin Nabin on Saturday summoned three of its MPs — Ramvir Singh Bidhuri, Yogender Chandolia and Kamaljeet Sehrawat - from



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Delhi and reprimanded them. The visit sparked criticism, particularly from BJP

leader HS Phoolka, who joined the party in April this year. The BJP has been at the forefront of seeking justice for the victims of the 1984 Sikh pogrom that took place in the aftermath of the then Prime Minister Indira Gandhi's assassination. The issue also has the potential to flare into a controversy in Punjab, where the BJP is set to contest the upcoming Assembly polls on its own.

"Strongly condemn the visit of the three MPs to mass murderer Sajjan Kumar's residence to offer condolences on his death," HS Phoolka posted on X.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Justice Nagarathna's warning: The bar cannot afford to lose relevance

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Supreme Court judge BV Nagarathna on Saturday lamented that the legal system is bogged down by pendency, delays and rising costs, and asked the bar to change its mindset, rethink its role and speak in a singular voice to sustain the justice dispensation system.

Justice Nagarathna, who was speaking at the 13th convocation of National Law University at Delhi, stressed that when a bar council does not earn the respect of its members, it is not a good sign for the legal profession.

Bar councils must intro-

spect on their role and importance in upholding professional ethics, morality and professional competence and it is time for members of the bar to introspect on their duties in seeking justice for the distressed litigant and for sustaining democracy in the country, she said.

"The lawyers of this country are the torchbearers of the values of our Constitution. Any lapse or errors of the bar will have a deep impact on our political and civic life. Hence, their importance in our society."

"I humbly remind every member of the Bar to change their mindset and endure to work for their clients as a



PTI

public service, lest they lose their relevance in the future to come. That would be disastrous for our system of dispensation of justice and for preserving the rule of law in our country."

Justice Nagarathna said that the bar must use its knowledge and judgment in the service of the rule of law.

"As the legal system in India is bogged down by pendency, delays, rising costs and uncertainty, the Bar in India must rise and speak in a singular voice as to how it could sustain the system of justice dispensation in India," she said.

Describing lawyers as the "safety valves" of democracies,

Justice Nagarathna said the independence of the Bar is not an entitlement given to lawyers for their own benefit.

It exists because a constitutional democracy requires a body of professionals who can advise, argue, challenge and represent without having to ask the permission of the State, the market or even their own clients before doing so, she said.

The bar must rethink its usefulness to the litigant public, its role in safeguarding our democracy and in upholding the majesty of courts of law and its indispensability in upholding justice and the rule of law, she said.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

28-year-old electrocuted after falling into roadside pit, family left destitute

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Following the death of 28-year-old Sandeep after falling into a pit in east Delhi, contrasting explanations by police and the PWD regarding whether he was electrocuted, along with promises of strict action, can offer little help to his grieving family, which now stares at another devastating concern.

“What will we do now? What will we eat?” asks Kishanpyari, Sandeep’s aunt as she struggles to come to terms with the loss of the family’s sole breadwinner.

Sandeep, employed as a caregiver, had left for work as usual on Thursday morning

and was expected to return home at around 9 pm, but he never came back, Kishanpyari said. He fell into a nearly three-foot-deep pit and suffered an electric shock, police have said.

“I called him multiple times but no one picked up. After some time, someone picked up and asked if I was Sandeep’s aunt. I said yes and asked him to make me talk to him. He said he would do so in five minutes. Then the phone got switched off,” she said. The family remained unaware of Sandeep’s whereabouts through the night until they received a call from police at around 6 am, she said.

“They asked what he was wearing. I told them about his

clothes, bag and slippers. They took him to one hospital and then another. That’s all we know,” Kishanpyari said. Her distress has now been compounded by the family’s financial uncertainty, as its livelihood depended on Sandeep.

“He was the sole bread earner. I have become aged, and no one gives me work. What do we eat?” she said.

According to the preliminary police enquiry, Sandeep was crossing Road Number 58 in east Delhi’s Surajmal Vihar when the unpaved section of the road near an electricity pole on the divider caved in. He fell into a nearly three-foot-deep pit and was trapped up to his waist.

Police said an electric



current was allegedly passing through the lower portion of the pole, causing Sandeep to suffer an electric shock and die on the spot.

A PCR call regarding the incident was received at around 7.30 am on Thursday, following which police per-

sonnel reached the spot and took Sandeep to a hospital, where doctors declared him brought dead.

The body was sent to the GTB Hospital mortuary for a post-mortem examination, and the report is awaited, police said.

Police are examining CCTV footage from cameras installed around the spot and have indicated alleged negligence by civic agencies as part of their investigation.

According to locals, workers filled the caved-in portion of the road with stones, debris and cement by the evening after the incident.

However, the Delhi Public Works Department (PWD), whose street-light pole was located at the spot, has denied that any electrical fault or current leakage from its infrastructure has been established.

In a statement, the PWD expressed condolences to the family and said a detailed technical inspection of the site had

been carried out, along with an examination of the electrical infrastructure and relevant maintenance records.

“Based on the technical findings available so far, no electrical fault or current leakage from the PWD street-light pole at the location has been established,” the department said, adding that the pole and its electrical components were found to have the required protective measures in place.

The department said the Government has directed that all aspects of the incident be thoroughly examined and responsibility fixed wherever any negligence, lapse or violation of prescribed safety protocols is found.

“Strict action will be taken against any person or agency found responsible for negligence or dereliction of duty,” the PWD said.

The department added that it was extending necessary cooperation and technical information to the authorities and would strengthen inspections and maintenance of electrical infrastructure.

Sandeep lived with his aunt in Bihari Colony and used to walk to work every day to look after an elderly person at a house in Surajmal Vihar, police said.

Kishanpyari now has to mourn his untimely death, as well as cope with the loss of the family’s only earning member.

CM announces Seva Pakhwada from September 17 to October 2

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday announced that from September 17, which is the 76th birthday of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, up to October 2, a Seva Pakhwada or a fortnight of service, will be organised in Delhi. During this period, the Rekha Gupta Government will dedicate new schemes and projects related to transport, roads, sewerage, water treatment, education, power, public utilities, and urban beautification.

Among these, the most significant is the inauguration of the Barapullah Elevated Road (Phase-II), built at a cost of around ₹1,635 crore. Apart from this, the project for the construction of an underpass on Outer Ring Road near Mukarba Chowk and an approach road from Badli Junction to Haiderpur Metro Station, built at a cost of ₹54.10 crore, is also ready for inauguration. Last year, the Rekha Gupta Government had dedicated 75 projects on PM Modi’s birthday to the public.

The chief minister said PM Modi who first became the Chief Minister of Gujarat on October 7, 2001, is soon going to complete an historic 25



years in public office. “Therefore, this Seva Pakhwada of the Delhi Government is going to be particularly special this time,” she said.

The chief minister also informed that during the Seva Pakhwada, several key projects related to sewerage and water management will be dedicated to the residents of Delhi. These include the construction of a 2-MGD recycling plant at the existing 20-MGD Water Treatment Plant in Bawana, the construction of a 564-MLD Wastewater Treatment Plant at Okhla, and the construction of an interceptor sewer from Barapullah Drain to Batla House Phase-II SPS. Along with these projects, work on a 35-MGD Sewage Pumping Station at Batla House Phase-II and rising mains to the

Okhla WWTP is also included. In addition, projects for the rehabilitation and upgrading of Wastewater Treatment Plants at Rithala Phase-I and Kondli Phase-I, II, and III will also be inaugurated. The total cost of these water and sewerage projects is ₹863.38 crore. Projects to provide household sewer connections in the left-out colonies of Gokalpur assembly constituency and laying sewer lines in parts of Sriram Colony, Rajiv Nagar, and Sonia Vihar are also included.

The Chief Minister informed that in the education sector, the inauguration of a G+3 permanent school building in Sector-16, Dwarka, is proposed during Seva Pakhwada. Apart from this, the construction of 68 G+3 equivalent SPS classrooms in East Vinod Nagar and 76 equivalent SPS

classrooms in Sector-41, Rohini, has also been completed. The costs of these three projects are ₹38.44 crore, ₹38.30 crore, and ₹66.28 crore, respectively.

She also shared that several sub-station projects strengthening the power infrastructure of the capital will be inaugurated during Seva Pakhwada. The total cost of these power projects is ₹232.42 crore. Along with this, projects like a two-storey community hall near Golok Dham in Bijwasan, Dwarka, renovation of Balmiki Chaupal in Basant Village, RK Puram, reconstruction of Sisodia Chaupal in Malikpur, and the construction of a protective wall along the Barapullah Drain have also been completed.

“The projects being launched during Seva Pakhwada will directly benefit lakhs of citizens living in different areas of Delhi and will help make their lives smoother, safer, and more convenient. Our Government is resolved to ensure that the benefits of development reach every area and every section of Delhi, and that the capital is developed into a modern, clean, empowered, and facility-rich Delhi,” she added.

Nearly 48 lakh voters marked uncollectable in draft roll, one-third electorate may be missing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Around one-third of Delhi’s electorate could be missing from the draft electoral roll set to be released on Monday as part of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), with officials saying that the names of about 47.7 lakh voters have been categorised as uncollectible. The final draft list is expected on November 4. Those excluded in the draft roll can seek inclusion by filing claims and objections from August 31 to September 30, officials said.

The draft roll will contain around 97.5 lakh electors, whose enumeration forms were submitted and digitised during the door-to-door exercise that concluded on August 17, accounting for 67.18 per cent of Delhi’s 1,45,10,299 electors, according to figures released by the Delhi Chief Electoral Officer (CEO).

The remaining 47.7 lakh electors have been marked “uncollectable” and placed in the “Absent, Shifted, Dead, Duplicate and Others (ASDDO)” categories. They will not appear in the draft



roll but can seek inclusion by filing claims and objections from August 31 to September 30, officials said.

The publication of the draft will also begin the next phase of scrutiny, with some electors whose names figure in the roll likely to receive notices if their details could not be linked to the 2002 intensive revision roll or if anomalies were detected in their enumeration forms, officials said.

A Delhi CEO official said such anomalies could include a mismatch between an elector’s name in the current roll and the 2002 roll, an age gap of less than 15 years or more than 50 years between an elector and a parent, or a gap of less than nine months between the birth dates of siblings.

The Electoral Registration Officer (ERO) may seek additional documents where there are doubts about an elector’s age or citizenship, the official said. Aadhaar alone will not be sufficient to establish eligibility.

The documentary requirements will also vary according to an elector’s date of birth. Those born in India before July 1, 1987, will need a document establishing their date and/or place of birth; those born between July 1, 1987 and December 2, 2004, will need documents for themselves and one parent; and those born after December 2, 2004, will need documents for themselves and both parents, officials said.

The scale of exclusions has varied sharply across Delhi’s 70 Assembly con-

stituencies. Rohini recorded the highest digitisation of enumeration forms at 83.43 per cent, while Tughlakabad recorded the lowest at 52.15 per cent, according to the CEO’s data.

Among minority-dominated constituencies, Okhla had 1,64,435 of its 3,62,813 forms, or 45.32 per cent, marked uncollectable.

Chandni Chowk recorded 38.98 per cent, followed by Ballimaran at 32.65 per cent, Mustafabad at 28.09 per cent, Babarpur at 27 per cent, Matia Mahal at 24.50 per cent and Seelampur at 23.37 per cent.

BLOs had earlier reported difficulties in linking residents in areas such as Shaheen Bagh and Jasola Vihar with the 2002 roll, particularly among migrant families from Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Assam and West Bengal.

At the other end, several constituencies recorded relatively high digitisation. Shakurbasti stood at 81.26 per cent, Rajouri Garden at 79.14 per cent, Mangolpuri at 78.76 per cent and Uttam Nagar at 77.76 per cent.

Govt amends Fire Service Rules, mandates 6-metre access, smoke barriers, dedicated control rooms



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has amended the Fire Service Rules, introducing a comprehensive set of minimum fire prevention and safety standards for buildings, including provisions for fire and smoke barriers, encroachment-free access, emergency power and dedicated fire control rooms.

According to Delhi Home Minister Ashish Sood, these revised rules enforce modern, mandatory safety measures across all buildings – ranging from 6-meter clear access routes for fire engines to automated continuous monitoring, sprinkler systems, and dedicated emergency power backups. “Furthermore, a standardized auditor inspection checklist will bring complete transparency and accountability to safety compliance. We are committed to building a safer, more resilient, and modern Delhi,” he said.

The Delhi Fire Service (Amendment) Rules, 2026, notified by the Home Department of the city Government on August 28, provide that the minimum standards applicable to buildings will be linked to their height and class of occupancy and will be governed by the Building Bye-Laws.

The amendment in the rules comes in the wake of fire tragedies in the city in the recent months, including Malviya Nagar hotel fire that claimed lives of 23 persons, mostly foreign nationals, in June. The amended rules lay down that buildings for which fire prevention and safety

measures are not specified in the Building Bye-Laws, the Delhi Fire Services (DFS) director may require owners or occupiers to adopt additional measures in accordance with the standards prescribed by the fire prevention wing.

The Government may also relax, modify or remove specific requirements for certain classes of occupancy or buildings in special areas, according to the amended rules.

These rules will come into force from the date on which the amended Unified Building Bye-Laws (UBBL)-2016 are notified by the DDA. The Home Department notification clarifies that applications pending on the date of commencement will continue to be processed under the provisions in force on the date of application submission.

The amended rules have 18 categories of fire safety measures to be considered for buildings under the provisions relating to fire prevention and fire safety certification and issuance of no-objection certificates by the DFS and third party auditors, officials said.

These include a minimum six-metre right of way for fire engines up to the premises, protection of exits through fire check doors or pressurisation, fire and smoke barriers, fire stops and smoke management systems.

Buildings will also be required to provide fire extinguishers, first-aid hose reels, automatic fire detection and alarm systems, MOEFA, public address or voice evacuation systems and automatic sprinkler and fire suppression systems, as applicable.

Jamia suspends four students over protest against admission irregularities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Jamia Millia Islamia has suspended four students and barred them from entering the campus in connection with a protest over alleged irregularities in 2026-27 admissions, according to suspension orders issued by the university.

The students were part of an “unauthorised” sit-in at the university’s Central Canteen on August 24, despite being informed that protests could be held only at a designated area near Gate No. 18, according to the university.

The orders state that the students were suspended for varying periods and barred from entering the campus during the suspension period. They have also been asked to explain why further disciplinary action should not be taken against them.

“One student has been suspended for 10 days, two students for a week each and a fourth student for only three days, depending on the varying degree of offence,” a university official told PTI.



“The suspension periods are fairly brief so the students can come back to their academic commitments without any disruption. We have no intention to punish students, just that grievances should be raised through proper channels,” the official added.

The development comes days after students affiliated with the Jamia unit of the National Students’ Union of India (NSUI) held an indefinite sit-in demanding transparency in examination results, a review of admissions and accountability for alleged irregularities in the admission process.

The NSUI had also alleged that protesting students were forcibly removed from the campus. The university had previously rejected similar

allegations raised by the Students’ Federation of India (SFI), terming them “baseless” and maintaining that its admission process was “extremely transparent” and could not be manipulated.

The SFI had raised questions over spot admissions, reservation policies and the disclosure of vacant seats and waiting lists. The university, in the suspension orders, maintained that its officials had engaged with the protesting students and assured them that genuine grievances would be examined by the competent authorities.

The students have been given time to submit their explanations, following which the matter may be considered by the university’s disciplinary authorities.

Rainfall crosses seasonal average, yet temperatures stay high

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

From rain-soaked days to warm nights, August has unfolded differently for Delhi this year: Rainfall has already crossed the seasonal average, day and night-time temperatures remain high, and the month’s average air quality index has reached a three-year high.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), Delhi has received 653.9 mm of rainfall at Safdarjung since the beginning of the monsoon season, compared with the long-period average of 506.7 mm, resulting in a surplus of 147.2 mm, or 29 per cent.

The capital also recorded



its wettest first week of August in 15 years, receiving 127 mm of rainfall during the first seven days of the month, the highest for the period since 2011. The month witnessed one of its heaviest single-day rainfall spells on August 25, when Safdarjung recorded 99.1 mm of rain in 24 hours, the highest rainfall for an August day in two

years, the IMD said.

The last time Safdarjung recorded more rainfall in August was on August 1, 2024, when the station received 107.6 mm. The seasonal rainfall surplus has been recorded across most of the city’s weather stations.

Palam received 533.2 mm against its seasonal normal of 482.1 mm, a surplus of 11

percent, while Lodhi Road recorded 648.2 mm against 506.7 mm, 28 per cent above normal. The Ridge recorded 703.1 mm against its normal of 432.1 mm, a surplus of 63 per cent, while Ayanagar received 686.3 mm against 431.3 mm, 59 percent above normal.

August was considerably wetter than normal. Safdarjung recorded 354.1 mm during the month against the normal of 222.9 mm, a surplus of 131.2 mm or 59 per cent. Palam received 300.8 mm against its August normal of 207.6 mm, 45 per cent above normal, while Lodhi Road recorded 332 mm against 222.9 mm, a surplus of 49 per cent, the IMD said.

Civic body, World Bank discuss waste management overhaul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Saturday held discussions with World Bank experts on revamping the city’s waste management system, learning models followed by Tokyo, New York and Barcelona, officials said.

According to a statement, MCD commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar chaired the meeting attended by additional commissioners, the engineers-in-chief and deputy commissioners of all zones.

The World Bank team presented Tokyo’s technology-driven system, New York’s reliance on private agencies for waste transportation and



processing, and Barcelona’s focus on decentralised facilities, waste segregation and changing citizen behaviour.

“Tokyo’s system, which has 23 waste-to-energy facilities, was discussed as an example of large-scale processing of municipal waste using technology,” read the statement.

IN FOCUS



People carrying an idol of Lord Ganesh to a Pandal ahead of Ganesh Chaturthi festival in Mumbai, Maharashtra

PTI

Kolkata police file suo motu FIR against ex-CM Mamata

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Kolkata Police have registered a suo motu FIR against former West Bengal chief minister and Trinamool Congress supremo Mamata Banerjee for alleged violation of Calcutta High Court-imposed conditions for holding a TMCP foundation day event here, a senior officer said on Saturday.

The FIR was filed on Friday at the Hastings Police Station against Banerjee as well as the organisers of the meeting of the Trinamool Chhatra Parishad (TMCP), an officer said.

"The FIR has been registered for the alleged violation of the court's order. The role of all those involved in the violation will be exam-



ined during the course of the investigation. The case was registered under various sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) on August 28," he said. The case was registered after examining the conditions imposed

by the court for holding the TMCP meeting at Cathedral Road in central Kolkata on Friday, the officer said. "The FIR was based on a complaint lodged by sub-inspector Apu Baidya, posted at the Hastings Police Station. It

was alleged that Banerjee and the organisers entered into a criminal conspiracy and, in furtherance of it, violated the high court's order," he said.

During the programme, TMCP supporters "breached barricades and jostled with police personnel deployed for maintaining law and order, leading to a chaotic situation", the officer claimed.

Those who attended the programme allegedly disrupted vehicular movement on one flank of the Cathedral Road, he said.

"The allegations include violation of the high court's directions, obstruction of traffic and incidents involving police personnel deployed at the spot," the police officer said.

Hundreds gather in Delhi to pay tribute to Sajjan Kumar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Hundreds of people gathered at Talkatora Stadium on Saturday for a condolence meet held for former Congress MP Sajjan Kumar, who died at 80 last week.

He was serving a life sentence in cases related to the 1984 anti-Sikh riots.

Kumar died at a Delhi hospital on August 20 and was cremated at Nigam Bodh Ghat the following day. The condolence meet was attended by several MPs, MLAs, other political leaders from Delhi and neighbouring states, Delhi Congress president Devender Yadav, and representatives of social and religious outfits, according to a statement issued by the organisers.

Kumar's son Jagpravesh Kumar, who addressed the gathering, said he would continue to raise public issues and serve people, inspired by his father.

The Congress leader was sentenced by the Delhi High Court to life imprisonment in December 2018 for the killing of five Sikhs and the burning of a gurdwara during the 1984 riots.

In February 2025, he was sentenced to life imprisonment by a Delhi court in another case concerning the killing of two Sikh men.

Kumar resigned from the Congress following his 2018



conviction. He was brought to Safdarjung Hospital from Tihar jail on August 20 after developing an altered sensorium. Despite resuscitation and life-support measures, he died at 12.30 pm, according to the hospital.

The hospital said Kumar had a history of high blood pressure and Parkinson's disease and had been admitted several times in the past.

The Supreme Court was scheduled to hear his plea seeking three weeks' parole on medical grounds in connection with his ailing wife on the day of his death, but the matter did not come up for hearing. Kumar entered politics as a municipal councillor from Nangloi and later became general secretary of the Delhi Pradesh Congress Committee. He was elected to the Lok Sabha from Outer Delhi in 1980, 1991 and 2004.

Anti-Sikh riots broke out in 1984 following the assassination of then prime minister Indira Gandhi by her Sikh bodyguards on October 31 that year.

Noida rape accused killed in police encounter after firing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

A 40-year-old man accused of abducting and raping a six-year-old girl was killed in an encounter with Noida Police on Saturday after he allegedly opened fire at a police team, officials said.

The girl had gone missing from her home on Friday night, following which her family lodged a missing-person complaint at the Ecotech 3 police station in Central Noida.

Swatantra Kumar Singh, Additional DCP, Central Noida, told PTI that police formed five teams to search for the child after receiving the complaint.

"Through CCTV footage and other sources, the police teams identified Balraj (40) as the person who had abducted the child. After raping her, he had stuffed her body into a sack and discarded it," Singh said.

UP CM accuses Opposition of caste, region division

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gorakhpur

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Saturday accused his political rivals of dividing people in the name of caste, region and language. He called them a gang of dacoits and said whenever they got the chance, they engaged in plunder, looted the state and the country, and spread anarchy.

Adityanath said over the past decade or so, his Government eliminated the



mafia. "We need to be wary of them. We must not trust them," the chief minister said while inaugurating and laying the foundation of 170 development projects worth over Rs 130 crore in Gorakhpur. "They seized the land belonging to the poor and to traders, their birthright. However, this 'double-engine' BJP Government will not allow the oppression of the poor, nor will it permit the exploitation of Dalits or the marginalised," Adityanath

said. He said the UP Government will not allow anyone to compromise the safety of any daughter or any trader; and whoever attempts to do so will be dealt with strictly within the framework of the law.

Adityanath said the BRD Medical College (in Gorakhpur) has been upgraded and now offers super-specialty facilities.

"A Regional Virology Centre has been established. AIIMS Gorakhpur is now operational," said.

Telangana CM urges EC to extend SIR claims, objections period by four weeks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy on Saturday urged the Election Commission to extend the period for filing claims and objections under the SIR by four weeks from September 19.

In a letter to Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, he said the period presently notified for claims and objections from

August 17 to September 16, with the final publication scheduled for September 19, is very short for a mammoth exercise of SIR.

"I would request that this period be extended by four weeks, so that electors whose names are missing from the draft rolls- the ASDD (absent, shifted, dead, duplicate) class particularly- have a sufficient time to find out where they stand and to file Form 6 claims," Reddy said. He observed that Election

Commission manual provides for the draft roll to be read out at Gram Sabhas, and, in urban areas, at ward committee meetings so that omissions can be identified and rectified while there is still time.

The CM suggested that the Telangana Chief Electoral Officer be asked to direct District Election Officers specifically to convene these meetings at least twice. He requested that each elector be



allowed at least three to four weeks to reply to the notice issued to them during SIR as daily wage earners, migrant workers may find it difficult to gather the documents and furnish reply in one week. The Chief Minister suggested opening help desks, particularly in urban districts, to help voters respond to the notice.

Recalling the EC's clarification that the Telangana Government's Family Register Certificate will

not be accepted in SIR verification, he said the voters may not possess any of the admissible documents.

He urged the EC that a "widened" list of documents be notified which should include papers obtainable at the mandal level. Reddy also sought deploying more Additional Electoral Registration Officers and permitting hearings over claims and objections below the ERO level.

FROM PAGE - 1

Nepal opens doors to international aid

Indian External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar spoke with Nepal's Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal and reaffirmed New Delhi's readiness to support the rescue effort.

India has also supplied emergency materials, including portable power generators, food, dignity kits and water-purification tablets.

An 11-member contingent comprising doctors, paramedics and tunnel-rescue specialists has been deployed alongside additional relief supplies. China and Nepal restarted rescue efforts in the flood-affected Himalayan region on Friday. A 21-member Chinese rescue contingent, accompanied by a search-and-rescue dog, reached the severely damaged Gyirong border crossing after flooding destroyed road connections to the area.

The team travelled through difficult mountain terrain, using ropes to cross forests and steep sections of the route. On reaching the border facility, rescuers found large parts of the complex destroyed.

Chinese authorities are also watching glacial lakes and other possible sources of additional flooding. A barrier lake upstream remains a concern, with officials warning that rising water could create another surge.

Rescue operations have faced additional dangers as floodwaters altered the landscape. At one point, rescuers were forced to temporarily withdraw after a lake created by the disaster began spilling into the Lhendé Khola and Trishuli rivers.

Teams returned once the immediate danger diminished. Nepali officials are continuing to monitor two barrier lakes and have cautioned that flooding could remain a threat until the accumulated water drains away.

The disaster has affected more than 90,000 people, according to the Red Cross. The United Nations and partner agencies are also expanding emergency assistance, including supplies of food and clean water.

Families in Nepal and abroad continue to wait for information about relatives who disappeared when the floods struck. A number of foreign nationals had been travelling through the region for trekking and pilgrimage activities.

Amid the devastation, rescue teams have also recorded dramatic survivals. An eight-year-old boy, initially feared dead after his school was destroyed, was later found alive and reunited with his mother.

Nepal's decision to accept foreign assistance reflects the increasingly complex nature of the rescue operation. Domestic agencies remain responsible for coordinating the response, but international teams can provide highly specialised expertise that may be difficult to deploy quickly at such a large scale.

Capabilities such as tunnel rescue, advanced medical assistance, DNA testing and forensic identification could prove particularly important as teams search for missing people and work to

identify recovered remains. The presence of foreign nationals among the missing also added a diplomatic dimension to the crisis. Several countries, including India, China, the United States, the United Kingdom, Japan, South Korea, Sri Lanka and Bangladesh, had expressed interest in sending assistance.

The policy reversal signals a move away from Nepal's initial preference for conducting the rescue operation independently towards targeted international cooperation, while keeping overall command of the response in the hands of Nepali authorities.

Pilgrims stranded in Tibet head to Nepal

Reddy was part of a 31-member group from Hyderabad that travelled to Tibet on August 23. They had entered the Tibet Autonomous Region through the Gyirong-Nepal border and were due to return through the same point on Friday.

Earlier, China's official media reported that 555 tourists were among 1,000 people evacuated from Gyirong County. Reddy said he and his family heard the news about the flash floods on Wednesday when they were doing the 'Parikrama' - circumambulation - around the sacred Kailash mountain along with thousands of others.

He was informed about the devastating flash flood at the Gyirong-Nepal border post through a call from embassy officials.

"Otherwise, we have not felt any impact and continued our Parikrama," he said.

The torrent of water, mud and debris which engulfed vast stretches of the border area has also raised concerns over the safety of the pilgrim centres. Reddy said Kailash Mountain and Mansarovar Lake - which are 700 kms from Gyirong - were not impacted by the flash floods.

The Chinese Government, which is carrying out massive relief and rescue operations, has not yet commented on the impact of the flash floods on the rest of Tibet's fragile mountainous environment. The Kailash Manasarovar Yatra route was reopened last year as part of the normalisation process between India and China after a five-year freeze due to COVID-19 and a stand-off at Eastern Ladakh. (PTI)

US revives plan to end work permits for some...

It is currently classified as a long-term regulatory action.

Under the existing rules, certain H-4 dependent spouses can apply for employment authorisation if their H-1B spouse meets specific requirements linked to the employment-based green card process. According to US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS), an H-4 spouse may qualify for an EAD if the H-1B spouse is the beneficiary of an approved Form I-140 immigrant petition or has received certain extensions of H-1B status beyond the standard six-year limit under

the American Competitiveness in the 21st Century Act. The H-4 EAD programme was introduced in 2015, with USCIS beginning to accept applications on May 26 that year. The policy was designed to allow eligible spouses of H-1B workers pursuing permanent residency to participate in the US workforce.

For many H-1B families, the work permit provides an important source of income and allows spouses to build or continue their careers in the US. Unlike H-1B employment, an H-4 EAD does not generally tie the spouse to one specific employer. If the proposed rollback eventually becomes law, affected H-4 spouses could lose this employment option and may need to obtain work authorization through another immigration category.

The current development, however, does not mean that H-4 employment authorization has been immediately cancelled.

The proposal remains at an early stage in the federal regulatory process. DHS would need to publish a formal proposed rule, allow the public to submit comments and review those comments before deciding whether to issue a final regulation. Until any final rule takes effect, qualifying H-4 spouses remain eligible for employment authorization under the current system.

The issue is not new. During Donald Trump's first administration, DHS pursued a similar proposal to remove employment authorization for certain H-4 spouses. That effort did not ultimately eliminate the programme and was later withdrawn. The latest regulatory action revives the debate over whether spouses of H-1B workers should continue to have access to employment authorization while their families navigate the lengthy employment-based immigration process.

For H-1B families, the distinction between a regulatory proposal and an actual policy change is particularly important. A listing on the federal regulatory agenda does not itself terminate existing work permits or prevent eligible H-4 spouses from working. If DHS proceeds with formal rulemaking and ultimately adopts the proposal, the change could have significant financial and professional consequences for affected families.

For now, there is no immediate nationwide ban on H-4 spouses working in the United States. The existing H-4 EAD framework remains in place while DHS considers whether to move forward with its proposed rollback.

Red Fort blast: Court accepts NIA's...

The NIA says the case involves a vehicle-mounted bomb, a high-intensity charge, and chemical explosives made through trial and error. The charges include the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, the Explosive Substances Act, the Arms Act, and the Prevention of Damage to Public Property Act.

The group involved is Ansar Ghazwat-ul-Hind (AGuH), an offshoot of Al-Qaida in the Indian Subcontinent that was banned in 2018. The NIA says the group has not disappeared. According

to the agency, it rebranded as AGuH Interim at a closed meeting in Srinagar in 2022 and started Operation Heavenly Hind, which aimed to overthrow the Government and replace it with Sharia law, using rifles, drones, and car bombs.

The chargesheet describes how members were recruited and indoctrinated, and mentions stockpiles of AK-47s, Krinkovs, and locally made pistols. It also details experiments with explosives mounted on rockets and drones aimed at security targets. The NIA says the operation took place in Jammu and Kashmir, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, Gujarat, and the Delhi-NCR area. The case includes 588 witnesses, over 395 documents, and more than 200 seized items. DNA and voice analysis identified the man who died with the vehicle as Nabi.

Special Public Prosecutor Madhav Khurana, along with Trisha Mittal and Anil Dabas, said the large amount of evidence came from a multi-State investigation rather than a rushed decision. They explained that the blast was not the beginning of the inquiry, but the moment when the long-running plot became visible through the explosion near the Red Fort.

The hearing on September 9 will likely set the schedule for the next steps in the case. The Red Fort case has drawn a lot of attention from officials and the public because of the target, the professional backgrounds of some accused, and claims that a white-collar network planned a major attack in the capital.

Justice Nagarathna's warning: The bar...

She also reminded that the legal profession played an important role in the national movement and in the making of the Constitution.

Justice Nagarathna also spoke about the changing nature of the legal profession and said that as lawyers of the 21st century, the young lawyers were entering a profession that must constantly adapt and respond to a changing reality.

"The velocity of change around us is unprecedented — technological advancements, environmental crises, social upheavals, geopolitical shifts, and transformations in the way we live, work, and think. These are not theoretical conundrums. "They go to the heart of what kind of society we want to live in — and what role the law should play in shaping it. We need thinkers who can build bridges between the past and the future, between tradition and innovation, between legality and legitimacy," she said.

Delhi High Court Chief Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyaya conferred degrees to those passing out from the NLU. Besides him, several other judges of the high court and Chancellor of NLU Delhi Prof (Dr) G S Bajpai were also present at the convocation. On the use of technology, Justice Nagarathna said it is impossible to automate human judgment even with artificial intelligence and added that some questions cannot be answered by a bare knowledge of law.

"They require judgment, communication, strategy and an understanding of people. And these are precisely the skills that ADR (alternative dispute res-

olution) develops," she said. The judge cautioned lawyers appearing before courts against relying on fake judgments generated through artificial intelligence, saying, "Don't fall prey to hallucination."

Justice Nagarathna also emphasised the importance of Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR) and said there had been a discernible shift from traditional litigation towards alternative mechanisms, though litigation remained authoritative and courts remained the cornerstone of the justice system. She said litigation faced procedural complexity, delay, costs and its inherently adversarial character. Arbitration, mediation and conciliation were therefore increasingly becoming components of the justice system.

BJP summons, reprimands MPs over...

A prominent advocate for victims of the 1984 anti-Sikh riots, Phoolka has called for a boycott of the MPs, arguing that the move raises serious questions about how political leaders should engage with figures associated with one of the darkest chapters in India's recent history.

"This when BJP has always supported our quest for justice against this culprit and supported us in ensuring that he stays in jail. Sympathy should be reserved for victims and their families-many of whom live the horror of those days even till now," he added. Phoolka, a former Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) member who is best known for representing 1984 anti-Sikh riots victims in their quest for justice, joined the BJP on April 1.

Recently, Congress leader Deepender Hooda, who has come under fire from the leaders of his own party across Punjab and Haryana for describing anti-Sikh riot convict Sajjan Kumar as a "role model" after the latter's death, has made a U-turn after criticism from his own party members and the BJP. The visits of the three MPs, however, have provided the party's political opponents an opportunity to target it.

Delhi AAP leader Saurabh Bhardwaj also took a swipe at the BJP, saying the hearts of the three MPs beat for the riot convict. "The hearts of BJP MPs Kamaljeet Sehrawat, Yogendra Chandolia, and Ramvir Singh Bidhuri still beat for convicted 1984 Sikh riots killer Sajjan Kumar," he wrote on X. "Will @NitinNabin suspend these MPs of BJP who have backstabbed Sikhs?" he added, tagging the BJP national president. Bhardwaj also questioned the "silence" of Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) leaders on the issue.

Kumar, who died on August 20, was serving two concurrent life sentences for his role in the killings of Sikhs during the 1984 anti-Sikh riots.

The three MPs represent constituencies in Delhi that were carved out of the erstwhile Outer Delhi parliamentary constituency, which Kumar represented in the Lok Sabha as a Congress leader. Bidhuri represents South Delhi, Sehrawat represents West Delhi and Chandolia represents North West Delhi.

ED arrests 3 more, including a CA, in Goa digital arrest probe

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ Panaji

The Enforcement Directorate's Panaji office has arrested three more people accused of being part of a nationwide money-laundering network. This group is suspected of converting proceeds from "digital arrest" cyber fraud into cash and foreign currency. Bhushan Suryakant Moye, a chartered accountant, along with Vilas Narayan Pawar and Shailesh Dagdu Chavan, were taken into custody on August 27 under Section 19 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002. A special PMLA court in Goa has ordered that the three remain in ED custody until September 1. With these arrests, five people have now

been detained in the case. Earlier, Fahim Moin Hussain Sayed and Naim Mueen Sayyed were arrested on August 23 and are still in custody. The investigation started with FIR No. 17/2025, filed on June 9, 2025, at the Cyber Crime Police Station in North Goa. In this case, a Goa resident was kept on a video call, convinced she was under investigation, and forced to transfer ₹2,60,33,634 between May 21 and June 2, 2025, into accounts falsely called "Secret Supervision Accounts." ED investigators say the victim's money entered an organised apparatus designed to receive cyber-fraud proceeds as banking credits, convert them into cash, and then convert the cash into foreign currency through companies holding

Reserve Bank of India licences as Full Fledged Money Changers. The funds were fragmented across more than 400 beneficiary accounts and routed into companies whose directors of record were persons of no means; the accounts were operated by others so that the proceeds of crime would appear untainted. Those same entities' accounts figure in 330 victim complaints, and 163 first information reports filed across more than 20 states and Union Territories. Reported losses in those cases total ₹417.49 crore. The network's banking transactions total more than ₹27,850 crore. Earlier, the ED reported cash deposits of about ₹2,904 crore, including ₹584.70 crore deposited through 61,448 bulk-note-



acceptance-machine transactions at different locations. The agency says Moye set up 21 companies using identity documents provided to him and treated these companies

and their 43 dummy directors as a single group, filing their tax returns together rather than separately. Pawar handled the RTGS transfers that moved the illegal funds

into the network's accounts, while Chavan provided cash for those transfers. All three had their premises searched on August 21. The ED said that money

laundering continued even after searches on July 17, right up until just before the first arrests on August 23. This made it necessary to question the suspects in custody. Earlier searches under Section 17 of the PMLA took place at 20 locations in Mumbai and Goa on July 17, and at more places on August 21. These searches found ₹3.25 crore in cash. Accounts linked to the syndicate with over ₹30 crore were frozen. Investigators also seized digital devices, account books, financial records, and statutory registers, which are still being examined. This case shows a common pattern in digital-arrest frauds. Callers impersonate officials, keep victims on continuous video calls,

show fake documents, and convince them to transfer large sums by claiming the money is going into official "supervision" accounts. Law enforcement agencies have repeatedly said that no real agency would arrest someone over a video call. People who get such calls should hang up and report the incident to the national cybercrime helpline at 1930. The investigation is still ongoing. Because there are so many records to review and the banking and cash trails are so large, more arrests and asset seizures may happen. The ED has not yet said where the foreign currency ended up or named the licensed money changers involved. Officials say these details are still being investigated.

State prepared for possible glacial lake outburst floods incidents: Himachal Guv

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Himachal Pradesh Governor Kavinder Gupta on Saturday expressed concern over the devastation caused by the recent flash floods in the Nepal-Tibet region, describing climate change and global warming as major challenges for the world. "It is a very tragic incident and has become a challenge for the entire world. Climate change and global warming are major issues for all of us. We pray to God that such an incident does not happen again," Gupta told PTI Videos here. Asked about a recent joint report by IIT Ropar and the University of Technology



Himachal Pradesh Governor Kavinder Gupta

Sydney warning Himachal Pradesh about the threat of Glacial Lake Outburst Floods (GLOFs), the governor said the possibility of such incidents in the Himalayan region was a matter of concern. "Our concern is that such

an incident should not occur anywhere in the Himalayan range. Our Disaster Management Department has been prepared for such situations," Gupta said. He said there was also a need to focus on helping the

families and people affected by the disaster, noting with satisfaction that the Government of India had promptly begun extending assistance to the affected region. "There has been massive destruction, and if such devastation continues in this manner, the world will have to think seriously about finding a solution," he said, adding that people must come forward and participate in relief efforts to help those affected rebuild their lives. On the formation of a task force involving universities in Himachal Pradesh, Gupta said the initiative was aimed at preparing the state's youth to contribute to the Prime Minister's vision of a 'Viksit Bharat' (Developed India).

"There are around two dozen universities in Himachal Pradesh, and I am the Chancellor of some of these universities. Naturally, in view of the discussions taking place in recent days about Viksit Bharat, we have been thinking about how we can prepare our youth for the future," he said. Gupta said the Vice-Chancellors of all universities had been invited for discussions on employment, livelihood opportunities and the potential of local resources. "One of the major issues we face today is employment. We discussed what livelihood opportunities can be created and how we can generate income from local products," he said.

The man who outran death inside the tunnel

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Eyewitness Kiran Kumar's terrifying account of survival after a wall of water, mud and debris tore through the SLBC tunnel. For Kiran Kumar, it began like any other morning shift deep beneath the earth. Within minutes, it became a fight for survival. Kiran was among nearly 60 workers about 14 kilometres inside Audit-I of the Srisaillam Left Bank Canal (SLBC) tunnel in Nagarkurnool, Telangana, working near the Tunnel Boring Machine when disaster struck. At first, there were warning signs. "Everything was normal, then suddenly the water

seepage increased," Kiran recalls. "Mud and soil started falling from the roof. We were told to keep working." Then came the roar. A roughly three-metre section of the tunnel roof suddenly collapsed. Almost instantly, water, silt and debris came rushing through the underground passage. "Someone shouted, 'BHAGO, BHAGO!' We dropped everything — our tools, our helmets — and just ran." There was no time to understand what was happening. There was no time to look back. The workers ran through pitch-black darkness as water rose around their knees. Behind them came



the terrifying sound of earth and concrete collapsing. They ran for nearly three kilometres. "We couldn't see the end. We thought we would be buried alive right there," Kiran said. For those trapped underground, every second mattered. Then, in the dark-

ness, they saw something that offered a glimmer of hope — a loco train used to ferry material through the tunnel. The workers scrambled aboard. The train carried them away from the danger zone and towards safety. Kiran survived. But the escape came at a terrible cost. Thirteen workers were injured and rushed to GENCO Hospital, while eight others remained trapped deep inside the tunnel. For Kiran, however, survival did not mean the nightmare was over. The memory of that moment remains etched in his mind — the darkness, the rushing water and the deaf-

ening roar of the collapsing tunnel. "I can still hear that roar," he said. "If that train had been two minutes late, I wouldn't be here to tell this story." His account is a chilling reminder of how quickly an ordinary workday can turn into a battle between life and death. Kiran entered the tunnel that morning as a worker. He emerged as one of the men who had narrowly escaped a disaster deep beneath the earth. For him, those two minutes — and that approaching train — were the difference between a terrifying story of survival and a tragedy no one would ever forget.

Mumbai pilgrims remain untraceable after Nepal floods

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Anxiety is mounting for families in Mumbai as a 61-member Kailash Mansarovar pilgrimage group led by doctor-mountaineer Milind Chitley remains untraceable after the flash floods devastated the Nepal-Tibet border region. The group, led by Dr Chitley

and his wife Janhavi, had departed Mumbai on August 23 for Kathmandu and was last heard from on August 25 evening, hours before high-altitude torrents destroyed key immigration infrastructure on the morning of August 26. Dr Chitley's brother-in-law Sandeep Padhye said, "We were in touch with my sister till August 25, but the messages

sent on August 26 remain unread." It is still unclear whether the group crossed into China before or during the floods, he said. As per the itinerary, the group was to drive from Timure to the China border in the early hours of August 26 and reach Mansarovar on Saturday. "We haven't got any information from the authorities. An official of the Hills and Trails, a

travel company founded by Dr Chitley, has travelled to Nepal to check. Till then, we are keeping our fingers crossed. We have to accept whatever the situation is," he said. The group was to return to Mumbai on September 6 after completing their Kailash Parikrama on September 2. Dr Chitley, who founded Hills and Trails and has led treks to the Himalayas for nearly

three decades, had posted a notice outside his clinic, stating it would remain closed until September 6. The missing group also includes Dr Anand Deshpande, a consultant in Transfusion Medicine at PD Hinduja Hospital, and his wife Dr Gayatri Deshpande, head of Obstetrics and Gynaecology at Nanavati Max Hospital.

‘We can’t lose hope’: Gujarat families anxiously await word from loved ones stranded in Nepal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

For families of pilgrims, including NRIs with a Gujarat link who were on the Kailash Mansarovar pilgrimage when the flash floods struck the Nepal-Tibet region, the anxious wait is traumatising, and the devastating visuals of destruction are distressing, but they have not lost hope. The number of untraceable persons rose to 26, including several NRIs from Gujarat, according to a list released by the State Emergency Operations Centre on Friday. Several NRIs from the US, Canada, Australia and New Zealand have links to Ahmedabad, Anand, Rajkot, Valsad, Surat, Kheda, Amreli, Gandhinagar and Vadodara, it said. "It's difficult to see the horrific visuals of flash floods in Nepal, but we can't lose hope," said Rajkot resident Viral Nathwani, whose cousins are among those



Sonu Adhikari looks for remains at her house that was destroyed in the devastating flash floods at Galchhi area in Dhading district of Central Nepal on Saturday

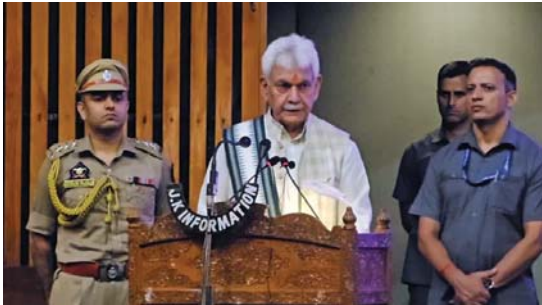
currently untraceable. Nathwani said his cousin Jay Kotecha, a Mumbai resident, and Roma Intwala of Valsad were last contacted on Wednesday when they were near the Friendship Bridge and heading towards the immigration building. He said around 56 people who had travelled through the same Mumbai-based Hills and Trails travel agency are currently unreachable. In Vadodara, Chirag Patel is anxiously awaiting news of his sister Kinnari Patel and her husband Mihir Patel, both NRIs who have been

living in New Zealand for the past 25 years. The couple had travelled to Kathmandu on August 23 to undertake the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra. "I was waiting to hear from my sister yesterday on Raksha Bandhan. We were supposed to celebrate it after their arrival back in Gujarat," Chirag said. The couple had travelled to Kathmandu on August 23 to undertake the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, Chirag said. "I hope they are fine and come back soon. I am just praying to Lord Shiva that they come back," he added. For another family,

hope rests on the possibility that poor network connectivity, rather than the floods, has cut off communication with their loved ones. Paresh Patel and his wife Jyoti Patel, and his sister Minaxi Ramani had completed immigration and were proceeding towards Kailash Mansarovar when they became unreachable, a relative, Gita Patel, said. Paresh and Jyoti are US residents, while Minaxi had joined them from Mumbai for the Kailash Mansarovar pilgrimage. "Paresh had called his mother, Sushilaben Patel, who is around 80 years old, and told her that they had completed immigration and were going to Kailash Mansarovar, where there might be a network issue," Gita Patel recalled. She said the family hopes that it is just a network issue and that they will contact them soon, as her sister is desperately waiting for them.



States Focus



J&K SHOULD ASPIRE TO HOST GLOBAL SPORTS EVENTS: LG

Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Saturday said Jammu and Kashmir should aspire not only to participate in international sporting events but also to host them and showcase its talent to the world.

Addressing a function on National Sports Day, Sinha said the region's achievements in sports over the past six years showed that dedicated preparation could create "an entire era of champions".

He also paid tribute to hockey legend Major Dhyan Chand and called upon the youth to contribute to building a Viksit Bharat by 2047.

"Champions are forged through discipline and effort, not shortcuts," Sinha said, urging corporate houses to support athletes at the talent-recognition stage rather than only after they win medals. He said society, coaches, support staff and parents had a collective responsibility in shaping sporting champions. Sinha outlined three duties for young people – to lead by example, compete with dignity, accept defeat gracefully and inspire future generations.

(PTI)



BJP CHIEF NITIN NABIN HOLDS MEETING ON YOUTH OUTREACH

BJP president Nitin Nabin on Saturday held a crucial meeting with party leaders to discuss and formulate the party's youth outreach plan, sources said.

According to sources, the party's preparations for the upcoming Assembly polls in seven States, including Uttar Pradesh, Punjab and Gujarat, were also a key agenda for the meeting.

The meeting was attended by newly appointed BJP Yuva Morcha president Hemang Joshi. Former presidents of the party's Yuva Morcha, Anurag Thakur, Poonam Mahajan and Tejasvi Surya, were also present at the meeting.

(PTI)

PM Modi must order filing of FIR: Rahul on Kharge purification row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday attacked the BJP-RSS over the 'shuddhikaran' (purification) ceremony carried out at the venue of a rally addressed by AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge in Haldwani earlier this month, saying it was a "crime", and Prime Minister Narendra Modi must order the registration of an FIR in the matter.

The Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha said this incident shows the BJP-RSS mindset that they do not want the Dalits to progress and live with respect and be successful.

"We are demanding justice for the Congress president. Give the Congress president justice in Uttarakhand. It is the duty of the Central and State Governments to ensure that Kharge gets justice," he said at a press conference.

Gandhi also accused the Uttarakhand BJP chief Mahendra Bhatt of defending the purification act and said 20 days have passed since the "crime" was committed, but no action has been taken.

"We demand that an FIR be



LoP in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi addresses a press conference at Indira Bhawan in New Delhi on Saturday

lodged against those who have done this. PM Modi states that he belongs to every caste and is the prime minister of the country, but his party chief of Uttarakhand defends 'shuddhikaran,' Gandhi said.

It is the RSS people who did it, and the PM should order an FIR under the SC/ST Act against these people, Gandhi demanded, asserting that the Congress will ensure justice for its party chief.

"There is a fight between two ideologies — the Constitution given by the likes of BR Ambedkar, Mahatma Gandhi, Jawaharlal Nehru on one side, and the BJP-RSS on the other side," he said.

"For thousands of years,

violence was perpetrated against Dalits. This is illegal under the Constitution, but today also in schools, Dalit children are made to clean toilets. This is the reality of the country," Gandhi said.

"Dalits are not allowed to drink water from wells. In tea shops, there are two cups — paper ones for Dalits and glass ones for others. In a Baraat in India, a Dalit groom wears a helmet as he could be beaten up for riding a horse. This is the reality in the country," Gandhi said.

Citing the examples of Congress president, the party's Rajasthan leader Tikaram Jolly and NDA minister Jitan Ram Manjhi - who all reportedly faced 'purification' situations at different

times - Gandhi said the more successful the Dalit person is, the attack on him or her is more fierce.

"This is another name for untouchability.

"The BJP people practice untouchability. When they do shuddhikaran, they say that Dalits cannot touch as they are impure," Gandhi said.

"They did shuddhikaran on August 10, two days after the rally of Kharge ji in Haldwani. This is a crime. On August 13, Kharge ji raised this issue in Parliament," Gandhi recalled.

The Congress on Thursday accused Uttarakhand BJP chief Mahendra Bhatt of "justifying" the purification ceremony and asked whether the ruling party would take action against the leader as he "defended untouchability".

Bhatt had reportedly said the place was polluted with slogans not fit for a religious place, as he dismissed the criticism over the ritual by the opposition.

The alleged purification took place at Ramlila Maidan in Haldwani, where Kharge had addressed a gathering on August 8.

Bihar Govt to replace term fail with eligible for skill training in marksheets of Class 10, 12

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

The Bihar Government has decided to replace the word "fail" with the phrase "eligible for skill training" in the marksheets of students appearing for Class 10 and Class 12 board examinations from the current academic session, officials said on Saturday.

The move is aimed at enabling the students to pursue vocational training programmes offered by the Bihar Board of Open Schooling and Examination (BBOSE), they said.

"The Education Department will amend the



Bihar Education Minister Mithlesh Tiwary

rules accordingly to implement this change. The department will soon issue necessary instructions to the BSEB. Instead of 'Fail', the certificates will carry the term 'Eligible for Skill

Development'." Bihar Education Minister Mithlesh Tiwary told reporters.

Tiwary said students' talent does not disappear merely because they fail to secure the expected marks

in an examination.

"Students appearing for the Class 10 board supplementary examinations will be provided special sessions for one month to help them prepare and improve their chances of success," he said.

The initiative is part of broader efforts to provide remedial support and prevent students from falling behind after an unsuccessful examination attempt, Tiwary said.

The Bihar Government has been taking measures to provide students with greater exposure to activities beyond conventional textbook-based learning, the officials said.

BJP to go ahead with foot march despite Karnataka minister's resignation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The BJP will go ahead with its scheduled 10-day foot march from Raichur to Ballari beginning September 1, former minister B Sriramulu said on Saturday.

The saffron party decided to continue with its plan despite Planning and Statistics Minister B Nagendra resigned on Friday over allegations of ₹89 crore scam in the Maharshi Valmiki



Ex-Karnataka minister B Sriramulu
Scheduled Tribes Development Corporation in 2024.
The padayatra will begin at

Lingasugur on September 1 and conclude in Ballari on September 10, covering nine Assembly constituencies, Sriramulu said.

The march was earlier announced as a campaign demanding Ballari Rural MLA Nagendra's resignation.

"The speciality of the Government today is that it has accepted a resignation for the second time on the same charges," Sriramulu said.

He said the march would be

inaugurated at Lingasugur by BJP state president BY Vijayendra, Leader of Opposition in the Assembly R Ashoka, Leader of Opposition in the Legislative Council Chalavadi Narayanaswamy and Union ministers, including Pralhad Joshi and former Chief Minister HD Kumaraswamy.

The march will pass through Maski, Sindhanur, Hanchanal Camp, Kanakagiri, Gangavathi, Kampli, Sandur and Ballari Rural

before culminating in Ballari city, he said.

Sriramulu credited the BJP and JD(S) legislators' protests in the Assembly with forcing Nagendra's resignation, saying, "They ensured that a minister resigned within about 25 days." He alleged that the ₹187-crore irregularity involved funds meant for the development of Scheduled Tribe communities, and was used during the Lok Sabha elections in Ballari and Koppal.

Bombay HC disposes plea by cab drivers as Govt grants one-year time to learn Marathi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court on Saturday disposed of a petition filed by four cab drivers seeking a stay on the Maharashtra Government's Marathi language mandate after it was informed about the State's decision to extend the timeline to learn the language by a year.

Additional Government pleader Jyoti Chavan told a bench of acting Chief Justice Ravindra Ghuge and Justice Gautam Ankhad that the Government has decided to extend the time given to auto rickshaw and taxi drivers to learn the language by one year.

The high court accepted the statement and disposed of the petition.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis announced the timeline extension after a delegation met him on Thursday, halting immediate action against non-Marathi drivers and giving them more time to learn the language.



Bombay High Court

The public interest litigation (PIL), filed through advocate Vivek Shukla, had said the Government notification dated August 12 was violative of the fundamental rights of citizens.

The petitioners - Mohd Kasim Ahmad, Mohd. Tauseef Shaikh, Siyad Ahamad, and Sadik Nasir Ali Khan - had claimed that the rule violates their fundamental rights under Articles 14 (right to equality), 19 (freedom to carry on trade and profession) and 21 (right to life) of the Constitution and is ultra vires the Motor Vehicles Act, which does not prescribe any language requirement for driving licences.

It added that lakhs of poor and migrant drivers, including themselves, face the imminent threat of suspension of badges and cancellation of permits, due to the implementation of the "working knowledge" of Marathi rule, which they said will affect their livelihoods.

"The Motor Vehicles Act confers no power upon the State Government to prescribe working knowledge of any language as a qualification for a driver, as a condition of a badge, or as a condition of a permit, and confers no power to suspend or revoke a badge on such a ground," the plea had said.

"The State Government to pre-scribe working knowledge of any language as a qualification for a driver, as a condition of a badge, or as a condition of a permit, and confers no power to suspend or revoke a badge on such a ground," the plea had said.

"Today, even those seen as close to the BJP establishment are not safe. What does this say about the state of law and order under the BJP Government?" he asked.

CM Sawant said this is the first such incident during his tenure as the chief minister.

Maratha activist Jarange begins fast over Kunbi certificates

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar

Quota activist Manoj Jarange launched an indefinite hunger strike on Saturday, demanding that the Maharashtra Government immediately issue caste certificates based on the 58 lakh Kunbi records identified earlier and asserted that the community will not grant any further time.

Speaking to reporters at Antarwali Sarati village in Jalna district, Jarange warned

that this would be his "final agitation" and accused Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis of bearing a "grudge" against the Maratha community and Deputy CM Eknath Shinde of quietly supporting him.

He also demanded the elimination of the caste verification committee, and threatened to march to the Chief Minister's residence in Mumbai if the Government fails to resolve all pending quota issues.

"Devendra Fadnavis is deliberately bearing a grudge



against the Maratha community, and Eknath Shinde is giving him covert support

through Social Justice Minister Sanjay Shirsat. If they do not resolve our

Lok Sabha with Odisha BJP MPs' support, was a "black day" for the State.

Noting that Parliament is the highest temple of Indian democracy, Patnaik said MPs are the voice of Odisha in this tallest forum of democracy.

"The people of Odisha elected you in good faith to protect their interests. It is therefore a matter of utmost concern that you voted in favour of one of the most arbitrary legislations that will have far-reaching adverse implications for the people of Odisha who put their trust in you," the BJD chief said in the letter.

Government," Patnaik said in the letter.

He also said August 13, which saw the passage of the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026 in the



BJD president Naveen Patnaik

conscience and think about the future generations of Odisha. I appeal to you to challenge and call for a reversal of the amendment made in the MMDR Act that takes away the powers of the State

Goa police hunt for suspects who fired at casino director

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panaji

The Goa Police have launched a search to trace two unidentified men who allegedly opened fire at the director of a casino group outside his hotel in Porvorim, a senior officer said on Saturday.

The director escaped unhurt while his security personnel returned fire, police said, adding that the shooting occurred on Friday night outside a five-star property, located near the local police station.

The incident has prompted the opposition Congress to allege that law and order has collapsed in the



BJP-ruled State.

Chief Minister Pramod Sawant on Saturday said that those involved in the incident will not be spared.

Superintendent of Police (North Goa) Harishchandra Madkaikar said that two men fired three rounds at Srinivas

Nayak, director of Majestic Pride Hotels and Resorts at Porvorim, around 8.45 pm.

Nayak, who was sitting in his car along with his bodyguards, escaped unhurt, he said.

The CCTV footage from the location, which was made public, showed two men waiting near the hotel gate before firing three rounds at Nayak's car. Nayak escaped unhurt while his security personnel returned fire, forcing the assailants to flee.

A manhunt has been launched to apprehend the duo, Madkaikar added.

When contacted, Nayak said that he was unhurt and safe.

The Congress, meanwhile, claimed the incident

reflected the collapse of the law and order situation in the State.

"A firing incident reportedly took place just metres away from the Porvorim police station. If criminals can allegedly open fire in the vicinity of a police station, how safe is the common Goan?" Goa Congress chief Girish Chodankar said in a social media post.

CM Sawant said this is the first such incident during his tenure as the chief minister.

Banks to appeal NCLT approval of Subhash Chandra repayment plan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Days after the controversial NCLT Order favouring media baron Subhash Chandra, many lenders such as Union Bank of India (UK) Ltd, Canara Bank and LIC Housing Finance Ltd have decided to challenge the order reducing liability from more than ₹22,000 crore to just ₹6.25 crore. The controversial order came in a case filed by Indiabulls (now name changed as Sammaan Capital) against Subhash Chandra, from invoking personal guarantee against the loans to firms related to him.

These lenders will challenge the NCLT's decision in the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) as they are aggrieved by the former's decision, which gives them a recovery of just 0.03 per cent of their admitted dues. Referring to the matter of a personal insolvency case filed by Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd against Subhash Chandra, Union Bank of India, in a statement, said its wholly-owned UK subsidiary "along with other public sector undertakings



Subhash Chandra

like Canara Bank, LIC Housing Finance Ltd etc have rejected the resolution plan and pleaded before NCLT for not approving the same."

However, due to a majority vote of certain private creditors, the same plan has been approved by NCLT, it added. Now, Union Bank of India (UK) Ltd is immediately challenging the decision of NCLT before NCLAT, per the statement.

Canara Bank, in its statement, said the bank (1.60 per cent voting share), along with other public sector entities Union Bank of India (0.76 per

cent voting share) and LIC Housing Finance (6.09 per cent voting share), opposed and voted against the repayment plan submitted by Chandra for ₹6.25 crore. However, the repayment plan was approved by other private creditors with a majority vote (80.81 per cent voting share), it added.

"In fact, Canara Bank demanded a forensic audit, but the same could not be allowed in view of our minority voting share. The bank is filing an appeal in NCLAT against the NCLT order," the public sector bank said. LIC

Housing Finance Ltd, in its statement, noted that it and other public financial institutions, including Canara Bank and Union Bank of India (UK) Ltd., voted against the repayment plan proposed by Chandra. The plan was ultimately approved on account of the votes cast in favour of the repayment plan by the other financial creditors, aggregating to 80.81 per cent.

LIC HFL said it will immediately file an appeal before the NCLAT, along with the other public financial institutions. HDFC Bank was the first to come out with the statement challenging the order in NCLAT.

HDFC Bank, in its statement a couple of days back, observed that its admitted claim was only 3.2 per cent of the total stated claim amount. The bank inherited this facility, which was previously provided by HDFC Ltd.

Meanwhile, Subhash Chandra came out in the media, blaming Mukesh Ambani for attacking him through his media organisations by putting out "wrong stories". Reliance Industries rejected Chandra's allegations.

HDFC Bank CEO Jagdishan opts out of reappointment amid governance concerns

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

HDFC Bank's managing director and chief executive Sashidhar Jagdishan on Saturday opted out of being considered for reappointment after his current term ends on October 26, the largest private sector lender said in a regulatory filing.

Jagdishan, 61, will retire from the bank on October 26 after spending nearly three decades at the lender.

After taking over as the bank CEO in October 2020, Jagdishan is serving his second three-year term as the lender's head.

The HDFC Bank board will fast-track the process for selection and appointment of Jagdishan's successor "well within time", the exchange filing said.

He conveyed his decision not to seek reappointment as the Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer and also reiterated the decision despite "persuasion" from the board, it added.

"The board deeply appreciated his commitment, leadership, contribution to the growth and stability of the



HDFC Bank's CEO Sashidhar Jagdishan

Bank and his role in successful completion of one of the largest mergers in corporate India," the filing said.

It also conveyed best wishes to Jagdishan in his future endeavours.

Jagdishan took over as the CEO of the bank from Aditya Puri, who had led the bank since its founding in 1995.

Within months, it announced the merger of its mortgage major parent, HDFC, with itself, leading to huge expansion in the asset book and worries over business performance, HDFC liability payouts and compressed net interest margins of the combined entity.

The management, however, said the merger will accrue benefits over the long term.

The issue of Jagdishan's reappointment has been a subject of intense speculation, especially after the surprising resignation of non-executive chairman Atanu Chakraborty in March this year, citing concerns on ethics and governance practices at the lender.

In late July, the bank board found shortcomings in the deposit arrangements with the Maharashtra State Road Development Corporation (MSRDC) and also slapped a fine of Rs 1 lakh each on Jagdishan and other key

executives, even though it said that their actions were not mala fide.

It was alleged that the bank paid, over and above the card rate, for getting high-value deposits from the state-run body and routed them as marketing spends.

Besides, the bank has also faced allegations of mis-selling Credit Suisse's AT-1 bonds to diaspora clients from its Dubai DIFC branch, which led the local regulator to prohibit the bank from onboarding new customers or conducting new business last year.

In an interview after his sudden exit, Chakraborty rued that the bank did not act in time in the AT-1 bonds case, and compensation practices have to be in sync with value systems to ensure that any mis-selling does not happen.

There have also been reports of non-resident Indians being stuck with over USD 100 million in investments in a platform floated by Carlisle Asset Management sold as a high-yield product, but clients are unable to redeem their investments.

Finance ministry to begin preparing for Budget 2027-28 from October 12

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Finance Ministry will begin the exercise to prepare the Union Budget for 2027-28 from October 12 amid heightened global uncertainties and rising food and fuel prices.

The Budget for the next financial year is expected to focus on the reform continuation exercise to further accelerate economic growth, with measures to create jobs and boost domestic demand.

"Pre-budget meetings chaired by Secretary (Expenditure) shall commence from October 12, 2026. Financial Advisers shall ensure that necessary details... are properly entered in UBIS (Union Budget Information System) before/latest by October 6, 2026," Budget circular 2027-28 issued by the Department of Economic Affairs said.

Hard copies of the data in the specified formats should be submitted for cross-verification, it said.

It will be the fourth Budget of the Modi 3.0 Government



Niramala Sitharaman with senior finance ministry officials

FILE PHOTO

and the 10th straight Budget for Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, a rare distinction in Indian polity.

The circular further said that pre-budget meetings would commence from October 12, 2026, and continue till mid-November 2026.

The Budget Estimates for 2027-28, as well as Revised Estimates for 2026-27, will be provisionally finalised after completion of pre-Budget meetings, it added.

After detailed discussions in the pre-budget meetings, provisional expenditure ceilings will be indicated to the ministries/departments, it said.

Final expenditure ceilings will be decided by the ministry after factoring in the expenditure priorities and receipt projections of the Government, it said.

The final expenditure figures would be transmitted through and reflected in the UBIS latest by end-December 2026/early-January 2027, it added.

It further said that estimates of central taxes and duties, including surcharges and cesses, should be furnished by the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) and Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) to the Budget Division.

Temasek says supportive of Singapore Airlines' investments in Air India

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Singapore's sovereign wealth fund Temasek on Saturday said it supports Singapore Airlines' investments in Air India and highlighted that the Indian carrier's large-scale transformation involves complex, multi-year operational and integration challenges.

A statement from Temasek, which is a stakeholder in Singapore Airlines (SIA), comes against the backdrop of concerns raised in certain quarters about the carrier's investment in the loss-making Air India.

Singapore Airlines owns a 25.1 per cent stake in Air India, and the remaining shareholding is with Tata Sons, which acquired the Indian airline from the Government in January 2022.

In a statement on Saturday, Temasek said SIA has articulated its objective to invest in a second hub to secure long-term growth beyond Singapore.

"As the world's third-largest air transport market after the US and China, India is well-positioned to serve as this second hub. SIA has



long participated in the India market, including an operating presence through Vistara since 2013, and its investment in Air India allows it to deepen its participation in India's aviation growth," it said.

Temasek said that as a shareholder of SIA, "we view their business decision from a long-term perspective and are supportive of it".

Earlier this week in a social media post, Singapore's Member of Parliament Kenneth Tiong Boon Kiat cited a media report and flagged concerns about Singapore Airlines investing more in Air India.

"Air India has asked its owners for another \$1.5 billion. Singapore Airlines

owns about a quarter of it, and Temasek owns most of Singapore Airlines, so this is not only a question for private shareholders. Whichever of the two writes the cheque, it will have a significant impact on Temasek," he had said in a Facebook post.

Singapore Airlines Group's net profit dropped 57 per cent to SGD 1.184 billion (nearly ₹8,900 crore) in the fiscal year ended March 2026, mainly due to the absence of a prior-year one-off accounting gain related to the Vistara merger, and Air India losses.

Air India's loss stood at more than SGD 3.56 billion (over ₹26,700 crore) in the financial year ended March 2026, as the carrier grap-

pled with the fallout of airspace curbs and other headwinds.

Figures were disclosed by Singapore Airlines Group in its annual financial report for 2025-26, released in May. The rupee figures are based on the exchange rate of May 14.

Sources earlier this week said Air India is planning to seek additional funds to the tune of \$1.5 billion, which is over ₹14,000 crore at the current exchange rate.

On Saturday, Temasek also said it recognises that the large-scale transformation of Air India involves complex, multi-year operational and integration challenges.

"Efforts of this scale take time and are not expected to be linear, particularly in the aviation sector, where outcomes are shaped by industry developments, including aircraft innovation and fleet renewal cycles, and external factors such as airspace disruptions, geopolitical developments, and fuel price volatility," it said in the statement.

Meanwhile, on August 27, Singapore Airlines said its board will carefully consider Air India's any requests for

additional capital after taking into consideration the group's other capital requirements, as well as the Indian carrier's business strategy.

N Chandrasekaran, Chairman of Tata Sons and Air India in July, said Air India's transformation journey must be seen as a five-to-ten-year journey considering the years-long supply chain disruptions in key components, the need to overhaul the legacy systems, culture, fleet and creation of a large cadre of airline professionals.

Earlier this month, Chandrasekaran announced he would step down as Tata Sons Chairman when his current term ends in February 2027.

In the Facebook post earlier this week, Kenneth Tiong Boon Kiat also said that no one, least of all Singaporeans, owes Air India a living.

"I will not support, nor expect, any future use of Temasek's funds to prop up Air India via Singapore Airlines. If Singapore Airlines wants to continue its bet on Air India, it should do so on its own two feet, and not on Temasek's," he had said.

Argentina to ease market entry for Indian pharma sector, says Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Argentina has committed to reduce barriers to facilitate entry of Indian pharmaceutical sector in the South American nation, the Commerce Ministry said on Saturday.

This is expected to provide greater opportunities for Indian pharmaceutical companies and contribute to improving access to quality and affordable healthcare in Argentina, it said.

"Argentina has committed to work towards upgrad-



ing India from Annex II to Annex I under its pharmaceutical regulatory framework and reducing barriers to entry," it added.

The issue came up for discussions during the visit of Commerce Secretary Rajesh

Agarwal to Buenos Aires this week.

He was in the country for the India-Argentina Joint Trade Committee (JTC), which was held on August 24, 2026 at Palacio San Martin, Buenos Aires.

Geopolitical issues may slow Noida airport ramp-up: Zurich Airport

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Noida International Airport is expected to see a "slower ramp-up" due to a challenging geopolitical environment, and near-term performance is subject to elevated uncertainty, according to its operator, Zurich Airport International AG.

The airport, located in Jewar, Uttar Pradesh, started operations on June 15, handling 1,044 flights and 77,000 passengers in July.

In June, Noida International Airport handled 204 flights and



Noida International Airport

25,000 passengers.

"Slower ramp-up expected due to challenging geopolitical environment, with near-term performance remaining subject to elevated uncertainty," Zurich Airport International said in its investor presentation for the first half of 2026.

After Bombay HC rap, FDA withdraws licence cancellation and suspension orders against Cipla and MCA eateries

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court on Saturday dealt a double blow to the Maharashtra FDA, forcing the regulator to backtrack on two major enforcement actions after being admonished for acting against the "principles of natural justice" and taking a "pedantic instead of pragmatic view."

Pulling up the FDA for showing "undue haste" in passing orders without analysing the law in connection with eateries on the Mumbai Cricket Association premises, the high court asked: "Do you feel you are a Lord and you can do anything?"

In the first instance, the FDA withdrew its order cancelling the



Bombay High Court

drug sale licence of Cipla Pharma and Life Sciences Limited's unit in Pune after a bench of Acting Chief Justice Ravindra Ghuge and Justice Gautam Ankhad scolded the regulator for going "overboard" and behaving in a "high-handed" manner.

In a separate setback for the agency, the FDA informed the court that it would also withdraw its order suspending the operations of five restaurants at the MCA premises in Bandra-Kurla Complex after the court warned of stinging orders against officials, noting that a fresh inspection showed the eateries were 88 per cent compliant with food safety rules.

However, the licences of eateries remained suspended as they were being operated by another entity, M/s Shirke Infrastructure, despite the licences being issued in MCA's name.

The court said there is no provision under the law prohibiting the same, noting that on the last hearing the court had specifically

asked the FDA officials to apply their mind and take a pragmatic view of the situation.

"However, despite clearly saying this, the FDA has disobeyed our order and taken a pedantic view instead of a pragmatic view. We are tired of scolding the department and officers all the time. It is now time to pass stinging orders. We will issue contempt action against the concerned officers. Let them convince us or go to jail," the HC said.

When warned of contempt action, the FDA said it would issue a fresh notice to MCA and grant them a hearing on the issue of the contract between the association and Shirke Infrastructure and then pass a reasoned order.

कार्यालय, अधिशासी अभियन्ता, अनुरक्षण शाखा (गंगा)

उत्तराखण्ड जल संस्थान, जगजीतपुर, हरिद्वार – 249408

जल संवर्धन – जीवन संचय

ई-मेल – eegangaujs@gmail.com, eeganga-ujs-uk@nic.in

पत्रांक : 987 / निविदा सूचना / 2026-2027

ई-निविदा सूचना

दिनांक – 27.08.2026

मुख्य महाप्रबन्धक, महोदय उत्तराखण्ड जल संस्थान देहरादून की ओर से कार्यालय अधिशासी अभियन्ता उत्तराखण्ड जल संस्थान, अनुरक्षण शाखा, (गंगा) जगजीतपुर हरिद्वार, के अन्तर्गत माननीय मुख्यमंत्री द्वारा की गयी घोषणाओं के क्रम में निम्नानुसार कार्यों हेतु उत्तराखण्ड जल संस्थान / उत्तराखण्ड पेयजल निगम में सीवर लाइन सम्बन्धी कार्यों के अन्तर्गत निम्नलिखित श्रेणी के पंजीकृत ठेकेदार / फर्मों को ई-निविदा, दू-बिड सिस्टम के आधार पर ई-निविदा निम्नानुसार आमंत्रित की जाती हैं :-

क्र० सं०	कार्य विवरण	घरोहर धनराशि (लाख में)	कार्य की समाप्ति	बिड सिस्टम	निविदा मूल्य	पंजीकृत श्रेणी
1	जनपद हरिद्वार की हरिद्वार गंगा शाखा में मा० मुख्यमंत्री घोषणा सं० 749 / 2025 के अन्तर्गत जोन तृतीय ज्वालापुर में विभिन्न स्थानों पर सीवर लाईनों के प्रतिस्थापन के कार्य हेतु प्राकलन (नगरीय)	8,18,000.00	04 माह	दू-बिड	5000.00+18% (जी.एस.टी.)	बी श्रेणी या उच्चतर
2	जनपद हरिद्वार की हरिद्वार गंगा शाखा में मा० मुख्यमंत्री घोषणा सं० 748 / 2025 के अन्तर्गत जोन द्वितीय कनखल में विभिन्न स्थानों पर सीवर लाईनों 150 एमएम और 200 एमएम व्यास सीवर लाईनों के प्रतिस्थापन के कार्य हेतु प्राकलन (नगरीय)	7,60,400.00	04 माह	दू-बिड	5000.00+18% (जी.एस.टी.)	
3	जनपद हरिद्वार की हरिद्वार गंगा शाखा में मा० मुख्यमंत्री घोषणा सं० 747 / 2025 के अन्तर्गत जोन प्रथम भोपतवाला में विभिन्न स्थानों पर स्थित क्षतिग्रस्त एवं कम व्यास की सीवर लाईनों के प्रतिस्थापन के कार्य हेतु प्राकलन (नगरीय)	9,64,800.00	04 माह	दू-बिड	5000.00+18% (जी.एस.टी.)	
4	जनपद हरिद्वार की हरिद्वार गंगा शाखा में मा० मुख्यमंत्री घोषणा सं० 436 / 2026 के अन्तर्गत जोन तृतीय ज्वालापुर में विभिन्न स्थानों पर सीवर लाईनों के प्रतिस्थापन के कार्य हेतु प्राकलन (नगरीय)	3,14,100.00	04 माह	दू-बिड	5000.00+18% (जी.एस.टी.)	

Sl. No	Details of Tender Activity	Date Of Activity
1	Date of Tender	27.08.2026
2	Date of online Publication of tender Notice and tender document	01.09.2026
3	Online Document download: Start Date	01.09.2026
4	Online Document download: End Date	14.09.2026
5	Pre Bid Meeting	08.09.2026
6	Physical Submission of Bid Security, cost of bid Document and offline Submission of bid Documents :End Date	15.09.2026
7	Date of online Technical Bid Opening	16.09.2026
8	Date of online Financial Bid Opening	Date will be announced later on after Technical Bid opening.

ई-निविदा से सम्बन्धित समस्त जानकारीयां व शर्तें उत्तराखण्ड की वेबसाइट www.uktenders.gov.in पर ऑन लाइन देखी / प्राप्त की जा सकती हैं।

अधिशासी अभियन्ता

FROM THE WORLD

USA

Trump claims Venezuela oil

President Donald Trump said the US has entered an agreement with Venezuela to take control of 65 billion barrels of the South American country's oil reserves. Trump in a social media post announced the agreement he said was negotiated by Secretary of State Marco Rubio, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth and Venezuela's interim President Delcy Rodriguez.

The announcement of the deal comes nearly nine months after the US military at Trump's direction carried out an operation to capture Venezuela's president and spirit him to the United States to face federal narcoterrorism and drug trafficking charges. (AP)

CANADA

Reverses 9/11 terrorism policy

Canada's public broadcaster said Friday it is making an exception to its policy of not labelling specific attacks as terrorism for the 9/11 attacks after coming under fire over a memo restating it.

Like other news outlets including The Associated Press, CBC/Radio-Canada's standards normally don't allow reporters to describe events as terrorist attacks unless they are quoting someone else's words. (AP)

Nepal digs through mud and grief, as families search for loved ones

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kathmandu

People lined up outside hospitals, looking through photographs of the dead pasted on walls; families wading through mud and debris in search of their possessions; a woman carrying a child past damaged buildings; and a dead dog lying amid the wreckage. These are some of the stark images that have come to define the aftermath of Nepal's devastating flash floods.

With each passing day, relatives of those missing lose a little more hope, even as rescuers battle difficult conditions in the search for survivors. Nepal is struggling to find its footing after a torrent of water, mud and debris swept through towns and villages on Wednesday, washing away homes, vehicles, roads, bridges and damaging hydropower projects, causing heavy casualties.

The death toll crossed 650 on Saturday, while more than 2,400 people remained missing, as rescue teams raced against time amid intermittent rainfall in the flood-affected regions.

Outside hospitals, families could be seen lining up to check lists of injured people admitted for treatment, carefully going through names and photographs in the hope of finding someone they know. When they fail to find their loved ones among the survivors, many turn to another list – photographs of the dead – with heavy hearts. Rescuers, meanwhile, are working round the clock, braving rain in some places and digging through drying



People stand amid mud and debris outside damaged structures in the aftermath of devastating flash floods in Dhading district, Nepal

mud in others in their search for those still missing.

In the darkness of the night, Nepal Home Minister Sudan Gurung monitored excavators clearing tonnes of mud at the Upper Trishuli 3A hydropower project site, where more than a hundred people were trapped inside a tunnel following the devastating floods.

The Nepali Army has already rescued 350 people who were trapped inside the tunnel, online Khabar news portal reported.

The scale of the devastation was visible across villages in central Nepal, with buildings buried under

several feet of mud, vehicles half-submerged, and roads and other infrastructure washed away by the torrent of water and debris.

For those who survived, the immediate task is to find shelter, seek medical assistance and recover whatever belongings can be salvaged from the wreckage.

Heart-wrenching scenes have emerged from the affected villages.

In Devighat village in Nuwakot district, people moved through thick mud and debris in search of their possessions. Damaged structures and uprooted electricity poles stood amid the

wreckage, while vehicles remained buried in the mud.

A woman sat beside scattered corn, while another, carrying a child, walked past damaged structures and a dead dog. A man carrying a gas cylinder made his way through the debris-covered area – the only belonging he could salvage from the wreckage. An aerial view showed damaged structures stretching alongside a swollen river, underlining the scale of destruction caused by the floods.

In Trishuli, an Army relief camp has emerged as a major support centre for people affected by the disaster. Army personnel were seen helping elderly people and children, while makeshift medical facilities treated the injured. The camps were also providing information on those missing, dead and rescued. More than 15,000 security personnel have been mobilised for search and rescue operations. An 11-member Indian team comprising medical personnel and tunnel rescue experts also arrived in Nepal to assist local authorities.

Around 4,500 people have been rescued so far, Nepal's Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal said on Saturday, adding that the country remains on "high alert". With the country's meteorology department indicating the possibility of moderate rainfall, the task facing rescuers is expected to become even more difficult.

Yet, for a country that has faced similar disasters before, the focus remains on searching for the missing, helping the survivors and beginning the long task of rebuilding.

PM Modi begins visit to Uzbekistan and Kyrgyzstan, eyes deeper ties

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi began a two-nation visit to Uzbekistan and Kyrgyzstan on August 29, 2026, with New Delhi seeking to deepen strategic, economic and security cooperation with key partners in Central Asia.

Before his departure, Modi said he was confident that his engagements during the visit would further strengthen India's partnerships in the region. His tour will begin in Tashkent, where he is scheduled to meet Uzbek President Shavkat Mirziyoyev for bilateral discussions on August 29 and 30. He will then travel to Bishkek to attend the 26th Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit on August 31 and September 1. Modi described his Uzbekistan programme as an opportunity to further advance the longstanding friendship between the two countries. He is also scheduled to visit the Lal Bahadur Shastri Memorial and the Mahatma Gandhi Centre at Tashkent State University of Oriental Studies.

The India-Uzbekistan relationship has historical roots stretching back centuries. India was among the first countries to recognise Uzbekistan as a sovereign state following its independence. Diplomatic relations were formally established on March 18, 1992, while the two countries elevated their relationship to a Strategic Partnership in 2011.

Modi has previously visited Uzbekistan in 2015, 2016 and 2022. Mirziyoyev travelled to India in 2018 and 2019. The two leaders last



PM Narendra Modi during his two-days visit to Uzbekistan in Tashkent

met in person on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit in Kazan in October 2024 and spoke by telephone in August 2025.

Economic cooperation is expected to be a major focus of the visit. India and Uzbekistan are working to expand bilateral trade, which currently stands at around \$1.5 billion. Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal has said the two sides aim to raise trade to approximately \$3 billion within the next three years, while also exploring the possibility of a free trade agreement.

Indian exports to Uzbekistan include pharmaceuticals, machinery, vehicle components, mobile phones and optical equipment. Uzbekistan supplies India with products including fruits and vegetables, fertilisers, extracts and lubricants. Investment opportunities are also expanding. Uzbekistan has encouraged Indian companies to explore sectors such as mining, metallurgy, chemicals, energy, pharmaceuticals, automobiles and digital infrastructure. Cooperation in critical minerals, healthcare, information technology and emerging technologies is

gaining importance.

Around 400 Indian companies are reportedly operating in Uzbekistan, with projects worth more than \$5 billion, highlighting the growing commercial relationship. Security and defence will also feature prominently in the bilateral relationship. India and Uzbekistan established a Joint Working Group on defence in 2019 and have strengthened military cooperation through regular exchanges and exercises.

The two countries conduct the joint military exercise DUSTLIK, aimed at improving interoperability and sharing operational experience. The sixth edition of the exercise was held in India in April 2025.

With an estimated Indian community of about 18,500 people in Uzbekistan—including students, workers and business professionals—the visit is also expected to reinforce people-to-people ties.

Modi's participation in the SCO Summit in Bishkek will provide an additional platform for discussions on regional security, connectivity, trade and cooperation among Central Asian and other member States.

I knew I was going to die: Eyewitnesses recall the terror of Nepal's flash floods

SHIRISH B PRADHAN
■ Kathmandu

At first, Dipak Tamang thought the ground was shaking. Then he saw a wall of water, mud and stones

racing towards the houses along the Bhotekoshi river in Timure market, and realised there was nowhere to go but up. Survivors of the floods have described scenes of extraordinary terror – des-

perate climbs towards higher ground, homes collapsing around them and people being swept away as torrents of water, mud and debris tore through towns and villages, washing away

everything on its way, on Wednesday. The death toll crossed 650 on Saturday, while more than 2,400 people remained missing. Nearly 2,500 people were evacuated as rescue teams raced against time amid intermittent rainfall in the flood-affected regions.

For some, survival came down to a desperate race uphill. Others watched helplessly as friends and loved ones were swept away.

People who reached the affected areas later found markets buried in mud and families searching for missing relatives. (PTI)

**SOUTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**
Follow us on [e-Procurement](#)
Details of the Tender Notices of S.C Railway can be seen on our website - [www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in](#)

TENDER NOTICE No. 23/2026
Dt.28.08.2026.
SUPPLY OF STORES ITEMS e-Procurement Tender Notice

The Following Tenders Have Been Floated Online. Tenders Are Requested To Visit The Website [www.ireps.gov.in](#) And Submit Their Offers Online. The Tender Description, Qty, EMD, SD May Be Seen In Website. Offers Submitted Manually Will Not Be Accepted. Offers By Post Will Not Be Entertained. Tender Closing Time Is 14.30 Hrs Of The Due Date Of The Tender. "For All Indigenous Offers, EMD Will Be Accepted Only Via Online System As Available On [www.ireps.gov.in](#)."

Tender No.	Brief Description
LT256166A	Design, Supply, installation & commissioning of Hydraulic jacks provided with control stand & Power pack mounted on 04-wheeler Battery operated platform truck of 03T Capacity
LT265850	Supply and installation of Automatic fire alarm and fire aspiration system comply with RDSO Specification No. RDSO/ SPN/ 217/ 2025, Version 3.1 or the latest applicable version at 50 stations/ locations over SC Division
46267002	107 SQMM Silver bearing Grooved copper contact wire
29265012	Coupling Socket Assembly with Locking Arrangement
82262704	Coronary Intravascular Lithotripsy Catheter, 80 PLS Sizes: 2.50, 2.75, 3.00, 3.25, 3.50, 3.75 and 4.00 mm
43261072A	Disconnecting and Earthing Device, 8 pole, 2 Way
56261004	PVC Insulated, armoredsignaling cable (copper conductor) sixize 2 core x 2.5 sq.mm
91261125	Aluminium Chequered Sheet 2.03x813x2960 mm.
Note:-Due dates of Tender Opening: SL.No.01 on dt.10.09.2026. SL.No.02 & 03 on dt.15.09.2026 SL.No.04 on dt.17.09.2026 SL.No.05 on dt. 18.09.2026 SL.No.06 & 07 on dt 21.09.2026. S.L.No.08 on dt.26.10.2026.	
Beside Above Mentioned Tenders There Are Other Tenders Having Value Above Rs.50 Lakhs. For Details, Please Visit Railway Website Above.	
Principal Chief Materials Manager/Secunderabad	
For further tender conditions / details and for downloading the tender documents, Please visit website at https://www.ireps.gov.in or www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in	

**LOVELY TEACHER'S TRAINING INSTITUTE**
Priyadarshini Vihar, Delhi-92
ADMISSION NOTICE

Management Quota seats are available for those who applied for admission of D.El.Ed. / D.P.S.E. course as per SCERT norms and guidelines for 2026-2028, may apply on the prescribed admission form available in the institute w.e.f. 27/08/2026 to 10/09/2026 between 10.00 AM to 4.00 PM

MANAGER

**PUBLIC NOTICE**

I, Chirag Jain S/o Shri Dhanpat Jain R/o B-239, Surajmal Vihar, Delhi-110092, have lost the I) original GPA executed by Smt. Sheela Bahuguna in favour of Shri Prem Kumar duly registered as Doc. No.2306, in Addl. Book No.4, Vol.No.7040, at pages 95 to 96, dated 15/01/2001, in the office of Sub-Registrar IV, Delhi and ii) original GPA executed by Shri Prem Kumar in favour of Smt. Komal Gupta duly registered as Doc. No.14569, in Addl. Book No.4, Vol.No.7171, at pages 125 to 126, dated 04/04/2001, in the office of Sub-Registrar IV, Delhi, related to my Shop No.G-1, on Ground Floor, in Pankaj Plaza, constructed on Commercial Plot No.7, at LSC, A-Block, Suraj Mal Vihar, Delhi-110092. I have lodged a complaint in this regard vide LR No.560487/2026, dated 22/08/2026, P.S. Anand Vihar/e-Police Station, Delhi.

**DIRECTORATE Uttarakhand Agriculture Produce Marketing Board**
Mandi Bhawan, Rudrapur (U.S.Nagar) Ph:05944-250056 Fax: 05944-50059

Ref: U.K.A.P.M.B./2026/1415 Date: 29.08.2026

Public Information

Uttarakhand Agriculture Produce Marketing Board, Rudrapur is Inviting Auction of land in Bhurarani Rudrapur and to be given on lease rent.

Applying process and other related information and conditions may be seen on [https://www.procofox.com](#) from 31.08.2026 on 12:00 noon to 17.09.2026 till 5:00 pm.

Interested persons and firms may visit at [https://www.procofox.com](#) for further necessary action.

General Manager (Finance)

**DIRECTORATE Uttarakhand Agriculture Produce Marketing Board**
Mandi Bhawan, Rudrapur (U.S.Nagar) Ph:05944-250056 Fax: 05944-50059

Ref: U.K.A.P.M.B./2026/1414 Date: 29.08.2026

Public Information

Uttarakhand Agriculture Produce Marketing Board, Rudrapur is Inviting Auction of land in Bhurarani Rudrapur and to be given on lease rent.

Applying process and other related information and conditions may be seen on [https://www.procofox.com](#) from 31.08.2026 on 12:00 noon to 17.09.2026 till 5:00 pm.

Interested persons and firms may visit at [https://www.procofox.com](#) for further necessary action.

General Manager (Finance)

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM | অসম চৰকাৰ
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER | মুখ্য অভিযন্তাৰ কাৰ্যালয়::
PWD BUILDING | লোক নিৰ্মাণ (গৃহ) বিভাগ::
ASSAM:: GUWAHATI | অসম :: গুৱাহাটী-৩

No. CEB/CS/TB-IV(B)/01/2026/14

PRESS NOTICE
নিবিদ্যা আহ্বান কৰা জাননী

The Chief Engineer, PWD (Building), Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-03 on behalf of the Governor of Assam, invites fresh bid for the work detailed in the table below, from eligible Firm/Contractor of repute having experience in similar nature of work. Details of bid may be seen at e-procurement portal i.e. [www.assamtenders.gov.in](#)

The bidders must be enrolled with e-tendering web portal [www.assamtenders.gov.in](#)

মুখ্য অভিযন্তা, লোক নিৰ্মাণ (গৃহ) বিভাগ, অসম, চান্দমাৰি, গুৱাহাটী-০৩ এ অসমৰ ৰাজ্যপালৰ হৈ, তলত উল্লেখিত কামৰ বাবে একে ধৰণৰ কামৰ অভিজ্ঞতা থকা যোগ্য ফাৰ্ম/টিকাদাৰৰ পৰা নিবিদ্যা আহ্বান কৰিছে। নিবিদ্যাৰ সবিশেষ ই-টেন্ডিং পৰ্টেল অৰ্থাৎ [www.assamtenders.gov.in](#) ত চাব পাৰিব।

নিবিদ্যাকাৰীসকলে ই-টেন্ডিং ৱেব পৰ্টেল [www.assamtenders.gov.in](#) ৰ জৰিয়তে নামভৰ্তি কৰিব লাগিব।

Sl. No. ক্ৰমিক নম্বৰ	Name of work কামৰ নাম	Approx. Value of work (In Rs) কামৰ আনুমানিক মূল্য (টোকাত)	Bid Security নিবিদ্যা নিৰিদ্ধা সুৰক্ষা জমা	Bid Processing Fee (in Rs) নিবিদ্যা প্ৰক্ৰিয়াকৰণ মাফুল (টোকাত)	Completion period কাৰ্য সমাপ্তিৰ সময়সীমা
1.	Construction of Cultural Complex of Shankardev Shishu Niketan at Hajongbari, Kamrup (Metro), Assam: Phase II	4,68,58,970.00	2 % for General category or 1 % for Reserved category on value of work	9372.00	12 (Twelve) Months
১.	অসমৰ কামৰূপ (মেট্ৰো) জিলাৰ হাজংবাৰীত শিশু নিকেতন সাংস্কৃতিক প্ৰকল্প নিৰ্মাণ: দ্বিতীয় পৰ্যায়	৪,৬৮,৫৮,৯৭০.০০	সাধাৰণ শ্ৰেণীৰ বাবে কামৰ মূল্যৰ ২% বা সংৰক্ষিত শ্ৰেণীৰ বাবে কামৰ মূল্যৰ ১ %	৯৩৭২.০০	১২ (বাৰ) মাহ

Note টোকা:
(i) The value of work may change during uploading of DNIT for which no claim will be entertained. ডিএনআইটি আপলোড কৰাৰ সময়ত কামৰ মূল্য সলনি হ'ব পাৰে যাৰ বাবে কোনো দাবী গ্ৰহণ কৰা নহ'ব।
(ii) The Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Documents. নিবিদ্যা আহ্বান কৰা জাননী নিবিদ্যা নথিপত্ৰৰ অংশ হ'ব।

Chief Engineer, PWD (Building), Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-03
মুখ্য অভিযন্তা, লোক নিৰ্মাণ (গৃহ) বিভাগ, অসম, চান্দমাৰি, গুৱাহাটী-০৩

DIPR/C/PIO/121/30-Aug-26

**MEDICAMEN ORGANICS LIMITED**
Corporate Identity Number (CIN): L74899DL1995PLC066416
Regd. Office: 10, Community Centre No. 2, Ashok Vihar Phase II, New Delhi, Delhi – 110052, Ph. No 011-27430249
Website: [www.medicamenorganics.com](#), Email ID: [cs@mediorganics.in](#)

INFORMATION REGARDING THE 31st ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING TO BE HELD THROUGH VIDEO CONFERENCING / OTHER AUDIO-VISUAL MEANS

Dear Members,

1. Notice is hereby given that the 31st (Thirty-First) Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of the Members of Medicamen Organics Limited ("Company") will be held through Video Conferencing/Other Audio Visual Means ("VC/OAVM") on Friday, September 25, 2026 at 11:00 A.M. (IST), to transact the businesses as set out in the Notice of AGM, in compliance with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 ("Act") and the rules made thereunder, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("Listing Regulations") read with all the applicable circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA") and Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI") for convening general meetings through VC/OAVM. The members can attend and participate in the AGM through VC/OAVM, without their physical presence at a common venue. The members joining the AGM through VC/OAVM shall be counted for the purpose of reckoning the quorum under Section 103 of the Act.

2. In compliance with the Circulars, electronic copies of the Notice convening the AGM along with explanatory statement pursuant to Section 102 of the Act and Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26, shall be sent within the prescribed timelines by e-mail to all those members whose email IDs are registered with the Company/Depository Participant(s). The Notice of the AGM along with Annual Report shall also be available on the website of the Company at [www.medicamenorganics.com](#), the website of the stock exchange where the equity shares of the Company are listed, i.e. National Stock Exchange of India Limited ("NSE") at [www.nseindia.com](#) and website of KFin Technologies Limited, Registrar and Share Transfer Agent of the Company ("KFinTech" or "RTA") at [www.kfintech.com](#).

3. In terms of applicable regulatory provisions, the Company will be providing Members, the facility to cast their votes using an electronic voting system from a place other than the venue of AGM ("remote e-voting"), to participate in the AGM through VC/OAVM and to electronically cast their votes during the AGM ("e-voting") and for the same, the Company has engaged the services of Kfintech.

The facility for e-voting will be made available at the AGM to the Members who have not cast their vote(s) by remote e-voting.

The detailed procedure for casting the votes through remote e-voting/e-voting and manner for attending the AGM through VC/OAVM shall be provided in the Notice of the AGM. The details shall also be made available on the website of the Company.

4. Members holding shares in dematerialized form are requested to register/update their Bank account details and Contact details including e-mail IDs with their relevant Depository Participant(s).

5. This Notice is being issued for the information and benefit of all the Members of the Company in compliance with applicable circulars of MCA and SEBI.

For Medicamen Organics Limited
Sd/-
Divya Sharma
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer
Membership No.: A43980

Date: August 29, 2026
Place: New Delhi

Nepal's public, private sectors donate crores for relief

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kathmandu

Nepal's public sector, private companies and individuals have pledged millions of rupees to the disaster relief fund as the Himalayan nation continues its fight against one of its worst natural disasters that has killed over 600 people.

Nepal is struggling to find its footing after a massive flash flood swept through towns and villages on Wednesday, washing away homes, vehicles, roads and bridges, besides damaging hydropower projects.

The death toll crossed 600 on Saturday, while more than 2,400 people remained missing. Nearly 2,500 people, including 163 foreigners, were evacuated as rescue teams raced against time amid intermittent rainfall in flood-affected regions. Nepal's private companies, banks, insurers and individual donors have decided to contribute to the disaster relief fund to help victims, The Kathmandu Post reported. The contributions to the Prime Minister's Disaster Relief Fund will help authorities treat the injured and provide food and shelter to families displaced by the disaster.

Heavy gunfire, blasts shake Niger’s capital

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Niamey

Heavy gunfire and explosions were heard overnight into Saturday morning in Niger’s capital of Niamey, including near the main airport and in an area housing the presidential palace, according to an *Associated Press* witness and local media.

Sustained gunfire began past midnight at the premises of the Diori Hamani International Airport, which hosts a major military base, according to an AP witness who requested anonymity for safety reasons.

It is the third time this year the airport has experienced unrest. Local media also



reported gunshots ringing out from the Plateau administrative district, where the Presidential Palace and key institutions are located.

The ruling military council, known as the National Council for the Safeguard of the Homeland, said the military has been deployed.

Let us remain united, vigilant and supportive,” it said in a Facebook post. It was not immediately clear what caused the gunfire and explosions although a local lawmaker called it a “cowardly attack.”

The airport area had been attacked twice by jihadis in recent months as pressure mounts on Niger’s struggling military junta.

SOLDIERS ATTEMPTED PREDAWN MUTINY, SAYS DEFENCE MINISTER

Niamey: A group of soldiers in Niger rebelled against officers at a key military base and shot at “sensitive” locations in the capital city of Niamey in an apparent mutiny that resulted in gunfire and explosions, authorities said on Saturday.

Niger’s Defence Minister Gen Salifou Mody said there had been a “break with the discipline and military regulations.”

He said soldiers attempted to rebel against officers at the base and shot at “sensitive sites”



before authorities regained control of the situation. (AP)

Artemis II astronauts receive highest US space honour



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Washington

The Artemis II astronauts who flew around the moon earlier this year received the nation’s highest space honour on Friday.

President Donald Trump presented the Congressional Space Medal of Honour to the three Americans and one Canadian whose April lunar flyby set a new distance record for humanity.

NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman and other dignitaries took part in the packed ceremony at Houston’s Johnson Space Centre, home to Mission Control. Trump used the occasion to announce the creation of a US Space Academy for the Space Force as well as NASA and the commercial space community. “Space is the hot thing,” the

president told the crowd, adding that the academy’s location has yet to be determined.

Commander Reid Wiseman, pilot Victor Glover, Christina Koch and Canada’s Jeremy Hansen became the first astronauts to travel to the moon in more than half a century, coming within 4,067 miles (6,545 kilometres) while test-driving NASA’s new Orion capsule. They were the first to launch aboard NASA’s new moon rocket, a 30-story behemoth that had soared only once before from Florida’s Kennedy Space Centre. While they didn’t stop at the moon, the four set the stage for next year’s Artemis III docking rehearsal in orbit around Earth. Artemis IV’s moon landing by two astronauts, near the lunar south pole, could follow as soon as 2028.

27 dead in head-on minibus, truck crash in Zimbabwe

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Harare

A collision between a minibus taxi carrying church members and a haulage truck killed 27 people on Friday in Zimbabwe, a police spokesperson said, in the latest road disaster to hit the southern African country.

Paul Nyathi, the police spokesperson, said on Saturday that members of a popular indigenous African Christian denomination, known for wearing white robes, were travelling for a conference when the minibus taxi collided head-on with the truck Friday night.

The truck was trying to overtake another vehicle when it crashed with the minibus taxi on a major highway near Chivhu town, 132 kilometres (82 miles) south of the capital, Harare, Nyathi said in a statement.State-run broadcaster ZBC News, citing a provincial gov-

ernment minister, said 23 people died at the scene, while others succumbed to their injuries after being admitted to a local hospital.

The minibus taxi burst into flames and was reduced to a shell following the collision, according to local media, which published pictures of the wreckage. Nyathi said both vehicles were carrying an “unspecified” number of passengers.

Road accidents involving crowded buses, minibus taxis and unregulated sedan taxis are common in Zimbabwe and are often blamed on dangerous driving and poor road conditions.

Zimbabwe is among the countries with the worst road safety records, with 94 per cent of road accidents attributed to human error, according to authorities.

Across Africa, road crashes kill about 300,000 people annually, roughly a quarter of the global toll,



according to the United Nations Economic Commission for Africa, which says the continent has the world’s highest road fatality rate.

This is despite the continent of 1.5 billion people accounting for just about 3 per cent of the global vehicle fleet. (AP)

Colorado river water cuts leave cities and farmers in doubt

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Phoenix

On the outskirts of Phoenix, a small town with a huge reliance on the Colorado River has capped growth, revived old wells and struck water deals.

But Cave Creek Mayor Robert Morris can’t shake the real possibility that it’s not enough to keep the desert community of about 5,000 people afloat well into the future. And a recent federal plan to address a deepening crisis in the river basin won’t help.

Cave Creek gets nearly all of its water from the river, which serves 40 million people across the US West and has been dwindling because of climate change, demand and overuse. The town already was forced to make cuts this year, and it stands to lose more under a new federal plan.

Morris likened the situation to planning for a meteor strike. “You can see it coming, but you can’t get out of the way, and you don’t know what the damage is going to be,” he said.

The uncertainty stretches across seven US states, tribal nations and Mexico. Farmers are deciding which crops are worth the investment. Phoenix could lose some municipal and industrial water for the first time and turn to backup supplies. And residents could face even more costly water.

Nevada raised the stakes this week by suing the Interior Department and the US Bureau of Reclamation, saying basic needs in the Las Vegas region will go unmet if the area has to absorb planned reductions of up to 70 per cent of its Colorado River water in the next decade. The bureau said Thursday it does not comment on litigation.



Death toll following Russian attack on Ukraine’s Kyiv region rises to 37

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kyiv

At least 37 people have been killed following a Russian attack on the Bucha district, close to the Ukrainian capital of Kyiv, officials said Saturday.

Tymur Tkachenko, head of the local regional military administration, said that at least 50 residential buildings had been damaged in the attack, which also sparked a large-scale fire that spread to homes and a restaurant. In a statement, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said that a warehouse had been struck in the village of Myla “followed by a detonation.” He did not give details on the site, but wrote in the same message that criminal proceedings had been opened on charges of official negligence. “There are regula-



tions in place – ammunition cannot be stored near homes or other residential areas,” Zelenskyy said.

The Ukrainian leader wrote that a care home for elderly people and people with disabilities and residential buildings were damaged.

“More than 370 people have

already been evacuated, and the evacuation is ongoing,” he said.

“Unfortunately, we can already see that the terrible tragedy in Vyshneve did not become a lesson,” Koretskyi said. “In the fifth year of a full-scale invasion, making the same mistakes is criminal negligence. And all those guilty, without exception, must be severely punished so that such situations do not happen again.”

In a statement, Russia’s Ministry of Defense said that it had hit a warehouse in Myla storing components and launch boosters for long-range drones. It also said that it had attacked the ports of Mykolaiv and Izmail, as well as a logistics center and warehouse facilities storing parts for Ukraine’s Flamingo cruise missiles in the Kyiv region.

Munir visits Pak’s largest defence factory

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan’s army chief Field Marshal Asim Munir on Saturday visited the country’s largest defence industrial complex to see its production and export capabilities.

Pakistan Ordnance Factory (POF) in Wah is located about 41 km west of capital Islamabad.

According to a statement by the army, Munir’s visit to “Pakistan’s largest defence industrial complex”, focused on reviewing production capabilities, export potential and contributions towards the country’s defence industrial base.

During the visit, he was briefed on various aspects of POF’s operations and its role in strengthening national defence through the indigenous development and production of a diverse range of military equipment.He also witnessed



the tests and trials of locally designed and manufactured arms and ammunition, highlighting POF’s commitment to innovation, self-reliance and enhancing Pakistan’s defence production capabilities, according to the state-

ment. Munir was also apprised about the ongoing indigenisation and upgradation efforts through the installation of two new industrial plants, which are likely to commence production by the end of current year. (PTI)

Ex-Ecuador President gets 5 years for bribery

GONZALO SOLANO ■ Quito

Former Ecuadorian President Lenin Moreno was sentenced Friday to 5 years in prison after a court found him guilty of accepting bribes from a Chinese company in exchange for helping it secure a contract to build a hydroelectric plant.

Moreno, who was present for the reading of the verdict, is 73 years old and has a physical disability that prevents him from walking. He will serve the sentence under house arrest.

Moreno was convicted as a direct participant in the bribery scheme during his tenure as vice president under Rafael Correa. His wife and daughter, two brothers and a brother-in-law were convicted as accomplices. The wife and daughter each received 30-month sentences.

Moreno is the third former Ecuadorian president to be sentenced for corruption, though he was tried for crimes before reaching the presidency. Correa was sentenced in 2020 to eight years in prison in a bribery case involving Brazilian construction giant Odebrecht but remains in Belgium, where he has lived for years. Former President Jamil Mahuad was also sentenced in 2014 to eight



Former Ecuadorian President Lenin Moreno

years for misuse of public funds. Another former president, Abdala Bucaram, is awaiting sentencing after being convicted of organised crime.

Prosecutors said a corruption network operated from 2008 to 2018, collecting bribes equal to 4 per cent of the value of the project carried out by Sinohydro. They said the money was distributed through domestic and international transactions to public officials and other beneficiaries, including Moreno. (AP)

FM Sitharaman invites global investors to build manufacturing and tech hubs in India

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman invited global investors to set up manufacturing bases, and technology and innovation centres in India, urging them to leverage talent and opportunity to build for the world.

Addressing a high-level Business Roundtable with leading investors and business leaders in Chicago on Friday, Sitharaman highlighted India’s broad-based growth, reform momentum and expanding opportunities for long-term investment.

Sitharaman emphasised that India’s investment proposition rests not on any



Union Finance and Corporate Affairs Minister Nirmala Sitharaman addresses a business roundtable with investors and business leaders in Chicago, Illinois, United States

single sector, but on the convergence of scale, growth, talent, infrastructure, technology and sustained reform over the past decade.

“The policy environment is increasingly focused on enabling businesses to invest, manufacture, innovate and expand,” she said at the roundtable organised by India’s Consulate General in Chicago in association with US-India Strategic Partnership Forum.

The Finance Minister invited global partners to co-develop, co-produce and build for global markets.

She urged them not to consider India merely as a market to serve, but as a platform from which to build for

the world -- whether as a manufacturing base, technology and innovation centre, consumer market or destination for long-term infrastructure investment—leveraging India’s engineering talent, manufacturing scale and technology ecosystem.

The focus of the meeting was “Manufacture in India - for India and for the world”, with opportunities across manufacturing, AI & digital, financial services, infrastructure, food processing, defence and advanced technologies.”As global companies reassess supply chains and capital allocation, India offers not only scale as a market, but increasing depth

as a long-term investment and operating platform,” Sitharaman said.

The minister said India’s Digital Public Infrastructure such as Aadhaar, UPI, DigiLocker, ONDC and India Stack, has created platforms at population scale.

“The next opportunity is to build higher-value businesses in AI, engineering, analytics, product development, semiconductors and electronics, with India’s Global Capability Centres increasingly becoming global innovation hubs,” she said.

Sitharaman said GIFT City was emerging as an international financial centre connecting global capital with Indian opportunities. (PTI)

BRIEFLY

Women’s Junior Asia Cup Hockey: India face Korea



Led by midfielder Khaidem Shileima Chanu, the Indian women's hockey team will open its campaign against South Korea in the AHF Women's Junior Asia Cup, to be held in Moqi, China, from September 4 to 13. The 18-member squad has undergone extensive preparations under newly appointed coach Tim White, including an exposure tour of the United Kingdom earlier this summer. India have been drawn in the Elite Pool alongside hosts China, Japan, South Korea, and Malaysia. The teams will battle for the top positions before the tournament moves into the knockout stage, culminating in the gold-medal match on September 13. White said the team's preparations in Bengaluru had gone according to plan.

"The team is very excited to leave for China tomorrow for the Asia Cup. Our preparation has been good, including important matches against a combined India A team, which came to Bangalore for four matches. We will go to China confident that we have built a game plan which can be hard to play against, and we are very excited to test that against the best teams in Asia," said White.

Pranavi lone Indian to make cut in Irish Open, tied at 8th



Rising Indian golf sensation Pranavi Urs emerged as the sole Indian to qualify for the weekend rounds at the prestigious KPMG Women's Irish Open.

Delivering a resilient performance at the Palmer South course at The K Club, Urs carded a solid two-under-par 70 in her second round to secure a spot tied for eighth place.

While her steady play kept Indian hopes alive in the tournament, a highly competitive global field means she faces a steep uphill battle. Urs currently sits ten strokes adrift of the runaway tournament leader, South Africa's Cassandra Alexander, who continues to dominate the leaderboard. Urs endured an erratic but ultimately resilient front nine.

She suffered an early setback with a bogey on the second hole, but quickly recovered with a birdie on the fifth.

A subsequent bogey on the sixth threatened to derail her momentum, but a crucial birdie on the eighth allowed her to turn in at even par. Urs then showcased her immense potential on the back nine.

Telangana Golconda Masters to tee off on September 1



Top Indian professionals, including Saptak Talwar, Veer Ahlawat and Rashid Khan, will be in action when the Telangana Golconda Masters is held at the Hyderabad Golf Association (HGA) from September 1 to 4. The prize purse for the event is ₹1 crore. This competition will determine the top-24 players from the DP World PGTI Order of Merit who will earn their spots at the season-ending DP World India Championship. The 132 field will include DP World PGTI Order of Merit leader Saptak, Honey Baisoya, Veer, Rashid, Akshay Sharma and Om Prakash Chouhan, to name a few.

The prominent foreign players in the field are defending champion Jamal Hossain of Bangladesh, Badal Hossain also from Bangladesh, Czech Republic's Stepan Danek, Sri Lankans N Thangaraja and Mithun Perera, Nepal's Subash Tamang, Uganda's Joshua Seale and the Japanese duo of Koichiro Ishika and Taiga Tanaka. The local challenge will be led by Hyderabad-based professionals Mohd Azhar, Vishesh Sharma and Rupinder Singh Gill.

The tournament is part of the Race to DP World India Championship which is a competition to crown the DP World PGTI's number one player. Kapil Dev, President, DP World Professional Golf Tour of India (DP World PGTI), said, "The tournament will go a long way in promoting Telangana and Hyderabad as a leading destination for golf tourism."

Golf: Ryan Gerard and Viktor Hovland share 36-hole lead at the Tour Championship

DOUG FERGUSON
■ Atlanta

Ryan Gerard hit it well enough for five relatively easy birdies on Friday and dropped a surprise from just inside 80 feet for another, giving him a 5-under 65 and a share of the 36-hole lead with Viktor Hovland at the season-ending Tour Championship.

Hovland had one of five birdies on the peninsula-green 15th hole, a par 3 at only 155 yards but tucked to the left near a sharp slope that feeds off the putting surface. He had a 66 to join Gerard at 10-under 130 going into the weekend. Right behind? Just about everybody. That includes Scottie Scheffler, the world's No. 1 player who had a 67 and was two back. And it included Cameron

Young, in last place after the first round and atop the leaderboard for much of the day after a 62. He also wound up two behind.

Collin Morikawa and Chris Gotterup each shot 67 and were one behind at 9-under 131.

Gerard has more on his mind than the \$10 million prize and the five-year exemption on the PGA Tour. The captain's picks for the Presidents Cup will be announced after the Tour Championship, and it's on the mind of the 27-year-old from North Carolina.

"It's hard not to think about it a little bit," Gerard said. "I'm very aware that a good week this week goes a long way to help my chances. I'm playing this week for myself and to try and put up some good scores and hopefully win a trophy at the end of the

Indian men’s hockey team finishes 8th at WC

MONA PARTHSARATHI
■ Wavre (Belgium)

Captain Harmanpreet Singh's last-gasp penalty-corner strike took the match into a shoot-out but India finished eighth at the FIH World Cup after losing 3-4 to co-hosts Belgium here on Friday.

World No. 2 Belgium were leading 3-2 until the final minute when India earned a penalty corner with just 26 seconds left on the clock. Harmanpreet made no mistake in converting it to force a shoot-out after the two sides were locked 3-3 in regulation time.

It was Harmanpreet's eighth goal of the tournament. In the shoot-out, Shilanand Lakra, Dilpreet Singh and Abhishek converted their attempts but Harmanpreet and Sukhjeet Singh missed the mark as Belgium prevailed 4-3.

Tom Boon, Arthur de

Sloover, Alexander Hendrickx and Roman Duvekot scored for Belgium, while Victor Fourbert missed the target.

Abhishek had opened the scoring for India before Harmanpreet struck twice, while Duvekot, Hugo Labouchere and Nicolas de Kerpel scored in regulation time for Belgium.

The Indians, who were playing all their matches in the Netherlands, took the lead in front of a sizeable group of home supporters at the Belfius Hockey Arena amid cold winds but could not maintain their early momentum against the higher-ranked Belgians.

Abhishek put India ahead in the sixth minute, finding the net after his shot from inside the circle took a deflection off a Belgian defender's stick. Belgium gradually took control and drew level in the 22nd minute through Duvekot before Labouchere



put them ahead a minute later with a powerful penalty-corner drag-flick.

India had a chance to restore parity soon after half-time and Harmanpreet did exactly that, converting a penalty corner in the 31st

The Indians came close to going ahead in the 40th minute when Harmanpreet took the ball from the left flank and passed it to Abhishek inside the D, but his shot hit a defender's stick and went wide of the goalpost. Belgium struck again in the 47th minute through de Kerpel to take a 3-2 lead.

India suffered another setback in the final quarter when Manpreet Singh was struck in the face by a Labouchere shot and fell groaning. India's most experienced player had to leave the field as the ball came at such a high speed that it appeared he had suffered a serious injury above the eye. He, however, returned for the shoot-out.

With time running out, India withdrew their goalkeeper in favour of an additional outfield player and threw everything into attack. Their persistence paid off

when they earned a penalty corner with 26 seconds remaining, and Harmanpreet sent his drag-flick into the net to keep India in the contest.

However, the Belgians held their nerve in the shoot-out to consign India to an eighth-place finish.

The Indian team, dreaming of winning a World Cup medal after 51 years, defeated Wales 3-1 and Pakistan 5-3 in the first round before losing to England 2-4.

In the second round, India failed to score a single point, conceding three goals in the final 19 minutes against the Netherlands in a 1-3 defeat. Argentina defeated them 5-3, ending their last remaining hopes of reaching the semi-finals. Belgium, meanwhile, also fell short of expectations, having been knocked out of the semifinal race after 1-1 draws against Australia and Spain in the second round.

Neeraj Chopra ruled out of Asian Games and rest of 2026 season with ankle ligament tear

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi,

In a setback for India's athletics campaign at the Asian Games, Olympic champion Neeraj Chopra on Saturday announced that he will miss the remainder of the 2026 season, including the Continental showpiece in Japan, after suffering a ligament tear in his ankle during training.

Chopra said he sustained the injury shortly after producing a season-best throw at the Lausanne Diamond League. "After a period of hard work, I finally felt I was gaining the momentum I had been looking for with a season's best throw in Lausanne. "Unfortunately, shortly after, I sustained a ligament tear in my ankle during training. After discussions with my doctor and team, we've decided that I will sit out the rest of this season," Chopra said in a



post on Instagram. The 28-year-old javelin thrower said the decision was disappointing as he felt he was "close to finding my rhythm", but added that his immediate focus would be on recovery. "My focus now is on recovering well and coming back even stronger," he said. While his focus now shifts

towards rehabilitation, the athlete has made it clear that he intends to return to competition after recovering fully from the injury.

"It's disappointing, especially because I felt close to finding my rhythm. But as they say, setbacks are a part of the journey," he said. "Thank you all for the love

and support," Chopra added. The injury means he will also miss the Diamond League Finals in Brussels on September 5 though he had qualified for it.

Chopra's withdrawal is a major setback for India at the Asian Games, where he was expected to be one of the country's biggest medal hopes. The Tokyo Olympics gold medalist had endured a challenging phase in the build-up to the second half of the season, but his performance in Lausanne had offered encouragement that he was finding his rhythm again. Chopra has been one of the most consistent performers in world javelin over the past few years, winning Olympic gold in Tokyo in 2021 and a silver medal at the Paris Games in 2024. He also became the first Indian to win a World Championships gold in athletics when he triumphed in Budapest in 2023.

If we get basics right, we will be unstoppable at Asian Games: Rifle shooter Ashi Chouksey

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bhopal

Multiple Asian Games medalist rifle shooter Ashi Chouksey is confident that if the Indian contingent gets the basics right and stays true to its fundamentals, it will be "unstoppable" at the upcoming Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan, next month. There are high expectations from the Indian shooters to bring home a rich haul of medals at the continental showpiece, to be held from September 19 to October 4, after their impressive performances at the last two editions in Jakarta in 2018 and Hangzhou in 2023.

"Little things matter a lot. We know what to do, we know how to shoot, but there are small things which are neglected. If we do them right, towards perfection, then I think we will be unstoppable," said Chouksey, 24, who won two silvers and a bronze at the previous Asian Games. Chouksey is also relishing

the prospect of competing against a strong Chinese shooting contingent in Aichi-Nagoya, with China being India's biggest rival on the continental stage.

"I am really excited to compete with the Chinese shooting team because they are a very strong team and in the 2023 Asian Games, we had a gold (Sift Kaur Samra) and a bronze (Ashi Chouksey) in the women's 50m 3P category, while they got a silver at their home," she said. "So they might still be holding it against us (laughs) and can be looking for revenge. They are a very strong team but I am really excited to compete with them," said Chouksey.

Chouksey won a silver in women's 10m air rifle team and women's 50m rifle 3P team event respectively, and a bronze in the women's 50m rifle 3P event at the Asian Games in 2023.

Reflecting on the difference between her first and second Asian Games campaigns, Chouksey said, "Asian Games is one of the



biggest multi-sport tournaments after the Olympics, and I have competed there before. I have performed on that stage, so I know what it takes. "After winning three medals, I now have good experience of competing at this level. So, this time, I am going to Japan with a clear view and goal for what I want to achieve at this competition."

From discovering shooting almost by chance at a school camp to establishing herself as a high-level international shooter, Chouksey's journey has been one of rapid progression. She was first intro-

duced to the sport at an NCC camp, where she picked up a rifle for the first time. A strong showing in her maiden attempt prompted her to consider shooting as a career, eventually leading to her selection at a state shooting academy.

Her road to the Asian Games has since involved an intensive preparation phase, with the Indian contingent undergoing training camps in Bhopal. The first camp featured multiple match and final simulations, including extended shooting sessions designed to test the athletes' endurance, focus, and stability.

Blaak lauds Savita-Bichoo camaraderie in women, flags post-Sreejesh gap in men



MONA PARTHSARATHI
■ Amstelveen

Legendary Dutch goalkeeper Pirmin Blaak is impressed by the camaraderie between veteran Savita Punia and Bichoo Devi, saying their willingness to help each other instead of rivalry could ensure a smooth transition in Indian women's goalkeeping, in contrast to the "huge gap" he sees in the men's team following the retirement of PR Sreejesh.

Blaak, 38, who was a part of the Netherlands' Paris Olympic gold-medal winning team, feels India's young men's goalkeepers have so far lacked the quality and presence needed to take the team to the next level.

"I watched the men's team also and there is a huge gap after the legendary PR Sreejesh retired. The big-status goalkeeper. Young goalkeepers have come but they lacked the quality to push India to the next level," Blaak said.

Blaak said replacing Sreejesh was not simply about finding a goalkeeper with the required technical skills. "Sreejesh has a big legacy. I feel some similarity with him. We had something with our body language like we are there. He was really outspoken. A goalkeeper should make a difference and it seems to be missing," he added. Blaak had a short stint with the Indian women's team to help Savita and Bichoo prepare for the World Cup and was struck by the relationship between the two goalkeepers.

"I love the way they help each other. It was not there during my career and I can also learn as a trainer with them. They are really nice, friendly people and that's what I like the most," Blaak

said. "It is very rare that two players are not competing but rather they are helping each other. I asked them, 'Are you serious, you are not competing with each other?'," he said.

Both the goalkeepers were instrumental in India's reasonably good World Cup show where they finished fifth – their best performance in 52 years.

Blaak feels Savita, who has been India's first-choice goalkeeper for more than a decade, is herself playing an important role in preparing her successor.

"What Savita was setting up for the last decade is incredible. It is nice that she herself is preparing Bichoo to come through.

"It will be really nice if they can play together for some time, where Savita opens up and says that I am going to retire soon and I am giving that last push to Bichoo to help her. It is nice to have an experienced goalkeeper besides a younger one," said the former keeper who has played over 150 matches for Netherlands. Blaak said his own role was not to make drastic technical changes to the two goalkeepers, given the limited time available before the World Cup.

"I haven't changed anything tactically. I just discussed where we want to grow and what my vision is. I keep them the way they are. They are brilliant and unique in their style of play," he said. Instead, he focused on the mental side of goalkeeping and the pressure that comes with representing India at a major tournament.

"Savita and I also talk about pressure to perform on Team India. I understand that. I have been in those moments and Savita has also experienced that," he said.



week." The trophies - one for the Tour Championship and one for the FedEx Cup - are up for grabs at the halfway point. One third of the field is separated by three shots on a course that has relatively soft with either rain Thursday

or overcast Friday, even with a little wind late in the day.

No one took advantage quite like Young, who remains in the picture for PGA Tour player of the year with his signature win at The Players Championship and a big

win at a signature event at Doral.

He opened with two early bogeys in the opening round when everyone was going low and jokingly said it made him wonder about his career choice. He shot 70 that left him tied for last place and going off as a single Friday in the 29-man field (J.J. Spaun has withdrawn).

He made the turn in 30, and then poured in two more birdies to reach 7 under through 11 holes. Young cooled slightly with a bogey from the bunker at the 12th and missed opportunities the rest of the way until a 40-foot eagle putt slammed into the back of the cup on the par-5 18th for a 62. The put him in a tie for the lead as the final group was starting, and Young would have been a little surprised to be within two

shots by the end of the round. Low scores were there, and he had reason to believe someone would motor well past him.

"I was in last place about three-and-a-half hours ago," Young said. "There's not much wind today, and the field seems to be playing pretty well for even par being last place after yesterday. I think I can pat myself on the back for shooting 8 under, but that doesn't change how much work there is left to even give yourself a chance." He ended the way with a mock handshake for the partner he didn't have. Young didn't race his way around the course. It felt like a practice round he plays by himself. There was one moment where it looked like any recreational round when he removed the flag on No. 12 and set it on the

fringe because his caddie was busy raking the bunker.

Now that single falls to Robert MacIntyre, the only player not under par at East Lake. MacIntyre shot a 76 - eight shots over the field average - and was 13 shots behind. Scheffler had two early bogeys to fall five shots behind and then answered with five birdies in a stretch of six holes around the turn to get back in the game. He was closing in until his approach sailed over the 17th green — the pin was in the back - and he stooped over for the longest time. "I watched it get in the jet stream up there and fly," Scheffler said. He made up for it with a two-putt birdie on the 18th was in a good position - along with so many others — with two days left in the season.

India begin Women’s Asia Cup T20 campaign against Thailand

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dubai

Harmanpreet Kaur’s India will look to banish their ordinary run in the shortest format while facing questions over their consistency and form as they take on Thailand in their Women’s T20 Asia Cup Group A opener here on Sunday.

India have been the most dominant team in the Women’s T20 Asia Cup over the last decade—winning the title thrice in five editions of the T20 format since 2016-17

— but their performances bring forth more concerns than assurances at the moment. India have lost nine of 16 T20Is this year, and their most recent loss — against Australia in the Women’s T20 World Cup —knocked them out of the competition at the group stage itself.

With questions persisting over captain Harmanpreet’s own form and future in the shortest format, India head into a crucial phase of competing in two Asian-level competitions in which they would

be expected to go the distance. Following the eight-team Women’s T20 Asia Cup, where India are placed in Group A along with Thailand, Hong Kong and Pakistan, they will head into next month’s Asian Games in Japan with expectations high to bring more laurels to the country.

Having endured a largely disappointing campaign in the Women’s T20 World Cup, Harmanpreet fired in the all-important clash against Australia, but her inconsistency with the bat remained one of the talking points



from the campaign in which India struggled against higher-ranked teams.

With dependable batter Jemimah Rodrigues sidelined for the Asia Cup and Asian Games, India have added Pratika Rawal to their star-studded squad, but the choice hardly settles the requirement for a middle-order enforcer. At the top, India will continue to have the formidable opening pair of Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma, but the biggest challenge for batters at No. 3 and beyond would be to

sustain momentum and provide further impetus to the scoreboard. Poor fielding was again a major concern the last time India played in the format, as a string of dropped chances near the ropes led to their downfall, and the team management would be desperate to have their bases covered this time around. India will rely on their seasoned all-rounder Deepti Sharma to lead the spin attack once again, with Shree Charani, the highest wicket-taker of the T20 World Cup, Radha Yadav and Prema

Rawat sharing the workload.

India’s seam bowling arsenal looks potent too, with the experienced Renuka Singh Thakur having the likes of Kranti Gaud, Arundhati Reddy and Nandani Sharma to share the responsibilities. Thailand, meanwhile, will look to draw confidence from their victory over Hong Kong in their opening match, for which they had to work hard. A sedate start led to Thailand finishing at a modest 120 for nine, but they did well with the ball and in the field to restrict Hong Kong to 114 for seven.

Sarfaraz denies knowing about PCB’s threat to end England tour



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

Former Pakistan captain and head coach Sarfaraz Ahmed has denied having any knowledge of Pakistan Cricket Board’s threat to end the tour of England during the second Test here, which was reportedly made around the airing of Sky’s interview with Imran Khan’s sons.

Sky Sports had aired an interview with Imran’s sons Suleiman Khan and Kasim Khan which was conducted by broadcaster and former England captain Michael Atherton, during the lunch break on the opening day of the second Test here at Lord’s. Imran’s sons had expressed their concern about the health of the former Pakistan captain in the interview, who has been in prison for three years, saying that they feared for his life. The 39-year-old Sarfaraz, who last played for Pakistan in December 2023, said at the end of second day’s play that he was not aware of any such developments. “I don’t

know anything. I’m just focusing on the match,” Sarfaraz said when asked what he knew about the situation and of the conversation between the PCB and the England and Wales Cricket Board. Sarfaraz was further asked if there was any suggestion that Pakistan players would not take the field after lunch. “No, no. You’re talking about the interview? We don’t know about the interview,” he said while interrupting the question.

When asked if the players were going to play, Sarfaraz replied, “All are okay. We were having our lunch at that time.”

The PCB had made a formal complaint to Sky Sports after the interview was aired.

According to the BBC, the ECB took government advice from the Foreign, Commonwealth and Development office in their “response to the tension” around the situation.

The interview was not telecast in Pakistan by PTV, which is broadcasting the match using Sky’s pictures.

England in control, stretches lead to 261 after skittling Pakistan for 110

FOSTER NIUMATA
■ London

England was bossing Pakistan by an imposing 261 runs after two days of the Lord’s test on Friday.

The host side was 81-3 in its second innings when bad light stopped play and in total command after routing a depleted Pakistan for 110 in the afternoon.

Pakistan medium-pacers Khurram Shahzad and Mohammad Ali did well to prise out Ben Duckett, Jordan Cox and Joe Root in the last session but they were bowling in damage limitation mode.

Their batters’ failure conceded an intimidating 180-run lead to England on the first innings. Pakistan hasn’t totaled 180 in the series yet and was without opening batter Imam-ul-Haq, who suffered a left calf strain while fielding early Thursday

and won’t reappear. England won the first test in Leeds by an innings last week and may yet repeat the three-day feat and clinch the three-match series.

England’s four seamers feasted on a Pakistan batting order that wasn’t boosted by the return of captain Babar Azam. Ollie Robinson took 4-11 from 13 overs, including six maidens. Jofra Archer had 3-26 from 11.2 and the fastest new-ball spell of his career. Josh Tongue claimed two wickets and Gus Atkinson was luckless. “I could probably play until 40 at this rate (with this attack),” the 31-year-old Archer told broadcaster Sky Sports. “It’s really nice having the extra seamers in the lineup. It’s unbelievable when everybody is fit and firing. Each day it will be someone else’s turn.” Pakistan was blown away in 37.2 overs, and the bowlers were back in



harness just over four hours after finishing England’s first innings at 290 at noon.

The only resistance when Pakistan batted came from novice opener Azan Awaais.

Embarrassingly out to the first ball of the series in Leeds, Awaais dug in for 35 overs at Lord’s. He debuted in May with a century in Bangladesh and was four runs shy of his third half-century. Awaais faced 102

balls to score 46. “I survived a good innings and built a little bit of my confidence,” Awaais told the BBC. His innings was remarkable considering the next best runs in Pakistan’s scoreboard was 20 extras. Awaais was dropped on 8 off Atkinson and over-turned being given out on 43. He was caught on the boundary after top-edging a pull at Robinson. Robinson was heading toward a third

player-of-the-match performance in three tests. He came to the fore after lunch, pinning Saud Shakeel and Mohammed Rizwan to expose the tail. Robinson added Shahzad and Awaais but couldn’t grab another Lord’s five-for.

Archer averaged 90.7 mph (146 kph) before lunch, topping at 95 mph (153 kph) but could nick off only Shan Masood, who moved up to open as Imam’s replacement. Archer took out two tallenders at the end.

“I don’t think the speed gun is accurate in this game, to be honest,” Archer said. “It didn’t really feel that way. But I’ll take it.” Tongue bagged Pakistan’s most in-form batter, Abdullah Shafique, right on lunch. Shafique tried driving Tongue on 5 and was caught behind after England reviewed. Tongue also got Babar straight after lunch. Coming back from a finger

injury that made him miss the first test, Babar hit a couple of boundaries through the covers then edged Tongue to third slip on 8. Tongue had a good day before he bowled. He earned a career-best batting score of 30 not out in the morning. Atkinson was last man out for 45. They resumed England’s first innings on 248-9 and their 10th-wicket partnership added a valuable 47 runs, 42 of them on Friday to retake the momentum from Pakistan. In their second bat, Duckett gave his wicket to Shahzad in the second over and Jordan Cox was pinned on the back pad by Shahzad in the fourth.

Root reviewed being dismissed by Ali on 24 but it was plumb, and he was out lbw for the ninth time in his last 12 test innings. Still batting at stumps were the streaky but determined Emilio Gay on 30 and Harry Brook on 7. (AP)

‘Ishan didn’t know I am wicket-taking bowler’

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

He could not contribute with the bat in his team’s only innings in the Duleep Trophy quarterfinal but Vaibhav Sooryavanshi provided two crucial breakthroughs as East Zone crushed North East Zone by an innings and 210 runs.

All eyes were on young batting sensation Sooryavanshi when East Zone batted first, but the left-handed batter fell for a mere eight and his side went on to pile up a massive 467 in their only outing with the bat. While the total was enough for East Zone to dominate the proceedings for the remainder of the game, their skipper Ishan



Kishan was forced to summon Sooryavanshi to roll his arm over with his left-arm spin, looking for a breakthrough.

“If you ask any batter, he enjoys bowling as well, or vice versa with the bowler; they like to bat. Both enjoy doing the other a lot,” Sooryavanshi, who returned figures of 3-0-11-2 in North East Zone’s second innings,



said in a video shared by the BCCI. “The wicket wasn’t falling for the opponent team and I was asked to bowl 2-3 overs. Ishan bhaiya felt that he was taking some risk in asking me to bowl, but he did not know that I am a wicket-taker.” Sooryavanshi, who dismissed Kishan Lyngdoh (25) and Imliwati Lemtur (4), said there is no greater

enjoyment for a batter than to taking wickets when required. “The only thing I had in my mind was even if I take five wickets here, I would only get three overs to bowl so I tried to bowl my best, tried to bowl at the same spot and finish my spell,” he said.

“I enjoyed it a lot because it did not go well in batting for me, so to have contributed with my bowling felt really good. Of course, when a batter takes a wicket there is no bigger enjoyment than that,” Sooryavanshi added.

East Zone will now take on the defending champions Central Zone in the first semifinal of the Duleep Trophy starting here on Sunday.

Duleep Trophy semis: Patidar’s Central take on East, South clash with North

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

The Duleep Trophy reaches its business end here on Sunday with defending champions Central Zone taking on an East Zone side brimming with confidence, while last year’s runners-up South Zone face North Zone.

The last-four stage promises an intriguing contest, with East and North having negotiated the quarterfinal hurdle while Central and South received direct entry.

East Zone recorded a crushing victory over North East Zone in their quarterfinal, while North Zone scraped through a tense knockout thanks largely to left-arm spinner Abid

Mushtaq. Central, led by Rajat Patidar for the second successive season, and South, last year’s runner-up, will have to hit the ground running despite not having played a game in the tournament. Central, however, have the advantage of continuity, having retained a strong core from the side that lifted the trophy last year. Patidar comes into the tournament on the back of a prolific season in the IPL and MP T20 League, while vice-captain Rinku Singh adds experience to the middle order.

Their biggest strength could be the bowling depth. Saransh Jain, who impressed under trying circumstances in the drawn second Test against Sri Lanka, and Harsh



Dubey, who recently featured in the ODIs against Afghanistan, form a quality spin combination. Yash Thakur adds pace and first-class experience, while Zeeshan Ansari, rewarded for his recent performances, will be another player to

watch. East, though, would want to build on their momentum with the young spin combination. Yash Thakur adds pace and first-class experience, while Zeeshan Ansari, rewarded for his recent performances, will be another player to

Bengal’s Sudip Gharami and Shahbaz Ahmed striking commanding centuries.

Shahbaz also contributed with four wickets, while Anukul Roy claimed a five-wicket haul in the second innings and Abhijit Sarkar finished with six wickets in the match. Gharami and Shahbaz’s form gives East plenty of confidence, while skipper Ishan Kishan adds experience and authority to the batting line-up. Abhimanyu Easwaran brings proven First-Class pedigree, while teenage sensation Sooryavanshi, despite a modest outing with the bat in the quarterfinal, remains capable of changing the game if he gets going at the top. Last year’s runners-up

South Zone have the experience to go one step further, with new captain Tilak Varma leading a strong batting unit featuring Ricky Bhui, Narayan Jagadeesan, and Karun Nair. Nair, in particular, will look to draw on his experience in pressure situations, while Jagadeesan has been among the more consistent run-getters on the domestic circuit. Shreyas Gopal and left-arm spinner Tanay Thyagarajan add variety to the attack, with Vidwath Kaverappa providing the pace option.

North Zone, however, arrive with the confidence of surviving a tight knockout, edging the star-studded West Zone by 52 runs in the quarterfinal.

Japan’s Rei Sakamoto beats Kei Nishikori to earn US Open spot

BRIAN MAHONEY
■ New York

Rei Sakamoto played his way into the U.S. Open - but only by taking the spot that Kei Nishikori, Japan’s greatest men’s tennis star, hoped to earn for one last Grand Slam appearance.

In a changing of the guard match, Sakamoto beat Nishikori 6-4, 7-6 (3) on Friday in the final round of qualifying to earn a place in the main draw. “Not happy to lose today, but I’m happy for Rei,” Nishikori said. “He’s the next Japanese top player.” The 20-year-old Sakamoto, like many other players from Japan,



considers Nishikori his hero. He was 8 years old and remembers when Nishikori reached the 2014 U.S. Open final, becoming the first Asian man to get that far in a Grand Slam tournament. “I honestly grew up watching him

play and he was my idol for my whole life,” Sakamoto said, “and it’s also a pity to see his last season.” Sakamoto is typical of many tennis players and doesn’t like to look at the draw ahead of time to see who he might play. (AP)

After being out for four months, Alcaraz expects to be himself at US Open

STEPHEN WHYNO
■ New York

After sitting out more than four months nursing an injured right wrist that caused him to miss the French Open and Wimbledon, Carlos Alcaraz didn’t decide to return for the U.S. Open to be anything less than his Grand Slam-winning self. “You’re going to see Carlitos playing the way he always has,” Alcaraz said.

The 23-year-old from Spain is set to play his first competitive singles match Monday since getting sidelined by the wrist injury in mid-April. He insists he has not changed anything about his mechanics and expressed confidence about physically feeling great.



“I need competition,” Alcaraz said Friday. “We, my team and me, believe that I’m ready. It wasn’t an easy decision. I just did whatever it took to be ready.”

Alcaraz is the defending champion and favored to go back-to-back, a year after beating Jannik Sinner and

overtaking him for the No. 1 ranking. The field this time does not include Sinner, who withdrew because of a right knee injury.

“We are not going see each other for, like, six months now, seven months,” Alcaraz said. “It’s kind of a weird situation, to be honest.”

Alexander Zverev is the top seed in Sinner’s absence. But all eyes are on Alcaraz, who earlier this year won his seventh Grand Slam title by defeating Novak Djokovic in the Australian Open final.

“Everyone is going to be pretty tapped in to see his first match,” 11th-seeded American Frances Tiafoe said. “If he comes back anywhere near his level, it’s tough. Regardless, even if he’s not at his tip-top (shape), you’ve still got to beat him in five (sets).” Alcaraz opens against Roman Safullin as he dives right back into best-of-five-set tennis in his return. He did get a chance to shake some rust off by playing a couple of mixed doubles matches with Serena Williams this week, but he knows not

getting a full ramp up to the U.S. Open adds another layer of difficulty. “It’s really challenging,” Alcaraz said. “Probably in terms of preparation and everything, (it) is not the best time.” But the energy of playing in New York was enough of a draw that he said, “There is no better tournament than the U.S. Open to be back.”

Can he win it off such a long layoff? He knows Roger Federer and Rafael Nadal have done it but does not want to set any expectations. “I’m not going to set a limit for myself,” Alcaraz said in Spanish. “I don’t want to focus on a specific result. I want to focus on process we’ve gone through. Just go out there, enjoy it and feel good.” (AP)

Folklore vibrates through time

With Janmashtami approaching, we swap our grandparents' familiar stories and old television reruns to watch this myth breathe on stage

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

SAKSHI PRIYA

How often do we skim a newspaper about age-old festivals and wonder if these rituals still carry genuine weight? The answer hits hard the moment Janmashtami takes over the subcontinent. It crashes in as a fiercely loud celebration of a divine birth that has commanded the spiritual conscience of the nation for centuries. Heavy drum strikes physically shake crowded temples. Midnight prayers bleed into intense devotion, forcing ancient mythology to become a beautifully chaotic shared reality. A quiet worry stalks our rushing modern society about stopping our most sacred memories from fading into dusty archives. Janmashtami answers that exact fear with a beating pulse. Because old scriptures often struggle to hold the incredibly restless modern imagination, communities naturally turn to the living stage to keep their cultural heritage wide awake. They layer heavy mythological texts with intricate classical dance, deeply rooted Bhakti music, and tactile heritage textiles to build a highly visible bridge straight back into the past. The stage transforms into a sanctuary where history is intensely lived instead of quietly read. Anchoring this exact cultural resistance is the Shriram Bharatiya Kala Kendra, staging the fiftieth monumental year of its landmark KRISHNA production at Kamani Auditorium. Conceptualised by Sumitra Charat Ram and driven by Padmashri Shobha Deepak Singh's sharp direction, it ensures our ancient history remains fiercely alive on stage.

BEFORE THE DIVINE DAWN

King Kansa tightens his cruel grip on Mathura as desperate pleas echo through the cold bars. This heavy emotional opening scene sets the dark stage for a divine birth that will shatter physical chains and restore absolute cosmic balance.

KRISHNA ASCENDANT

Anchoring this highly dramatic scene, Krishna stands surrounded by vibrantly costumed performers as one dancer kneels in deep reverence and another reaches forward in pure devotion, while striking blue lighting washes over the stage to transform this physical display of absolute surrender into an incredibly mystical theatrical experience.

THE FINAL CONFRONTATION

Krishna remains our fierce protector. This petal-strewn confrontation explodes onstage, capturing good defeating rooted corruption with raw physical energy. Feeling our ancient roots pulse through these handcrafted costumes is essential. Experience this living cultural heritage live until September 4, 2026.

When Kabir's poetry came alive through dance

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

TEAM VIVA

What happens when Kabir's timeless words find expression through the graceful language of Bharatanatyam? *Kabira: Sargun Se Nirgun* offered an answer that was as much about looking inward as it was about performance. Premiered by Gayathri Sharma and Bhadra Sinha in collaboration with Meghnaa Mital, the production took the audience on a journey through Kabir's philosophy at a packed India Habitat Centre in Delhi. Presented by Kalakriti Arts Trust and Satyanjali Trust, the evening explored the movement from sargun, the visible and manifest world, to nirgun, the formless and eternal. Instead of presenting Kabir's poetry as separate pieces, the production brought together four compositions that flowed into one another like chapters of a single journey. There was a seeker at the heart of it all—one who awakens, questions the world around him, seeks guidance and finally turns inward to discover the truth. The journey began with *Ud Jayega Hans Akela*, a reminder of life's fleeting nature and its illusions. Guru Kripa Anjan brought the Guru's guidance, while *Yugan Yugan Hum Yogi* turned inward, reflecting on the soul's eternal nature. The final piece, *Bhajo Re Bhaiyya*, brought a shift in mood. Introspection gave way to joy and celebration as the audience joined the performers in the bhajan, clapping along and becoming part of the experience. One of the most striking aspects of the production was the way the four pieces came together. Each one carried the thought and emotion of the previous composition forward, allowing Kabir's philosophy to unfold naturally rather than explaining it outright. Gayathri Sharma and Bhadra Sinha brought depth and sensitivity to the stage, blending the discipline of Bharatanatyam with expressive abhinaya. Through movement, gesture and expression, they made ideas such as illusion, seeking, self-discovery and liberation feel personal and easy to connect with. Music played an equally important role, with Meghnaa Mital and M Sridhar blending Hindustani and Carnatic traditions. Uma Arun led the ensemble, while Ratul S. Kumar and Aparna Rajaraman Balaji added depth with mridangam and nattuvangam. The evening ended with a standing ovation. But what stayed with the audience was perhaps more than the memory of a beautifully staged performance. It was the feeling of having travelled somewhere from the distractions and illusions of the outside world towards a quieter space of introspection, connection and joy. The production was also appreciated by the Chief Justice of India, Justice Shri Surya Kant, and the Union Minister for Environment, Forest & Climate Change, Bhupender Yadav, who praised the artists for bringing Kabir's philosophy to life through this journey of awakening, seeking and self-realisation. In a rushed and noisy world, *Kabira: Sargun Se Nirgun* brought Kabir's words alive, reminding us that the search for truth can lead us back to ourselves.

KABIR'S POETRY FINDS GRACEFUL EXPRESSION IN A COMPELLING JOURNEY FROM SARGUN TO NIRGUN

Strings honour the unsung heroes

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

Strings and percussion unite to honour unrecognised soldiers while celebrating a pioneering tabla maestro's centenary

SAKSHI PRIYA

Music carries a rare ability to remember those whom history easily forgets. That quiet ache filled Kamani Auditorium during the 29th Amar Jyoti concert. It brought strings and percussion together to honour the unrecognised soldiers of the nation, while also celebrating a full century since the birth of Pandit Chatur Lal. He was the pioneering tabla genius whose work helped take Indian classical music and the tabla to audiences beyond India. The sheer weight of musical history settled over the crowd the very second Grammy winner Pandit Vishwa Mohan Bhatt ran his slide over the Mohan Veena. He played a stunning duet with Pandit Salil Bhatt on the Satvik Veena, and they relied completely on the frantic energy of Pranshu Chatur Lal to anchor the rhythm. The young musician looked fiercely determined to hammer the roaring fire of his grandfather into every single driving beat. The hall grew noticeably heavier when Banaras Charana vocalists Pandit Ritesh Mishra and Pandit Rajnish Mishra finally let their melodies loose. Their layered voices tangled directly with the acoustics of the room to make the sacrifice of nameless fighters feel incredibly close to home. A recently released commemorative postal stamp officially recorded the late maestro hitting the century mark, but the live performance guided by artistic director Shruti Chatur Lal delivered the true tribute. It proved exactly how stretched skin and steel strings can speak volumes for heroes who gave up their own voices.

Styled Opulence

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

TEAM VIVA

Celebrating 20 years of fierce sustainable craft, Designer Samant Chauhan opens a shared Khan Market boutique alongside Symetree fine jewels. The joint room erases old boundaries dividing clothing and fine jewellery. His textured Bhagalpuri silks sit right beside bespoke designs, like massive cut emeralds anchoring diamond chains that reflect proper royal architecture. By placing modern shapes next to traditional Jadau and Navratna, both speak the same language of Indian craft.

Lineage
Vibrant crimson rubies and raw uncut diamonds meld beautifully across this tiered masterpiece, elegantly finished with soft, hanging pearl drops.

Architecture
A massive, sharply cut emerald pendant boldly anchors a brilliant diamond chain to deliver visual weight.

The renaissance of Indian adornment
The collection pulls together heavily ornate Indian aesthetics through beautifully layered necklaces and tight chokers alongside classic drop earrings and delicate maang-tikkas. Rich emerald greens and deep rubies sit next to soft pink stones and lustrous pearls against heavy gold detailing to create pieces that feel completely traditional yet effortlessly wearable for the modern buyer. The designers draw inspiration from classic *Jadau*, uncut *Polki*, and old temple designs rooted in royal history.

CLOTHING AND ADORNMENT CARRY EQUAL WEIGHT HERE, PROVING TO THE MODERN COLLECTOR THAT POWERFUL WARDROBE CHOICES ALWAYS START WITH SOLID ARTISANAL ROOT

ART CORNER

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

TEAM VIVA

An artist's visual language is never truly finished; it fractures and matures through a lifetime of wrestling with memory and raw material. This quiet evolution anchors *Becoming*, the opening exhibition at Akar Prakar. Guided by Siddhi Shailendra, the collection steps back, allowing the sheer historical weight of six distinct practices to command the room naturally. The artworks spark intense conversations around fading landscapes and complicated personal histories. Debasish Mukherjee maps the emotional geography of displacement in his sweeping textile work, *The Land We Carry*, weaving fragmented memories directly into heavy fabric. Leang Seckon's dense, striking collage, *Who Owns the Land*, physically stitches together archival photographs and cultural motifs, demanding answers from a torn environment. Moving inward, C Douglas pulls viewers into a deeply psychological, circular realm with *Dream*, manipulating mixed media to explore distorted forms and quiet symbolism. By refusing to trap these creators behind a rigid theme, the exhibition offers a rare sanctuary to witness how seasoned masters constantly reinvent their intricate craft over decades.

The Pioneer AGENDA

The river is constantly turning and bending and you never know where it's going to go and where you'll wind up.
— Eartha



EKLAVYA PRASAD
Managing Trustee, Megh Pyne Abhiyan

The proposition may appear straightforward, link India's great rivers, from the Brahmaputra in the northeast to the Godavari and Cauvery in the south, and India could potentially overcome water shortages for decades. Union Home Minister Amit Shah recently brought the idea back into public discussion when, at the 31st meeting of the Southern Zonal Council in Mahabalipuram, Tamil Nadu, on August 20, he said that interconnecting India's great rivers from the Brahmaputra to the Cauvery and Godavari could help ensure that the country faces no water shortage for the next 100 years.

But before we look at the vision as a solution, there is a simpler question. What exactly would it mean to link the Brahmaputra to rivers such as the Godavari and Cauvery?

India has had a formal National Perspective Plan (NPP) for interlinking rivers since 1980. It envisages 30 links, 14 under the Himalayan component and 16 under the Peninsular component. The government says feasibility studies have been completed for many of these links, while Ken-Betwa is the first to enter implementation. There is also a proposal to transfer water from the Godavari towards the Krishna, Pennar and ultimately Cauvery basins.

The Union Home Minister's proposition therefore does not emerge from nowhere. It sits within a much older national ambition to move water between river basins. But it is important not to confuse that ambition with a ready-to-build Brahmaputra-Godavari-Cauvery project. Such a project would require a defined route, diversion

points, storage, volumes, costs, environmental assessments, operating rules and agreements among affected states. That gap between political vision and executable project matters.

At its simplest, river interlinking means transferring water from one basin to another through dams, barrages, reservoirs, canals, tunnels and, where necessary, pumping systems. The underlying argument is that some basins have more water than they need while others face shortages.

The difficulty begins with the word surplus. In the Brahmaputra basin, about 85 per cent of annual rainfall occurs during the monsoon, producing enormous seasonal variations in flow. But high monsoon flow does not automatically mean surplus water. Floodwaters can be destructive, yet the flood pulse also recharges wetlands and groundwater, supports fisheries, spreads nutrients and sediment, and sustains floodplain ecosystems and livelihoods. The Brahmaputra is one of the world's great sediment-carrying rivers, and its sediment contributes to the maintenance of downstream floodplains and deltaic systems.

The relevant question, therefore, is not how much water a river carries in a wet month, but how much dependable water is actually available for transfer after accounting for existing uses, downstream requirements, ecological needs, seasonal variability and international obligations.

This becomes particularly important when the proposed destination is the peninsular rivers. The Godavari, and Cauvery also receive a substantial share of their annual rainfall and runoff during the monsoon. So what exactly would be transferred from the Brahmaputra?

If the proposal is to move water during the monsoon, the case for transferring water from one river experiencing its principal period of abundance to another doing the same is not immediately obvious. If the intention is instead to capture Brahmaputra flows, store them and

THE BRAHMAPUTRA ADDS ANOTHER LAYER OF COMPLEXITY BECAUSE IT IS NOT SIMPLY A LARGE INDIAN RIVER. IT IS A TRANSBOUNDARY RIVER SYSTEM

transfer them south for use during dry months, the proposition becomes a vast storage-and-transfer system designed to overcome seasonal variability.

That raises another set of questions. Where would the water be stored, how much storage would be required, how much would be lost through evaporation, what energy would be required to move it, and how would the system perform after a weak monsoon? Surplus is not a permanent characteristic of a river basin. It is relative to season, location, demand and hydrological conditions.

The Brahmaputra adds another layer of complexity because it is not simply a large Indian river. It is a transboundary river system originating in Tibet, China and flowing through India and Bangladesh, where it continues as the Jamuna. The basin extends across four countries, with tributaries originating in Bhutan as well. Bangladesh is therefore not an incidental observer of what happens to the river upstream.

India already shares hydrological information with Bangladesh for flood forecasting and disaster preparedness, but there is no comprehensive Brahmaputra water-sharing treaty comparable to the Ganga agreement. A major alteration in the volume or timing of Brahmaputra flows would therefore have implications beyond India's internal water policy.

India must also consider that it is itself downstream of China in the Brahmaputra system. A major intervention would consequently sit within a wider geopolitical context involving

China, India and Bangladesh.

There is another question worth asking. India is already considering moving water southward without reaching for the Brahmaputra. The NPP includes the proposed Godavari Cauvery link project, which is designed as a three link system comprising Godavari Inchampalli or Janampet to Krishna Nagarjunasagar, Krishna Nagarjunasagar to Pennar Somasila, and Pennar Somasila to Cauvery Grand Anicut.

If the Godavari-Cauvery connection is already envisaged, why is the Brahmaputra required? Has projected demand in the south grown beyond what the peninsular links can address? Is the available water in the Godavari insufficient? Or are we progressively expanding the geographical area from which water must be sourced because demand itself continues to grow?

These are not merely engineering questions. They concern how India defines its water problem. The northeast and eastern India are often portrayed as having too much water, while western and southern India have too little. There is some truth in this broad seasonal picture, but it can obscure a second reality. India's water stress is also a problem of management and demand. Groundwater depletion, water-intensive cropping, inefficient irrigation, urban leakage, inadequate used-water reuse, destruction of tanks and wetlands, floodplain encroachment and poor watershed management all contribute to scarcity. This does not mean inter-basin transfers can never form part of India's water-security strategy. But before moving water across enormous distances, India should establish how much of the projected deficit remains after addressing these factors. The larger the intervention, the stronger that evidence should be.

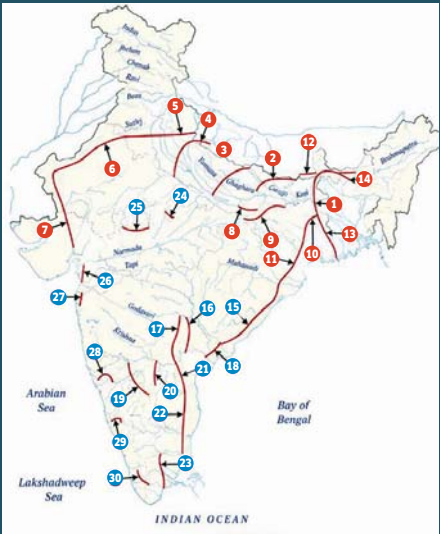
That leads to a more fundamental question. Is river interlinking being pursued because it is demonstrably the most appropriate response to water stress, or because it sustains a particular model of large-scale construction? There is nothing inherently wrong with infrastructure. India needs water-supply systems, irrigation infrastructure, wastewater-treatment systems and flood-management infrastructure. But infrastructure should follow a clearly demonstrated problem, it should not define the problem in a way that makes increasingly large infrastructure appear necessary.

Feasibility, therefore, cannot be reduced to whether engineers can build the system. A project may be technically possible but economically prohibitive, economically possible but environmentally damaging, politically agreed upon but difficult to govern, or functional under historical hydrological conditions but unreliable under climate change. A system that works in an average year may fail precisely when water is most needed.

The engineering challenge of creating a Brahmaputra to peninsular river system would be formidable, involving the diversion, storage

MAPPING INDIA'S RIVER LINKING PROJECTS

The National Perspective Plan envisages interlinking of 30 rivers through 14 Himalayan and 16 Peninsular projects to transfer surplus water to water-deficit regions and promote equitable water distribution.



HIMALAYAN RIVER LINKING SYSTEM

1. Manas-Sankosh-Tista-Canga
2. Kosi-Chagra
3. Gandak-Ganga
4. Chagra-Yamuna
5. Sarda-Yamuna
6. Yamuna-Rajasthan
7. Rajasthan-Sabarmati
8. Chunar-Gold Barrage
9. One dam-southern tributaries of Ganga
10. Ganga-Damodar-Subernarekha
11. Subernarekha-Mahanadi
12. Kosi-Mecchi
13. Farakka-Sunderbans
14. Joghiope-Tista-Farakka

PENINSULAR RIVER LINKING SYSTEM

15. Mahanadi (Manibhadra)-Godavari (Dowlaiswaram)
16. Godavari Inchampalli-Krishna (Pulichintala)
17. Godavari (Inchampalli)-Krishna (Nagarjunasagar)
18. Godavari (Polavaram)-Krishna (Vijaya)
19. Krishna (Almatti)-Pens
20. Krishna Srisailem-Pennar
21. Krishna (Nagarjunasagar)-Pennar (Somasila)
22. Pennar (Somasila)-Cauvery (Grand Anicut)
23. Cauvery (Kattalai) Vaigai-Gundar
24. Ken-Betwa
25. Parbati-Kalisindh-Chambal
26. Par-Tapi Narmada
27. Damanganga-Pinjal
28. Bedti-Vanda
29. Netravati-Hemavati
30. Pamba-Achankovil-Vaippar

SOURCE: NATIONAL PERSPECTIVE PLAN FOR INTERLINKING OF RIVERS, 1980

and long-distance transfer of water across multiple river basins, potentially requiring extensive pumping. It would also have to contend with sedimentation, evaporation, floods, seismic risks and increasingly variable rainfall patterns. But the federal challenge may be equally important. Who decides how much water moves, when it moves, who gets priority during water scarcity, and what happens when the source state's own requirements increase? The government itself recognises the importance of agreement among concerned states for interlinking projects.

Ken-Betwa offers an early opportunity to examine these trade-offs. It is the first NPP project to enter implementation, with the government projecting irrigation, drinking-water and hydropower benefits at an approved cost of ₹44,605 crore. At the same time, it has generated significant environmental concerns, including forest diversion and impacts on the Panna landscape. The lesson is not that large projects are necessarily unacceptable, but that their benefits and costs must be examined together.

International experience offers comparisons but no ready-made blueprint. China's South-to-North Water Diversion Project, Australia's Snowy Mountains Scheme, the Lesotho Highlands Water Project and California's State Water Project demonstrate that very large-scale inter-basin water transfer systems can operate.

CONTINUED ON >> P11

KEN-BETWA LINK PROJECT

The mega-infrastructure project aims to transfer surplus water from the Ken River in Madhya Pradesh to the water-deficit Betwa River in Uttar Pradesh

STATES: Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh.
CURRENT STATUS: Under implementation.
TARGET COMPLETION: 2030, generally stated in government documents as March 2030.
ESTIMATED COST: ₹44,605 crore.
PLANNED BENEFITS: Irrigation, drinking-water supply and hydropower generation in parts of Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh

This is currently the only National Perspective Plan river-linking project for which the Union government has publicly stated a firm completion target.



India's river-interlinking programme: The journey so far...

India's river-interlinking programme has 30 proposed links. Its implementation depends on State consent, land acquisition, rehabilitation, environmental and wildlife clearances, and water-sharing agreements; only the Ken-Betwa Link Project is under implementation with a stated completion target of March 2030.

1972 The idea of transferring water between river basins was formally examined through national-level water-resource planning.

1980 The Union government formulated the National Perspective Plan (NPP) for inter-basin water transfer, covering Himalayan and Peninsular river links.

1982 The National Water Development Agency (NWDA) was established to study and develop the proposed links. It is an autonomous society established in July 1982 under the Ministry of Jal Shakti, Government of India

1980s-2000s NWDA prepared Pre-Feasibility Reports and Feasibility Reports for proposed links. The programme expanded to 30 identified projects: 16 Peninsular and 14 Himalayan.

2002 The Supreme Court directed the government to pursue the interlinking programme and established monitoring arrangements.

2012 The Supreme Court reiterated the need for a time-bound mechanism and institutional structure to examine the projects.

2014 The government constituted the Special Committee on Inter-Linking of Rivers.

2015 A Task Force for Inter-Linking of Rivers was constituted to help accelerate studies, consultations and implementation.

2021 Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh signed an agreement for the Ken-Betwa Link Project. December 2021, The Union Cabinet approved implementation of Ken-Betwa at an estimated cost of ₹44,605 crore, including ₹39,317 crore in central support.

2022 Works on Ken-Betwa-including preparatory works and the Daudhan Dam component-started progressively.

2026 Feasibility Reports completed for 26 of 30 links and Detailed Project Reports for 13 links. Ken-Betwa remained the only priority link in the implementation stage. The primary objective is to tackle chronic water scarcity and mitigate droughts in the socio-economically marginalised Bundelkhand region, which spans across both states. The work on Ken-Betwa is likely to be completed by 2030.

“QUIET DIPLOMACY IS FAR MORE EFFECTIVE
THAN PUBLIC POSTURING”
— ATAL BIHARI VAJPAYEE

WEEKLY MOON SIGN FORECAST
30 AUGUST - 5 SEPTEMBER

When Quiet Reflection Turns
into Practical Action

Dr Shanker Adawal
Astrologer, Author & Researcher

This forecast is based on your Moon Sign (Janma Rashi), which often reflects day-to-day emotional and instinctive patterns more closely than general Sun-sign readings.

Moon Watch

The Moon's quiet message for the week ahead. The waning Moon begins reflectively, gathers courage in Aries and settles into Taurus. The message is simple: understand first, act with purpose, then give worthwhile decisions enough time to become steady.

Weekly Overview

The week opens with the Moon in Pisces, favouring reflection, intuition and a quieter pace. Aries then brings movement, initiative and more direct decisions. From Thursday, Taurus steadies the mood and turns attention towards practical matters. Friday adds a gentle note of devotion and simplicity, while late Saturday brings a livelier, more communicative tone.



Aries (Mesh): The opening days may feel slower than expected, and some unfinished thoughts need attention before you move ahead. Once the Moon enters Aries, confidence returns and personal matters begin moving more quickly. Taurus later shifts attention towards money, family and practical priorities. By Saturday, conversations become easier. Avoid spending energy proving a point that is already clear to you.



Taurus (Vrishabh): Friends, professional contacts or longer-term plans may bring useful support early in the week. The Aries phase then encourages you to step back, rest or work quietly behind the scenes. Once the Moon enters Taurus, confidence and emotional steadiness improve noticeably. Personal priorities become easier to sort out. Late Saturday turns attention towards finances and family arrangements that need a practical look.



Gemini (Mithun): Professional responsibilities may be active at the start, and your judgement could be noticed more than usual. Aries then brings friends, networks and future plans into the picture, helping a stalled idea regain momentum. Taurus later asks you to slow down and clear some mental clutter. By Saturday evening, energy begins returning. A little distance may help you recognise which commitments still deserve your time.



Cancer (Karka): Learning, travel or a broader life question may occupy your thoughts during the opening days. Aries then puts career and responsibilities back in focus, making direct action necessary in one area. Taurus brings support through friends, colleagues or familiar networks. The weekend becomes quieter internally. You need not solve everything immediately; sometimes knowing what can wait is also useful progress.



Leo (Simha): Shared finances, trust or an emotionally sensitive matter may need calm handling early in the week. Aries lifts the mood and encourages learning, travel or a wider perspective. Taurus then brings career matters and public responsibilities into sharper focus. Friday may feel especially grounded and purposeful. By Saturday, support from friends or professional contacts can make one practical matter easier than expected.



Virgo (Kanya): Relationships and one-to-one discussions need attention at the beginning of the week, especially where expectations have remained unspoken. Aries may then bring shared responsibilities, finances or trust issues into focus. Taurus broadens perspective and supports learning or future planning. Late Saturday turns attention towards career matters. A straightforward conversation earlier in the week may save unnecessary confusion later.



Libra (Tula): Work routines, health priorities or unfinished tasks may need better organisation early on. Aries then places relationships and cooperation at the centre, making balanced communication important. Taurus later deepens the mood and may bring financial commitments or emotional expectations into view. The weekend opens a wider perspective. Do not let one uncomfortable conversation convince you that the larger picture has changed.



Scorpio (Vrishchik): Creative interests, children or personal plans may bring welcome energy during the opening days. Aries then turns attention towards work, routines and health, where small improvements can be useful. Taurus highlights relationships and close partnerships later in the week. Friday feels steadier and more cooperative. By Saturday, shared matters may need a little more honesty. Listen carefully before assuming you know the other person's intention.



Sagittarius (Dhanu): Home, family or personal arrangements may keep you occupied early in the week. Aries then brings more confidence, creativity and social energy, making the middle phase feel lighter. Taurus restores discipline and turns attention towards work, health and everyday responsibilities. Late Saturday puts relationships back in focus. Keep the weekend flexible; another person's plan may not move at the same pace as yours.



Capricorn (Makar): Communication, paperwork or short journeys may make the opening days busy. Aries then shifts attention towards home and family, where one practical decision may need to be taken. Taurus later brings a lighter mood through creativity, children or personal interests. Friday supports simple pleasures rather than unnecessary pressure.



Aquarius (Kumbh): Financial priorities, family responsibilities or questions of personal value may need sensible handling at the start. Aries then increases communication, movement and useful exchanges of information. Taurus brings attention towards home, comfort and emotional security. Friday may encourage you to simplify rather than expand. Late Saturday feels lighter and more expressive, helping creativity or social plans return without much effort.



Pisces (Meen): With the Moon beginning the week in Pisces, personal feelings and priorities become stronger and easier to recognise. Use the opening phase to understand what you genuinely want before acting. Aries then turns attention towards money and practical arrangements.

Soft power: India's opportunity to shape the global imagination



CHAITANYA K PRASAD

Power has traditionally been understood in fairly straightforward terms, economic strength, military capability, technological advancement and political influence. But in today's interconnected world, there is another form of power that is becoming equally important: the ability of a country to attract, inspire and influence without coercion. That is the power of soft power.

India has always possessed it. What is changing now is the scale of the opportunity before us. In his Independence Day address, Prime Minister Narendra Modi identified soft power as one of the seven Saptadharas that can take India towards greater national strength, alongside manufacturing, agriculture and food processing, technology and innovation, infrastructure, defence, and the green and blue economy. The inclusion of soft power in this framework is significant because it places culture, creativity and global influence within the larger developmental vision of Viksit Bharat.

For India, soft power is not something that needs to be artificially created. It already exists in extraordinary depth. Yoga is today practised across continents. Ayurveda has found growing international interest. Indian cinema and music travel far beyond the country's borders. Indian food has become part of everyday life in cities across the world. Our spiritual traditions, festivals, textiles, classical arts, literature and philosophies have shaped perceptions of India for generations. But possessing cultural richness and converting it into sustained global influence are two different things. That is where India's next opportunity lies.

There is a broader understanding of soft power beyond the traditional ideas of heritage and culture. It connects yoga, Ayurveda and tourism with newer sectors such as VFX, animation, gaming and the creative economy. It also identifies wildlife, national parks, major sporting events and the rapidly growing concert economy as areas through which India can attract the world and showcase its capabilities. This is an important shift. Soft power today is no longer only about how much of a country's past the world admires. It is also about how relevant that country feels in the present.

India has one of the oldest civilisations in the world, but it also has one of the youngest populations. Our global identity, therefore, cannot rest only on ancient temples, classical traditions or historical achievements. It must also include contemporary India, its filmmakers, designers,



musicians, gamers, animators, athletes, entrepreneurs and digital creators. The real power lies in bringing both together.

India should be able to speak to the world through yoga and artificial intelligence, Ayurveda and animation, classical music and gaming, ancient knowledge systems and cutting-edge digital creativity. These are not contradictions. In fact, they are what make India distinctive. The creative economy is particularly important in this context. Countries increasingly shape global perceptions through the stories they tell. Cinema, television, music, gaming and digital content reach people in ways that formal diplomacy often cannot. They enter homes, influence taste, create familiarity and build emotional connections.

A person may know very little about the politics or foreign policy of a country and yet feel deeply connected to it because of its films, food, music or culture. That emotional familiarity matters. When people admire a country's culture, they become curious about the country itself. Curiosity can lead to tourism, education, business engagement and deeper people-to-people ties. In that sense, soft power is not separate from economic development; it can actively contribute to it.

Tourism is perhaps one of the clearest examples. India has extraordinary geographical and cultural diversity, from the Himalayas and the deserts of Rajasthan to wildlife reserves, coastal regions, heritage cities, spiritual centres and the North-East. Yet the potential of these assets as instruments of global influence remains far greater than what we currently realise.

The Prime Minister specifically highlighted wildlife, national parks and tourism as areas through which India can draw global visitors. A tourist who visits India does much more than spend money here. They experience the country personally. They interact with people, encounter its culture and carry those experiences back with them. In that sense, every positive visitor experience becomes a form of informal diplomacy.

International sporting events and the concert economy are becoming the new areas of opportunity. Hosting major global events does not simply generate revenue. It places a country at the centre of global attention. It showcases infrastructure, cities, culture and organizational capability. It



INDIA SHOULD BE ABLE TO SPEAK TO THE WORLD THROUGH YOGA AND AI, AYURVEDA AND ANIMATION, CLASSICAL MUSIC AND GAMING, AND CUTTING-EDGE DIGITAL CREATIVITY. THESE ARE NOT CONTRADICTIONS

also creates memories associated with a country that can last far beyond the event itself. India's improving international sporting presence and its ambitions around major sporting events therefore have a larger significance as well. There is also an economic argument for taking soft power more seriously. Culture today is an industry.

Films generate tourism. Music creates events and digital revenue. Gaming creates valuable intellectual property. Wellness traditions create global markets. Cuisine supports food exports and restaurant businesses. Heritage sustains tourism economies. Sporting events create opportunities across hospitality, transport, advertising and broadcasting. Soft power can therefore create a chain of value: cultural visibility creates curiosity; curiosity creates engagement; engagement creates trust; and trust can eventually create economic and strategic opportunities. But for India to fully realise this potential, one important shift is necessary. We have to move from simply being proud of our culture to becoming better at presenting it to the world. That means investing in creators, institutions and platforms. It means supporting animation, films, gaming, music and design at international standards. It means better preservation and presentation of heritage. It means making tourism seamless, safe and globally competitive. It means strengthening translation so that Indian literature and ideas can travel across languages. It means helping regional stories find global audiences rather than reducing India to a few familiar cultural symbols.

India's greatest strength here may actually be its diversity. There is no single Indian

story. There are thousands of them. Every region offers its own food, music, language, landscape, literature, craft, history and cultural tradition. If these are given global platforms, India does not merely have one source of soft power; it has an almost limitless reservoir of them.

There is, however, one condition. Soft power works only when it is credible. A country cannot build long-term influence through projection alone. What the world sees must ultimately connect with what the country is. The Prime Minister himself linked India's growing international respect with the country's political stability, vibrant democracy, judicial system and constitutional framework. Reputation is strongest when it is backed by reality. That is why soft power should not be viewed as publicity. It is something much deeper. It is the cumulative impression created by a country's culture, institutions, people, achievements and behaviour. For India, this makes soft power an extraordinary force multiplier. Manufacturing can make India competitive. Technology can make India innovative. Defence can make India secure. Economic growth can make India influential. But soft power can make India relatable. It can make people across the world feel that they know India, understand India and want to engage with India.

As India moves towards the goal of Viksit Bharat, this dimension of national growth deserves far greater attention. Becoming a developed country is not only about expanding economic capacity. It is also about expanding the space a country occupies in the imagination of the world.

India already has the stories, traditions, knowledge, landscapes and talent. The next step is to give them the scale, confidence and platforms they deserve. Because in the decades ahead, the countries that shape the world will not only be those that produce the most or possess the most. They will also be the countries that inspire the most.

The author is a Commentator and Writer on Cinema, Branding, Media Management and Geo-Strategic Communication. Inputs provided by Zoya Ahmad and Vaishnavie Srinivasan

— FROM AGENDA COVER —

United Rivers...

They also highlight the enormous investments, institutional capacity, long-term operational arrangements, and significant environmental and social trade-offs required to develop and sustain such large-scale inter-basin water transfer systems.

There is no close global equivalent to what Brahmaputra to Cauvery and Godavari implies. A system potentially connecting a huge transboundary Himalayan river with distant peninsular basins across a federal country. The absence of such a precedent does not, by itself, settle the question of whether such a system can be developed. It does, however, mean that India would be attempting something for which there is no established global blueprint to simply replicate.

Climate change makes the question more urgent. Historical rainfall and river-flow patterns may no longer provide a reliable guide to future conditions. Changing monsoon intensity and timing, extreme rainfall, prolonged dry spells and other hydrological shifts could alter the reliability of projected surpluses.

Before the Brahmaputra is declared a source of national water security, India should therefore publicly demonstrate the calculations. What is the dependable surplus? How much is required downstream? What storage is required? What are the energy and financial costs? How will the system perform during water scarcity? What alternatives have been examined? Which states will be affected? And what are the implications for Bangladesh?

Most importantly, the public should be able to see and scrutinise these calculations. Ultimately, the question is not whether India should ever move water between

river basins. Water already moves between basins through natural hydrological connections. The more important questions are whether a proposed transfer is necessary, how much water can actually be transferred without compromising existing downstream needs, and what its ecological, social, economic and political consequences would be. Any such proposal must also be judged against the enormous investments, institutional capacity, long-term operational arrangements, and environmental and social trade-offs that large-scale inter-basin water transfers entail.

The Brahmaputra makes this debate especially consequential. It is a river, a floodplain, a sediment conveyor and the basis of millions of livelihoods, with its waters continuing downstream as the Jamuna.

So when India hears the phrase Brahmaputra to Cauvery and Godavari, the first response should be to ask what exactly is being proposed, what problem it is intended to solve, and whether its hydrological, ecological, social, economic and institutional implications have been adequately examined. That means asking some very basic questions.

How much water? From where? In which months? What qualifies as surplus, and according to whose calculations? Where would it be stored? How would it be transferred? At what cost? Who would benefit? Who would bear the risks? And what happens when the river does not behave as planners expect?

India needs water security. But before India attempts to connect its great rivers, it must first demonstrate that the water can, needs to and should be moved.

A proposition is not yet a project. A flood is not necessarily a surplus. And a river is not a pipeline.

BY ANIL BHAT

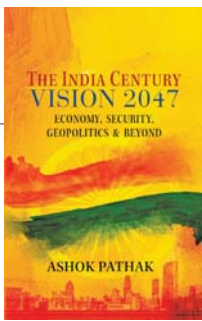
This book has been sponsored by Bharat Global Industries Forum (BGIF), a premier national think-and-action platform uniting India's top corporations, policy-makers, and global investors to support the concept and accomplishment of Atmanirbhar Bharat (self-reliant India) and helping this nation to grow into a manufacturing hub with a \$30 trillion economy.

The central theme of the book aims at Vision 2047 going beyond headline numbers of GDP (\$30 Trillion) and GDP per capita (\$18000/-) to the overall well being of ordinary citizens. NITI Ayog's ambitions of creating an India of 2047 where the citizens are intimately connected to governance, assured best of education, health care, social services and public infrastructure are discussed against the backdrop of past inertia and baggage of organisational slack.

He describes the unsatisfactory state of private sector investment in R&D and the inefficiencies of SMEs. At the same time some early silver linings are also highlighted - like the high percentage of indigenous defense systems, India's achievements in space, quantum computing and semi-conductors. The unique feature of author's style is his dependence on hard data without diluting the readability for an ordinary student of the subject.

In a broader sense linking 'Viksit Bharat 2047 Vision' to the three major pillars- economy, national security and geopolitics makes the road to 2047 much more distinct and meaningful. Students of macro and political economy will find the chapter on

India: Aiming to be a multi-trillion economy



Author: Ashok Pathak
Publisher: Pentagon Press
Pages: 124 pages
Price: ₹695

economy very lucid and informative as it links the current milieu with the ancient - Kautilya's Arthashastra; and western economic philosophy of Adam Smith.

The book highlights the Indian philosophy of oneness of humanity. Ekamavadvad, or Integral Humanism, is a socio-economic and political philosophy propounded by Pandit Deendayal Upadhyaya in 1964. It presents an integrated approach to human existence, balancing individual needs with societal welfare.

The author has emphasised that national security should not be looked at only in terms of military strength, but holistically and that defense expenditure should be viewed as economic investment. The issues of indigenisation of defense production have been very lucidly explained with the help of case study on HF 24 and LCA Tejas and the overall strength of Indian Air Force.

On geopolitics the book has exposed to the global challenges arising out of national ambitions based on power, assumed roles in global affairs and theol-

ogy driven undercurrents that trigger conflicts. India's strength, challenges, compulsions and their impact on achieving the vision 2047 have been neatly explained. The author has done well to bring out the role of soft power in achieving geopolitical goals.

Since the Bharatiya Janata Party came to power under Prime Minister Narendra Modi in 2014, India has witnessed a profound shift toward mainstreaming Hindu civilizational identity and state-backed cultural nationalism. This movement views its current trajectory as a long-overdue decolonization and public reclamation of indigenous heritage, contrasting sharply with decades of post-independence "secular" governance. This post-2014 era in India is at last emerging as a vital correction to centuries of cultural and political marginalization, during which foreign Islamic rulers and British colonial powers suppressed native Hindu identity, history, and traditions. This political shift in 2014 of democratic reassertion of India's indigenous civilizational ethos was waiting to happen.

Massive development of roads, railways, and ports; growth in manufacturing through production incentives; expansion of the tech and renewable energy sectors and strong domestic consumption of the rising middle class are indications of the strong possibility of the aims stated. The author served in the Corps of Signals and retired in 2006 as Deputy Director General of Army Signals Intelligence.

Col Anil Bhat, VSM (Retd) is a strategic affairs analyst and former Defence Ministry and Indian Army spokesperson.

“EAT FOOD. NOT TOO MUCH.
MOSTLY PLANT”
— MICHAEL POLLAN

Makkhan se prasad: Krishna's story through food



ANIL
RAJPUT

At midnight in Mathura, temple bells ring, conches sound and chants rise through the streets as devotees mark the birth of Krishna. In homes far beyond Braj, the same story is retold through food. White butter recalls the mischievous child of Gokul. Poha rem embers the humility of Sudama's offering. Sugar-palm fruit is turned into Taler Bora in Bengal, while rice flour becomes crisp seedai in Tamil Nadu. Across India, ingredients, techniques and memories transform devotion into taste. Janmashtami is therefore not simply a festival with a special menu. It is a journey from fasting to worship, from bhog to prasad, and finally from an offering made to Krishna to food shared among families and communities.

Celebrated in 2026 on Friday, 4 September, Janmashtami falls on the Ashtami, or eighth lunar day, of Krishna Paksha associated with Krishna's birth. The story begins in Mathura, where Devaki and Vasudeva were imprisoned by the tyrant Kansa. Tradition recounts that after Krishna was born, Vasudeva carried the infant across the Yamuna to Gokul, where he was raised by Nanda and Yashoda. His childhood unfolded in the pastoral world of Braj, among cows, milk, curd and butter, before his life later carried him from Mathura towards Dwarka. That geography helps explain why food occupies such an intimate place in Janmashtami. Krishna is remembered not only through sacred narrative, but through the foods associated with his childhood, friendship, pastoral surroundings and the regions that made his story their own. The 4 September date is also the one listed for the 2026 celebrations in Mathura.

The observance itself is shaped by restraint before abundance. Many devotees fast through the day, but the fast is not merely a dietary exercise or a list of prohibited ingredients. It is a spiritual discipline intended to reduce everyday distraction, cultivate self-control and turn attention towards Krishna. Practices differ between regions and traditions. Some devotees take fruit, milk, nuts or foods prepared from permitted fasting ingredients, while others observe a stricter fast until the midnight worship. For many, purity in preparation is as important as abstinence itself. What unites these practices is the idea that restraint prepares the mind for devotion. The day gradually moves towards Nishita, the sacred midnight hour, when Krishna's birth is celebrated with prayer, singing, abhisheka and the offering of food.

That offering also explains the difference between food and prasad. A preparation may begin in the kitchen as ordinary food, but once it is prepared with care, placed before the deity as bhog and offered in devotion, it is received back as prasad. The transformation is not one of ingredients but of meaning. Food that might otherwise satisfy hunger becomes something shared as grace. This movement from fasting to mid-

night worship, from bhog to prasad and from prasad to communal sharing gives Janmashtami food its spiritual structure. It also explains why the festival cannot be understood simply as a directory of festive dishes.

At the centre of this tradition stands Makhana Mishri, perhaps the most direct edible memory of Krishna's childhood. Fresh white butter is mixed with crystals of mishri and offered to Bal Krishna, recalling the affectionate image of Makhana Chor, the child who stole butter from the homes of Braj. Traditionally, curd is churned until the butter separates, then the butter is washed, collected and paired with sugar candy. Its simplicity is precisely its strength. Few ingredients could evoke Krishna's pastoral world more immediately. Makhana Mishri continues to be closely associated with Krishna devotion in Mathura and Vrindavan.

From the butter pots of Gokul, the story moves naturally to Mathura Peda, one of the defining foods of Krishna's birthplace. Milk is slowly reduced to khoaya, roasted until it develops a deeper caramelised flavour, then mixed with sugar and cardamom before being shaped into small rounds. During Janmashtami, peda is prepared in large quantities in Mathura and is also offered in temples and homes. Here, the sweet does more than satisfy festive appetite. It turns the sacred geography of Mathura into something that can be carried home, shared and remembered.

North Indian Janmashtami traditions also include Dhaniya Panjiri, particularly in households where grains are avoided during the fast. Coriander seeds or powder are gently roasted until aromatic, then combined with ghee, powdered sugar, coconut, makhana and nuts. The unusual use of coriander gives it a flavour distinct from ordinary wheat-based panjiri. Makhana Paag offers another characteristic preparation. Fox nuts are roasted in ghee until crisp and then bound with sugar, coconut, cardamom and sometimes nuts or raisins. Both are prepared as offerings and

reinforcing the festival's association with ingredients suited to fasting traditions while still producing texture and richness. The idea of abundance reaches its grandest expression in Chhappan Bhog, the ceremonial offering of fifty-six foods associated with Krishna worship and often presented during Janmashtami celebrations. Popular tradition links the number fifty-six to the belief that Krishna normally ate eight meals a day and went without them during the seven days he held up Govardhan Hill, leading devotees to offer eight times seven dishes in gratitude. The exact composition varies widely, and that variation is part of its character. Sweets, dairy preparations, fruits, savouries and grains may all appear depending on temple and regional custom. Chhappan Bhog is therefore less a fixed recipe than a statement of devotion expressed through abundance.

As Krishna's story travels west, Janmashtami food begins to take on distinctly regional forms. In Maharashtra, Gopalkala, also known as Dahikala, is especially associated with the celebrations surrounding Dahi Handi. Poha is mixed with curd and ingredients such as cucumber, grated coconut, roasted peanuts, coriander and green chilli. Some versions add fruit or soaked pulses. Cool, savoury and meant for sharing, it recalls Krishna eating with his cowherd companions and complements the public spectacle of the handi filled with curd or butter. Unlike a formal sweet carefully shaped for presentation, Gopalkala is mixed together and shared communally, which is part of its charm. Dahi Handi itself remains one of Maharashtra's most prominent Janmashtami traditions.

In some Gujarati households, where devotion to Krishna is strongly connected with Dwarka, Janmashtami menus absorb regional favourites while retaining the larger themes of dairy, fasting and offering. Alongside them, Thattai is made by flattening a seasoned rice-flour dough into thin discs before frying, often with chilli, sesame, asafoetida and soaked chana dal. Thenkuzhal uses rice and urad flours pressed through a mould into crisp coils, while Nei Appam provides a softer sweet contrast

through a batter of rice, jaggery, coconut and cardamom cooked with ghee until browned outside and tender within. These preparations are valued not only for their taste but for the skill involved in shaping them. In many homes, children learn by watching elders roll seedai, press thenkuzhal or turn appam, allowing ritual knowledge to pass almost invisibly from one generation to another. Flattened rice creates another bridge between regions and stories. Vella Aval, made by softening poha and combining it with jaggery, coconut and cardamom, recalls the beloved episode of Sudama bringing Krishna a humble gift of flattened rice. The story gives poha a meaning beyond its ingredients. It becomes a reminder that devotion is measured not by extravagance but by sincerity. In some southern households, the same ingredient appears as Aval Puttu, where poha is combined with jaggery and coconut, or Aval Payasam, in which it is gently cooked with milk or coconut milk into a softer sweet. The simplicity of aval sits beautifully beside the grandeur of Chhappan Bhog, showing that Krishna can be honoured through abundance or through a modest offering given with affection.

Beverages carry the same devotional symbolism. Panchamrit, made from milk, curd, ghee, honey and sugar or mishri, is central to many abhisheka rituals and is later received as prasad. Sweetened milk scented with saffron or cardamom may also be offered, while lassi and chaas reflect the dairy culture of Braj and western India. In different homes and temples, these drinks vary in sweetness and seasoning, but their common ingredients return again to the cow, milk and curd that surround the remembered world of Krishna's childhood. Even the act of drinking can therefore reinforce the festival's central imagery.

Taken together, these foods reveal two overlapping layers of Janmashtami. At the devotional core are the broad themes of fasting, milk, butter, curd, bhog, prasad and the midnight celebration of Krishna's birth. Around that centre sit regional expressions shaped by local crops, techniques and inherited household practice. Maharashtra gives Janmashtami Gopalkala, Bengal gives it Taler Bora, Gujarat adapts familiar regional foods for the occasion, and Tamil Nadu's Krishna Jayanthi is marked by seedai, thattai and other carefully shaped offerings. The festival does not become less unified because its food changes from region to region. Its unity lies in the intention behind the offering.

That may be Janmashtami's most enduring lesson about food. Heritage survives through practice: in the butter churned at dawn, in the peda patiently reduced over heat, in the seedai rolled between fingers, in the poha mixed with jaggery, and in the plate first placed before Krishna before anyone else eats. Tradition passes from one generation to another not only through texts or ceremonies, but through repeated gestures in the kitchen. This Janmashtami, families can preserve that inheritance by preparing at least one traditional dish with younger members, explaining why it is made, whom it is offered to and what story it carries. When the next generation learns both the recipe and the reason behind it, food becomes more than memory. It becomes a living tradition, renewed every time bhog becomes prasad and prasad is shared.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

A feast fit for the butter thief The flavours of Janmashtami



TEAM AGENDA

Janmashtami, the birth anniversary of Lord Krishna, falls this year on September 4 (September 5 for Vaishnava and ISKCON traditions), marking the eighth avatar of Vishnu's descent to earth to end the tyranny of King Kansa and restore dharma. Krishna's midnight birth in a Mathura prison cell to Devaki and Vasudeva remains one of Hinduism's most cherished stories - the child who would grow

up to deliver the Bhagavad Gita, teaching karma and devotion to a fractious world. For devotees, the day is less ritual than homecoming: Bal Gopal, the mischievous butter-stealing infant, is welcomed back into every household.

Celebrations open with a day-long vrat, broken only after the midnight Nishita Puja, when Bal Gopal's idol is bathed in panchamrit, dressed in new clothes and cradled in a jhula.



From midnight prayers to Chappan Bhog, Janmashtami brings devotion to the table, blending regional flavours, cherished rituals and Krishna's playful spirit.

Temples in Mathura and Vrindavan hold jagran through the night; Maharashtra and Gujarat erupt the next morning into Dahi Handi, human pyramids scaling for curd pots slung high above the street to re-enact Krishna's boyhood butter raids. Further south, Gokulashtami unfolds more quietly, with tiny rice-flour footprints tracing Krishna's path from doorstep to altar.

But it is food that truly carries the festival's spirit. Its centre-piece is Chappan Bhog - 56 dishes recalling the seven days Krishna went without food while holding aloft Govardhan Hill, after which the Brajwasis cooked him eight meals a day to make up the loss. Makhana-mishri, butter whipped with sugar crystals, remains the essential offering, alongside panjiri, kheer, peda, rabri and the honeycombed disc of ghehar across the north. Once presented to Bal Gopal, the spread is distributed as prasad, turning neighbourhoods into one shared table. Fasting devotees turn instead to sabudana khichdi, kuttu and singhara flour,



and fresh fruit, avoiding grain and salt until the midnight vrat breaks.

Regional larders reshape the feast entirely. Tamil Nadu and Karnataka offer crunchy seedai and murukku alongside sweet aval; Maharashtra and Gujarat pair Dahi Handi's chaos with shrikhand, poha and panchamrut-laced ladoos; Bengal answers with delicate sandesh and rasgulla; Bihar fries up vegetable taura fritters and simmers makhane ki kheer; and Puri's Jagannath temple sends out khichdi, dahi pakhal and khaja as mahaprasad. Across every kitchen, though, one instinct holds constant: Krishna is fed first, and only then does the household eat - devotion, quite literally, served on a plate.



Sufiana: Where culinary excellence meets melody



GYANESHWAR DAYAL

In a city brimming with dining options, Sufiana by Cherish stands out as a sanctuary for those seeking more than just a meal-it promises a complete sensory experience that lingers long after the last bite. Located within The Anand Villas in Ashok Vihar, this elegant 108-cover restaurant has masterfully crafted a space where traditional charm seamlessly intertwines with contemporary sophistication. ● The Culinary Journey Executive Chef Bharat V. Sharma's menu is a testament to thoughtful curation, striking an impressive balance between beloved classics and innovative creations. The dahi makhani arrives velvety and rich, its depth of flavor earned through meticulous preparation, while the butter chicken melts on the palate with understated elegance.

However, it's the experimental offerings-like the delicate tuls aur badam ke kofte and earthy mushroom rarha that truly showcase the kitchen's creative ambition. The diverse menu, spanning north Indian staples, artisanal steaks, aromatic Thai curries, and vibrant Mexican plates, ensures every palate finds its perfect match. Each dish reflects a commitment to quality ingredients and technique that never feels pretentious. ● Ambiance and Design The restaurant's spacious layout immediately puts you at ease. Warm lighting, thoughtfully appointed interiors, and comfortable seating create an inviting sanctuary where conversations flow effortlessly. Whether you're



celebrating a milestone or enjoying a casual evening, the relaxed yet refined atmosphere strikes that rare balance between approachable and elevated. ● The Soul of Hospitality What truly sets Sufiana apart is its genuine hospitality. Drawing on two decades of excellence with Cherish's hospitality legacy, the staff anticipates needs with quiet efficiency. Their warmth isn't performative-it feels authentic and personal, transforming service into genuine care. ● Live Music Magic The evening is elevated further by live music that complements rather than overwhelms the dining experience. The carefully

curated performances create an enchanting backdrop, adding emotional depth to your meal without interrupting intimate conversations. ● The Verdict Sufiana understands that unforgettable moments aren't about complexity; they're about the convergence of exceptional food, genuine service, and welcoming ambiance. This is where memories are made with people who matter, over dishes that delight, in a space that feels like home. Sufiana doesn't just serve dinner; it orchestrates experiences.



Taking responsibility as children of the earth

AMMA (SRI MATA AMRITANANDAMAYI DEVI)

Many years ago, when Amma was travelling through Tamil Nadu, she was giving rice, clothing, and other relief to those who had lost their homes and families to the 2004 Indian Ocean Tsunami. A very old man came up to her, and the moment the items reached his hands, the poor man broke down and wept aloud.

“O God, to whom am I to give this now? Who is left to me to cook a meal from it?” And then his tears completely engulfed him. The tsunami had carried away his house and all his dear ones. That face, and that sorrow, do not fade from Amma’s heart. For all the brilliant scientists the world over, no one could foretell the tsunami was coming; and even had it been foretold, nothing could have stopped it. Our home, our belongings, our parents, our children - any of it can be lost in the blink of an eye. We have seen the mightiest structures that human hands have raised collapse like a house of cards before nature’s fury.

This is happening because people blinded by arrogance and wealth have lost their sense of dharma; they are plundering nature for their own selfish gain. They have no regard for the destructive impact this will have on others. The harmony of nature is broken, and this is the root cause of most of the world’s disasters. Within our own lifetime we can see how greatly the seasons have changed. Because of our carelessness in guarding the soil, we have watched the great cities of Kerala go under in floods. Across the world, many creatures and birds once seen everywhere are nowhere to be found. Why is this happening?

In truth, we ourselves invite these calamities. So long as we are unwilling to cherish nature as we would a mother, such destruction will keep returning, like blows struck in the dark. Each disaster is an alarm bell, calling us to wake from a guilty sleep. And for



Amma offering prayers after mass funeral rites for those lost to the 2004 Tsunami in the area surrounding Amritapuri Ashram

all our cruelty, Mother Nature goes on loving us, even though today she lies ill. She who once gave us everything, like the wish-granting cow Kamadhenu, has become a starved and milkless cow.

Our numbers on this Earth continue to grow, and growth itself is not the sin - the question is how we take. There are three types of people: those of prakriti, who take only their own share and think no further; those of vikriti, who take their share and then snatch what belongs to others; and those of samskriti who take only as little as they need and give away as much as they can.

Look at Mother Nature Herself - she takes only to give back a hundredfold. If humanity is to survive, let us evolve as samskriti: learning to take only what we need to live peacefully and then share the surplus with those who are suffering. As the population increases, it does not need to come at the cost of ruin for all.

This Earth is the dwelling place of countless living things. It is a home that belongs equally to all, from the smallest of cells to the massive blue whale to humankind as its guardians. Under our vast sky of stars, let us delay

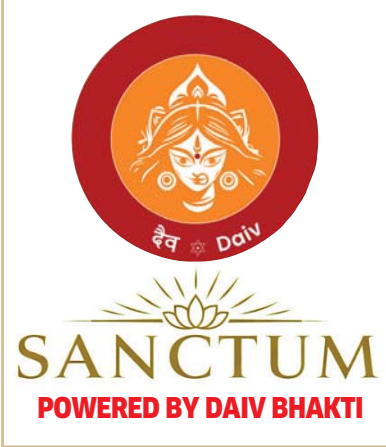
no longer to take responsibility for our global family.

The rhythm of Nature depends upon how humanity proceeds. We see this in the many natural disasters we are facing and the sorrow this causes to those left behind. But after our grief, even if we are completely surrounded by darkness, we must keep the light within aflame and use it to show the path to others as well. Even if we cannot completely remove their suffering, despair lessens when it is shared with others.

Regardless of the destruction we have witnessed, we do not need to remain bound by our mistakes. Look forward with strength and hope. Each one of us can do our own small part to help restore the natural world. We should perform these actions with utmost faith and alertness, and yet with a sense of detachment. Don’t be attached to the fruits of your actions. That is in Mother Nature’s hands.

So let us move forward, one step at a time. We are children of the Earth and, therefore, must be grateful for and take care of everything She gives. It is our dharma as humankind, the most intelligent of beings, to care for all others, both sentient and non-sentient. When beauty, harmony, and love blossom in our hearts, a new age will dawn.

(Sri Mata Amritanandamayi Devi, known simply as Amma, is a spiritual master and humanitarian who has given her darshan in the form of a motherly embrace to more than 4 crore people. Listening to the cries of the suffering, Amma leads the Mata Amritanandamayi Math, an NGO that reaches across more than 50 countries, working in the areas of healthcare, disaster relief, education, gender equality, and environmental restoration)



A Culture Based on Inner Science

SADHGURU

Right from ancient times, any number of visitors have visited India, and so did the great American writer and thinker Mark Twain. After his short visit, he said, “Anything that can ever be done either by man or God has been done in this land.”

Most Indians are not aware of the depth of mysticism and spiritual process that has happened and still continues to happen in India. This land has always been known as the spiritual capital of the world, simply because no other culture has looked at the inner sciences with as much depth and understanding as this culture has.

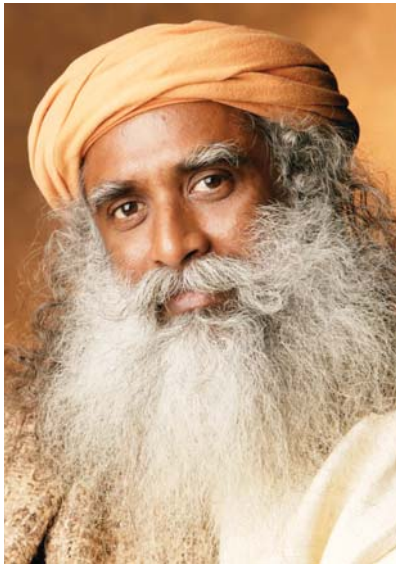
But in the last hundred years, because of a very upstart-ish attitude towards life, we have dropped many things. Because of political and other kinds of dominance, we have come to a kind of conclusion that if something comes from the West it becomes science; if it comes from the East it becomes superstition.

Many of the things that your grandmothers would have once told you are today being discovered in top scientific laboratories as “great” discoveries about human nature. Everything that they are saying after billion-dollar research studies, we have already said in our culture, because this is not a culture which has evolved out of compulsions of living. This is a culture which was evolved consciously by sages and saints —seeing how you should sit, how you should stand, and how you should eat. It was designed for what is best for human wellbeing, and there is immense scientific value in it.

Today, particularly in the last few years, a phenomenal amount of research has gone into water and the potential of water. One thing scientists are saying is that water has memory. Like a fluid memory bank, water remembers whatever it comes in touch with. For example, if I take a glass of water in my hand, look at it in a certain way and give it to you, wellbeing will come to you. If I look at it another way and give it to you, you will fall sick tonight.

In this culture, we have always known that water has memory. This is why in traditional homes, people keep a copper vessel which they wash every day, do a pooja for, and only then fill it with water to drink. What you call as teerth is just this. You may have seen how people struggle to get that one drop of teerth from the temple. Even if you are a billionaire, you are still dying for that one drop of water because you want to take in water which has the memory of the Divine.

Today, there are a lot of studies showing how a pregnant woman eats, what kind of people she is with, what she is exposed to has a huge impact on the next generation of people. But over the last few decades, fully pregnant women have been in trains, buses and bars. They



years, a phenomenal amount of research has gone into water and the potential of water. One thing scientists are saying is that water has memory. Like a fluid memory bank, water remembers whatever it comes in touch with. For example, if I take a glass of water in my hand, look at it in a certain way and give it to you, wellbeing will come to you. If I look at it another way and give it to you, you will fall sick tonight.

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Today, there are a lot of studies showing how a pregnant woman eats, what kind of people she is with, what she is exposed to has a huge impact on the next generation of people. But over the last few decades, fully pregnant women have been in trains, buses and bars. They

are drinking and smoking. When asked, “Won’t this have an impact on the baby?” people would say, “No. We studied the blood parameters, nothing happened.” Now, after fifty years of that culture, there are a lot of studies saying that it is actually having an impact for many generations of people.

In India, we have always been conscious about this. There is a whole process from the moment a woman conceives until delivery, and later on for as long as the mother is breastfeeding the child - what she should and should not consume, what kind of people she should meet, where she should go or not go.

Science has done incredible things in the last hundred years, no question. The comfort and convenience that all of us are enjoying today is essentially because of the outcome of the scientific endeavor on the planet. At the same time, the limitation of science has been in trying to achieve everything through physical means - by measuring physical quantities, going by the physical laws.

If only scientists, who have pursued things so far into physical reality, pay a little attention to the most fundamental physicality which is themselves, if they spend an equal amount of time turning inward rather than solely looking through a telescope or a microscope, I think something phenomenal could come out of it.

There is an inner strength in Indian culture that stems from a whole science and technology of inner wellbeing - right now the whole world is crying for it. They have outer technology with which they have done wonderful things on the outside, but they are struggling inside.

If we fall back on the knowledge bank that we have in this country, it could be the greatest asset — not only for this nation’s wellbeing but for the world’s wellbeing as well.

(Sadhguru is a yogi, mystic and visionary, and a prominent spiritual leader. An author, poet, and internationally-renowned speaker, Sadhguru’s wit and piercing logic provoke and widen our perception of life)

France’s first traditional Hindu Mandir

In Paris, a city renowned for art, beauty, and culture, France’s first newly built traditional BAPS Hindu Mandir is more than a remarkable example of Indian architecture. It stands as a living symbol of the cultural bond between India and France

DR SWAMI GYANANANDDAS

It was 7 July 1970. An aircraft travelling from London to Mumbai made a brief stop at Orly Airport in Paris. For the passengers, it was perhaps nothing more than an ordinary pause in their journey. Little did anyone know that, in that brief halt, an invisible seed of history was being sown.

Among the passengers was Swami Yogi Maharaj, who was returning to India after consecrating a Hindu mandir in London. At that moment, the visionary guru asked two of his disciples, Pramukh Swami Maharaj and Mahant Swami Maharaj, to step off the aircraft. Thus, for the first time, two swamis of the Swaminarayan tradition set foot on French soil, carrying the sacred murti of Swaminarayan Bhagwan in their hands. In accordance with their guru’s wish, they descended from the aircraft, paused in prayer, and then returned.

It was then that Yogi Maharaj expressed a profound resolve: “One day, a beautiful mandir will be built in Paris.” At that moment, there was no land for a mandir, no construction plan, no team of artisans, and no architectural blueprint. There was only the divine resolve of a guru and an unshakable faith in God.

Time moved on. Years turned into decades. Yet today, that sacred resolve has pierced through the veil of time and risen upon French soil as an enduring monument.

This newly built mandir is not merely



a place of worship. It is also a comprehensive center for Indian culture, art, education, and dialogue. Located at Allée Madame de Montespan, 77600 Bussy-Saint-Georges, France, in the eastern suburbs of Paris, the approximately 5,000-square-metre complex has two principal dimensions: a traditional mandir on the upper level and a cultural center, designed in the form of a haveli, beneath it.

5 pinnacles, 10 magnificent domes, 20 monumental pillars adorned with intricate carvings, 120 ornate windows, 49 sculptural character panels, and four elegantly ornamented chhatris reflect the timeless identity of traditional Indian architecture. The sanctum, prayer hall, and assembly hall further reveal the spiritual vision at the heart of the mandir.

Equally remarkable is the global collaboration embodied in its construction. Different varieties of marble sourced from Greece, India, Italy, and Vietnam, along with sandstone from Gwalior in India, have come together to give the mandir a truly international character. In India, skilled artisans painstakingly hand-carved these stones with motifs drawn from the classical traditions of Hindu sculpture. These sculpted stones then travelled to France, carrying with them the artistic heritage of a civilization thousands of years old, where they were harmoniously integrated with modern French engineering.

The grand haveli, built in the ancient Maru-Gurjara architectural style, houses an assembly hall, classrooms, exhibition

spaces, recreational areas, offices, and other multipurpose facilities. The entire complex thus becomes, at once, a place for darshan, a center of learning, a museum of culture, and a space where people can come together.

Significantly, the complex stands within the Esplanade des Religions et des Cultures, an area where places of worship representing different religious traditions stand alongside one another, a beautiful expression of mutual respect and peaceful coexistence.

The forthcoming Festival of Culture, to be held from 2 to 14 September, will be a celebration of this broader vision. A Vedic Mahayagna, a Palkhi procession, a journey on the River Seine, a grand procession passing near some of Paris’s celebrated landmarks, and a variety of cultural programs will offer more than festive occasions; they will create opportunities for cultures to meet and hearts to connect. The consecration and inauguration ceremony by Mahant Swami Maharaj on 6 September will mark a defining moment in this historic journey, with devotees from across the continents gathering to celebrate the mandir’s harmonious blend of traditions.

At a time when the world continues to struggle with divisions, conflicts, and cultural intolerance, a new cultural landmark has emerged on French soil, one that will stand as a living symbol of the unity between two great civilizations: India and France.

The creator and spiritual inspiration behind this mandir, Mahant Swami Maharaj, says: “This mandir has not been built to establish the identity of any one community, but to bring people of diverse identities closer to one another. Its very construction carries an important message: our paths may be different, but the ground of respect and coexistence can be one.”

The dedication of the swamis and volunteers in building this mandir is unforgettable. Of course, some carved the stones, some managed the arrangements, and some prepared the meals, but together, each one placed a piece of their heart into this mandir.

The mandir that now stands in Paris is not merely a symbol of India. It is a symbol of a deeper faith: that when cultures learn to respect one another, boundaries begin to fade, and a new mandir of humanity is built.

(Dr Swami Gyanananddas is a dedicated follower of the Swaminarayan tradition and has earned a PhD from MS University)

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

In life, everyone goes through pleasant and unpleasant times. Just walk ahead with courage. Whenever there is a problem, we either deny it, saying there is no problem, or we sit down to worry about it and make it bigger. Neither helps. A problem doesn’t disappear when you deny it, and it doesn’t get solved by worrying about it.

The first thing is to acknowledge that there is a problem. Then see it as small and solvable. If it concerns people, keep in touch with them rather than avoid them. Talk less and give time a chance. Get together and celebrate. When you put the problem on the back burner for a while, you often find that it gets resolved in time.

When a problem comes, instead of looking at the solution, we often keep looking at how big it can become and imagine the worst outcomes. But every problem that comes in front of you is an opportunity to discover the skill, talent, and ability within you. It is there for you to uncover your true potential.

The second thing is to see life from a broader perspective. Look back at your own life. How much time have you spent worrying? Even though you worried so much, things still happened as they should have. And you realised there was no need to worry.

Looking back at your own life gives you strength. You have overcome many difficulties in the past. This remembrance gives you confidence that you can overcome challenges in the future too. Challenges may come in new forms, but challenges have always been there.

Have confidence in your own ability and in your own fortune. Know that only the best happens to you. Life moves in the direction of the best. On the way, you may find rough roads, but they are taking you towards something better.

If these two things don’t work, there is a third option: invoke the valour in you. Tell yourself, “Come what may, I will handle it. I have the power to overcome this.” Know that you are never given a problem that you cannot handle. When you invoke this energy, this spirit to counter a challenge, fear vanishes.

Trying times bring out the best in you. Rewarding times give you the best of the world. Life is a combination of both.

Life is often caught in storms. In those moments, all your spiritual practices and philosophical ideas may seem to fall apart. But remember something very important: you aren’t alone in those trying hours. No storm can last forever. Waves come, and for no reason, turmoil is created in the mind. The storms rise in you, but they never stay forever. They subside after a while.

When the mind cools down and you experience that inner softness and delicate aspect of yourself, a big relief dawns in you. Peace and love are significant aspects of your true nature.

If the ocean thinks, “I am blue and nice only when there is no storm,” it is under the influence of a wrong idea. Even when the storms are there, deep inside, the



ocean is still calm.

Every storm that has come into your life has widened your horizon and deepened your awareness. It has destroyed some smallness inside you. A storm comes into your life, whether you like it or not, and pulls you out of your likes and dislikes, your cravings and aversions.

When there is chaos, and you are surrounded by problems, you need calmness the most. When everything around is peaceful, being peaceful is easy. But when everything is falling apart, remaining peaceful has real value.

Uncertainty can produce fear and anxiety, but it can also bring enthusiasm, joy, and a sense of thrill. When you know you are on a roller-coaster ride, uncertainty itself can become part of the experience. The uncertainty may remain, but your relationship with it changes.

There are four ways to overcome a tough situation. One is to have faith that this tough situation too will pass. Everything changes, and chaotic situations also change. The second is your own experience. Just as you have had the energy, courage, and strength to handle problems in the past, you have them for the future too.

The third is to share and serve others. If you always think about yourself, your problem becomes insurmountable. When you open up and see what is happening in the world, you realise that you aren’t the only one dealing with problems. The fourth is faith in a greater power. What you cannot do by your efforts, you can do by your prayers. You aren’t alone in your trials and tribulations. There is a higher power with you. Have faith in that.

Wisdom from past experiences, spiritual practices, valour, and faith help you sail through the rough patches of life. Problems and challenges are there in everyone’s life. Wisdom and Devotion give us the strength to overcome these easily. During hard times, take special care of your overall well-being. Keep the body active. Go for walks; practise Pranayamas, Sudarshan Kriya and meditation. These practices give you enormous prana, or life energy, and strengthen the mind and body, helping you overcome difficult situations. And don’t skip prayer-genuine, heartfelt prayer.

There will always be some flaw in worldly activities. Don’t overthink or try to find perfection in them. When we go deeper on the spiritual path and in meditation, we learn to rise above the challenges.

Having this, you can move ahead in life with confidence. That is why it is said

in Sanskrit: “Charaiveti! Charaiveti! Charaiveti!”-Keep moving. Keep moving. Keep moving!

In 2016, we organised the World Culture Festival on the banks of the Yamuna. Why did we choose the Yamuna? In 2010, through the ‘Meri Dilli Meri Yamuna’ campaign, thousands of our volunteers had come together to clean Delhi. We removed nearly 700 tonnes of waste-jerkins, slippers and all kinds of rubbish-from the Yamuna. Seeing the state of the river, I thought that if people from all over the world came to its banks for the World Culture Festival, perhaps the attention of the authorities would turn towards cleaning and restoring it.

We obtained the required permissions from all the concerned authorities. And then we created something extraordinary: a seven-acre floating stage, with 36,602 artists and people from 155 countries. Hundreds of dignitaries, heads of state, and 2,500 religious and spiritual leaders came from across the world. Representatives of the Pope, Dharmacharyas, the Grand Mufti of Syria, leaders from Egypt, the US, Cuba, Russia, Ukraine, ministers, Buddhist monks from the Far East-people from different faiths, cultures and nations came together on one platform. Around 3.7 million people attended the three-day celebration.

We took utmost care of the environment. The stage was constructed using metal sheets and pillars, without digging into the ground. When we dismantled it, there was grass still growing beneath the plates. Yet, even before the event began, allegations were made that we had damaged the Yamuna floodplains. The National Green Tribunal ordered us to deposit 75 crore as environmental compensation, even though the event had not yet begun. There were only two days left and international dignitaries from across the world were arriving. I did not want to pay for something we had not done. I said I was ready to go to jail, but I would stand for the truth. Eventually, with the programme at stake, our people requested that we comply with the order, and we deposited the amount while continuing to contest the allegations.

The matter continued for years. There was a media trial, and the allegation that the World Culture Festival had damaged the Yamuna was repeated again and again. But we did not lose heart. We stood by the truth with patience.

Today, after 10 years, the Supreme Court has upheld the truth. It has vindicated our stand. It set aside the NGT judgment and all consequential and interim actions against us, and directed that the 75 crore deposited in compliance with the NGT order be refunded. More importantly, the Court found that the material on record did not establish the necessary causal link between the event and the alleged environmental degradation.

This was a reminder of what I had shared in 2017. Truth will always Triumph; however, before that, lies will have their dance.